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*To my beloved grandfather Hasan Karatepe,*

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## Introduction

Asya Tipi Uretim Tarzi ve ciftlikization

For nearly three centuries, the fortunes of Bardizag's Armenian peasantry were inseparable from the political economy of an empire that alternately depended upon their labor, appropriated surplus, and, in 1915, sought their destruction. This dissertation traces historical arc. It asks how a rural Armenian community in the Nicomedia region, first constituted through seventeenth century migration and resettlement, became progressively incorporated into the fiscal, monetary, ecological, and labor regimes of the Ottoman state, and how the same infrastructures of extraction that structured peasant life across the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries were ultimately transformed into instruments of dispossession and mass violence during the Armenian Genocide.

My analytical position emphasizes understanding the structural material conditions of the Armenian peasantry. Central to this inquiry is the Armenian peasant household as a unit of analysis: to what extent were peasants dependent on the soil, and to what degree were they formally free to use or abandon it? Were agricultural yields sufficient to sustain rural livelihoods, or were tax obligations and labor demands prohibitive? This study further explores peasant mobility within the Bardizag region and interrogates whether "peasantry" should be treated as a fixed social category or as a historically contingent and changing social formation. It considers the differentiation of peasant types and traces how, particularly in the nineteenth century, many peasants supplemented subsistence farming with piecework and wage labor in response to shifting economic conditions. Through this lens, the dissertation situates Armenian peasantry within broader structural

transformations, emphasizing the material and social constraints that shaped rural life over centuries.

The chapters that follow adopt a longue durée perspective, tracing Bardizag's history from the origin of its Armenian settlement in the aftermath of the Celali rebellions, through the community's incorporation into the Ottoman mint's charcoal economy, its nineteenth-century semi-proletarianization under mounting fiscal pressures, and its participation in revolutionary and cooperative movements in the decades before the First World War, to the genocide itself. Such a temporal and analytical scope remains relatively uncommon within Ottoman studies. Longue durée and world-systems approaches were considerably more influential in the 1970s, when structural accounts of capitalism, dependency, and global economic integration occupied a more prominent place within the social sciences. Their subsequent decline alongside the intellectual ascendancy of neoliberalism and the fragmentation of structural historical analysis contributed to a broader historiographical movement away from large-scale accounts of political economy and toward more localized, discontinuous, and micro-historical approaches. Within Ottoman studies, world-systems perspectives have consequently been applied to rural Anatolia only unevenly, despite the field's longstanding concern with commercialization, dependency, and incorporation into wider markets.

The intervention is still more pronounced within Armenian studies. A historiography long oriented toward urban elites, ecclesiastical institutions, national political organizations, and the Armenian Genocide has often left the rural majority of Ottoman Armenians at the margins of analysis. Where Armenian peasants do appear, they have frequently been treated as social background to histories centered on institutions, political actors, or the genocide itself, rather than as historical agents whose economic practices and political choices shaped the communities

in which they lived. This dissertation instead places the Armenian peasant household at the center of historical inquiry; I treat the household as a site in which the intersecting (Baska bir kelime) pressures of land, taxation, labor, markets, state policy, and political mobilization became materially visible (baska bir yan cumle), while also emphasizing the capacity of peasants to negotiate, evade and contest those pressures.

**Historiographical Debate and Central Intervention**

This dissertation intervenes in the historiography of capitalism in the Ottoman Empire by asking a central question: how were capitalist relations constituted within a small village? Rather than treating capitalism as a process in which "traditional" peasants were gradually transformed into fully proletarianized wage workers, I examine how labor, household reproduction, ecological extraction, violence and imperial power interacted to produce capitalist relations. I argue that the Armenian peasantry of Bardizag experienced a historically specific form of semi-proletarianization: household retained access to land, subsistence production, communal resources, and non-wage labor even as they became increasingly dependent upon markets, wage labor, and imperial demands. Semi-proletarianization was not therefore not an incomplete stage preceding proletarianization, but a durable form of capitalist incorporation.

This argument also challenges the tendency to treat the Ottoman countryside as either outside capitalism or simply peripheral to a capitalist system structured elsewhere. Bardizag was not a pre-capitalist enclave (meaning) gradually penetrated by capitalism. Nor was its incorporation into the world economy simply imposed from the outside. Its incorporation was produced through concrete relations among Armenian households, Ottoman officials, imperial institutions, local intermediaries, merchants, fiscal regime, communal organizations, and

ecological resources. The central intervention of this dissertation is therefore to shift the question from whether capitalism existed in the Ottoman Empire to how capitalist and imperial relations were made through particular forms of labor, household production, violence, fiscal pressure, and ecological extraction**.**

This intervention responds to a historiographical problem identified by Murat Dağlı. Dağlı argues that although Ottoman historiography has expanded in subject matter and empirical depth. Its separation from historical sociology has narrowed its intellectual possibilities (bunu nasil yumusatsam?). His discussion of Halil İnalcık is especially relevant: Marxist scholarship, despite its theoretical limitations, expanded Ottoman history by bringing peasants and laboring classes, money and wages, everyday life, center-periphery relations, and urban-rural connections into historical analysis. Yet subsequent shifts in Ottoman historiography increasingly moved away from large-scale Marxist and structural interpretations toward local actors, negotiation, state-society relations, and institutional reconstruction. As Cem Emrence describes this trajectory, the field moved from modernization narratives, through macro-models, toward post-structural approaches that questioned both modernization and class-centered interpretations.

These developments produced important correctives, but they also created a problem that this dissertation seeks to address: how can the attention to local actors and institutions that characterizes recent Ottoman historiography be connected to larger questions of capitalism, class, and political economy? I do not propose a return to an older structural model. Instead, I reconnect structural analysis to local history by examining how broader processes of accumulation became concrete through the institutions and social relations of Bardizag.

This approach also requires reconsidering the question of periodization. Ottoman historiography has often organized historical change around major political and institutional

ruptures: the distinction between the early modern and modern periods, the Tanzimat reforms, the reign of Abdulhamid II, and the constitutional and CUP periods, among others. These divisions are analytically meaningful. Each period involved distinct political projects, fiscal priorities, institutional arrangements, and economic agendas, and these transformations shaped the conditions under which Armenian peasants lived and worked. Yet they do not necessarily correspond to complete ruptures in the social relations through which labor, property, and resources were organized.

Rather than treating these political transitions as self-contained historical periods, this dissertation follows the transformation of capital–labor relations across them. Its periodization therefore runs from the late eighteenth century into the early twenty-first century not because the period constitutes a single, continuous political or economic regime, but because it makes visible processes of transformation that cannot be fully captured by conventional political periodization. The question is not whether the same form of labor relation persisted unchanged across the Tanzimat, Hamidian, CUP, Republican, and post-Republican periods. It clearly did not. Rather, the question is how relations between labor, capital, property, household reproduction, and the state were reorganized across successive political regimes, and what persisted through those transformations**.**

The transition from one political regime to another could alter the legal status of property, the organization of taxation, the regulation of labor, the scale and form of markets, and the state's relationship to local communities. At the same time, older forms of household production, landholding, communal resource use, and labor could be incorporated into new institutional and economic arrangements rather than simply displaced by them. Political ruptures therefore matter

not because they automatically produced new social relations, but because they reconfigured the terms under which existing relations were reproduced, contested, and transformed.

Bardizag provides an especially productive scale for tracing these transformations. Following a single community across successive political regimes makes it possible to see how changing stae, policies, markets, property relations, ecological pressures, and forms of labor organization interacted over time. It also prevents the analysis from assuming that the emergence of a new political order necessarily meant the disappearance of earlier economic and social practices. The long chronology thus allows the dissertation to distinguish between political rupture and transformation in capital-labor relations, while also asking how the two interacted.

Rifa'at Ali Abou-El-Haj's account of Ottoman state formation provides an important reason to look beyond the Tanzimat when tracing the transformation of state power in Bardizag. In Formation of the Modern State: The Ottoman Empire, Sixteenth to *Eighteenth Centuries*, Abou-El-Haj argues that the centralizing practices institutionalized during the Tanzimat had antecedents reaching at least two centuries into the Ottoman past.[1] The growing sophistication of diplomatic, commercial, and administrative practices, including those recorded in the *mühimme defterleri,* points to an uneven process of centralization already underway in the late seventeenth and eighteenth centuries. The Tanzimat can therefore be understood, in part, as the synthesis of earlier experiments rather than as an absolute rupture in Ottoman state formation. At the same time, Abou-El-Haj emphasizes that this process was neither linear nor uninterrupted; centralization repeatedly encountered setbacks and reversals. For Bardizag, this longer chronology matters because many of the institutions through which the state regulated forests,

[1] Abou-El-Haj, Rifa'at Ali. 2005. *Formation of the Modern State : The Ottoman Empire, Sixteenth to Eighteenth Centuries*. 2nd ed. Syracuse, N.Y.: Syracuse University Press, p.65.

taxation, labor, and provisioning were already taking shape before the nineteenth-century reforms.

Bardizag also provides a way to connect this history of state formation to a broader Marxist debate over the relationship between the state, accumulation, and class relations. As Necati Ege Keklik's synthesis demonstrates, scholars including Halil Berktay, Abou-El-Haj, Baki Tezcan, Fatma Eda Çelik, Çağdaş Sümer, Alp Yücel Kaya, Doğan Çetinkaya, and E. Attila Aytekin have challenged approaches that treat the Ottoman state as an autonomous or self-explanatory institution. Instead, they examine state formation through changing relations of appropriation, class formation, and political struggle. Keklik further emphasizes the need to account for subordinate groups in these transformations, drawing on debates associated with Gramsci, Poulantzas, the German state debate, and Bob Jessop's strategic-relational approach. From this perspective, the state is neither simply an instrument of dominant groups nor an institution standing outside society; it is a historically specific institutionalization of social relations and struggles over the organization and appropriation of surplus

I agree with Önder Eren Akgül's intervention in the historiography of Ottoman capitalism. Akgül challenges to tendency to understand the Ottoman Empire's nineteenth-century incorporation into the world economy through a binary distinction between capitalist cores and supposedly pre-capitalist peripheries. Wallerstein's world-system framework was crucial for demonstrating the unequal terms of Ottoman integration into global capitalism, but it could also position Ottoman institutions, bureaucratic structures, and local actors primarily as intermediaries within a process structured elsewhere. Akgül instead calls attention to the forms of capitalism and capitalist exploitation that developed within the Ottoman Empire itself. I

extend this intervention by asking how those relations were constituted at the level of household reproduction, and X, Y.

This question is particularly important for the historiography of Ottoman labor. As Kristen Alff observes, critiques of Orientalist and neo-Orientalist interpretations have not necessarily displaced the tendency to describe Ottoman forms of labor control and production as "backward", feudal, or pre-capitalist. I share this critique. The persistence of smallholding, household, production, communal resource use, tenancy, and other forms of non-wage labor does not necessarily indicate a social formation outside capitalism. The question is instead how these forms were incorporated into relations of accumulation and how their persistence could itself become a condition of capitalist reproduction.

In his four-volume study, Immanuel Wallerstein argued that capitalism did not originate solely in nineteenth-century Europe but emerged as a world-spanning economic system beginning in the sixteenth century. Tracing the formation of an international division of labor from around 1450, he emphasized the expansion of European states, imperial competition, and the incorporation of peripheral regions into a hierarchical world economy. Scholars including Christopher Chase-Dunn, Giovanni Arrighi, and Beverly Silver extended this framework by examining how interstate competition generated successive hegemonic powers and reproduced the core-periphery structure of the world economy.[2]

Dependency and world-systems theorists such as Wallerstein, Samir Amin, and Arrighi also drew attention to the ways peripheral accumulation could depend upon subsistence sectors that lowered the costs of labor reproduction and facilitated the transfer of surplus. In such settings, wage labor did not necessarily displace household production; wages could supplement rather than replace subsistence. Jairus Banaji's critique of the articulation-of-modes-of-

[2] The Sage Handbook of Marxism., p.467

production framework offers a related but important refinement: forms of labor that appear "pre-capitalist" should not necessarily be treated as evidence of a separate mode of production. Capitalist relations can incorporate, reorganize, and extract surplus from labor that remains formally outside wage relations. This perspective is particularly useful for Bardizag, where household cultivation, seasonal wage labor, migration, and commodity production were not mutually exclusive but became increasingly articulated within wider circuits of accumulation.

Bardizag makes this theoretical problem concrete. Armenian households combined agriculture, artisanal production, forest labor, charcoal production, seasonal wage work, migration, and domestic labor. These were not successive stages in a linear transition from peasant production to proletarianization but overlapping components of household reproduction. Continued access to land and non-wage production did not place Bardizag Armenians outside capitalist relations. Rather, these forms could facilitate their incorporation into commodity production, imperial provisioning, and expanding labor markets. Semi-proletarianization thus describes a durable configuration in which households retained non-wage forms of production while becoming increasingly dependent upon markets and wage income.

The process was also ecological. Charcoal production connected Armenian household labor to the forests of Bardizag and, through the Imperial Mint, to the monetary and fiscal institutions of the Ottoman state. The forest was not simply the setting of economic activity; it was a material condition of accumulation. The production of charcoal reveals how monetary production itself depended upon the organization of rural labor and the appropriation of ecological resources. Labor and nature were therefore not separate dimensions of Bardizag's incorporation: they were mutually constitutive elements of the same extractive process.

The Ottoman state is equally central to this argument. Bardizag's incorporation cannot be explained simply through its position within a world economy. Ottoman institutions organized access to forests, taxation, labor obligations, monetary production, commercial activity. The state was therefore not merely an intermediary between a global capitalist system and a peripheral population. It actively constituted the political conditions under which labor and resources were extracted and incorporated into wider circuits of accumulation. Yet state power was neither fixed nor exercised exclusively from above. Regulations governing charcoal prodution could be revised in response to pressures from below; including peasants petitioning, the interventions of intermediaries, and the ecological consequences of intensified extraction and deforestation. Such revisions reveal the state as an adaptive institution, continually recalibrating the terms of extraction in response to social conflict, local negotiation, and environmental limits. At the same time, these relations were mediated and contested by Armenian households, amiras, communal institutions, and other local actors, whose actions could themselves reshape the regulatory framework through which labor and resources were mobilized.

The dissertation consequently brings together debates that are often separated in Ottoman historiography: Marxist accounts of class and labor, world-systems approaches to capitalist incorporation, scholarship on household production and semi-proletarianization, and studies of Ottoman law, state formation, and local agency. My intervention is to show that these cannot be understood as separate dimensions of Bardizag's history. Capitalist incorporation took place through their interaction.

This approach also reframes the relationship between primitive accumulation and the formal subsumption of labor. Rather than treating primitive accumulation as a completed stage preceding capitalist development, I examine expropriation and the formal subsumption of labor

as overlapping processes through which capitalist and imperial relations were continually produced and reproduced. In Bardizag, the appropriation of forests, regulation of peasant labor, expansion of commodity production, and growing dependence on markets were interconnected rather than sequential processes.

The result is a history that reconnects the structural questions raised by Marxist and world-systems scholarship with the local institutions, actors, and negotiations emphasized by more recent Ottoman historiography. Bardizag shows that capitalism did not require the disappearance of smallholding, subsistence production, communal resources, or household labor. It could depend upon their continued existence in transformed and subordinated forms. The making of capitalist relations in the Ottoman countryside was therefore not simply a transition from one mode of production to another, but an uneven process of reorganizing existing forms of labor, property, reproduction, and ecological use.

By following these relations across a single Armenian community, this dissertation asks not simply where the Ottoman Empire stood with global capitalism, but how capitalism was made within the empire; through whose labor, whose household, whose resources, and whose political institutions. Bardizag provides the scale at which these relations become visible: the world economy appears not as an abstract structure imposed upon the countryside, but as a set of political, social, and ecological relations made concrete in everyday labor and household reproduction.

**Social Reproduction, Household and Capitalism Debate**

Capitalist transformation did not occur only in fields, workshops, forests, and markets. It also reorganized the household, turning domestic space into a site increasingly implicated in the

production and reproduction of labor power. This dissertation therefore treats reproduction not as a sphere external to capitalist production or peasant economy, but as an integral component of the social relations through which labor was produced, maintained, and made available for exploitation.

Maria Mies pushes this argument further by showing how capitalism transforms social and natural differences into relations of social domination. Gender, she argues, becomes not simply a difference between men and women but a broader social and class relation, just as bodily and racialized differences are transformed into socially consequential distinctions. Her analysis of capitalist rent is particularly important here: the accumulation of capital can depend upon the monopolization and appropriation of people and resources that are not themselves organized as conventional wage labor. Women and colonized populations can therefore become sources of capitalist rent precisely through forms of appropriation that remain partially outside the formal wage relation. Leopoldina Forunati provides a complementary account of this process. What appears to be an exchange between male wage workers and women within the household is, at a deeper level, an exchange between capital and women, with male workers functioning as intermediaries. The apparent exchange between reproductive labor and the wage thus conceals another relationship: between labor power and money, both of which enter the circuit of capital.

This insight is essential for understanding the transformation of the Ottoman household. The production of labor power did not begin when a worker entered a workplace. It depended upon

The daily and generational reproduction of workers through food preparation, childrearing, taking care of elderly members of the family, domestic labor, care, sexuality, emotional support, and the maintenance of household life. Fortunati's distinction between

material and non-material use-values is particularly useful here. Domestic labor produces not only material goods and services but also non-material use-values—affection, companionship, sexuality, care, and other forms of social and emotional reproduction. These activities may not appear as commodity production, yet they are indispensable to the reproduction of the laboring population.

The distinction between production and reproduction must therefore be treated as a historical and analytical problem rather than as a fixed division between value and non-value. In capitalist production, labor appears directly as wage labor, organized through particular forms of cooperation, division of labor, and technological development. Reproductive labor, by contrast, is largely unwaged and takes place within the household. It appears to stand outside value production. Yet this apparent separation obscures the material connection between the two: the reproduction of labor power is a precondition for its exploitation, while the wage depends upon a sphere of reproductive labor that is often performed without direct remuneration.

Hence, this dissertation follows the feminist Marxist tradition associated with Maria Mies. Leopoldina Fortunati, Mariarosa Della Costa, and Alessandra Mezzadri in treating reproduction as an integral part of the capitalist cycle. From this perspective, the distinction between production and reproduction is not simply one between value and non-value. Production appears as the creation of value, while reproductive labor often remains invisible as value-producing activity even though it creates and maintains the labor power upon which production depends. Production requires reproduction, while reproduction is continually reorganized by the demands of production and accumulation.

This perspective is particularly important for Bardizag because the household was not simply a private sphere existing alongside the processes examined in this dissertation. It was one

of the principal sites through which labor was organized, reproduced, and made available to multiple forms of extraction. Armenian peasant households combined agricultural production, forest labor, artisanal activity, seasonal wage work, and domestic and reproductive labor. These activities cannot be analytically separated without obscuring how households reproduced themselves. The labor that produced charcoal, cultivated land, participated in markets, or entered wage employment depended upon another set of activities—often performed by women and children—that sustained workers and households across generations.

This argument also returns to the question of value. As Diane Elson emphasizes in her reading of Marx, the central object of Marx's theory of value is not simply the determination of prices but the social organization of labor. The value question is therefore fundamentally a question about the forms that labor takes, the relationships among different forms of labor, and the social and political consequences of those relationships. Labor time does not simply determine exchange value in a one-directional process; the organization of exchange and value also reorganizes the social conditions under which labor time is expended. What appears in the market as the value of a commodity is consequently inseparable from the social relations through which labor power is organized and reproduced.

Von Werlhof's argument sharpens this point by challenging the assumption that only labor directly organized as commodity production is socially productive for capital. From the standpoint of capital, the social field encompasses everything that can be appropriated, commodified, or made to produce profit. This includes forms of labor and resources whose contribution may not appear directly in the commodity price. The question is therefore not simply whether a particular activity produces a commodity, but how different forms of labor and social reproduction are incorporated into relations of accumulation.

For this reason, I do not treat value as something generated exclusively at the point of commodity production. I ask instead how different forms of labor—waged and unwaged, productive and reproductive, agricultural and artisanal, human and ecological—were brought into relation through processes of accumulation. In Bardizag, the production of commodities and the reproduction of laboring households were mutually constitutive. The charcoal worker could enter the circuit of imperial monetary production only because a household economy sustained the capacity to work; conversely, the household's reproduction increasingly depended upon labor organized by markets, imperial demands, and commodity production.

The history of Bardizag thus requires us to look beyond the workplace and beyond wage labor alone. Capitalist and imperial extraction operated through the household as much as through the forest, field, workshop, and market. Examining reproductive labor makes visible forms of labor that disappear when value is identified exclusively with waged production. It also shows that the transformation of labor under Ottoman capitalism involved not only the incorporation of peasants into commodity and wage relations, but the reorganization of the household itself as a site of labor reproduction, social reproduction, and extraction.

Chapter two examines Bardizag's incorporation into the Ottoman monetary economy through charcoal production for the Mint between XY and the Z. Reading an 1831 petition composed by Bardizag villagers alongside the broader "monetary turn" in economic history, the chapter that Ottoman coinage should be understood not simply as a medium of exchange but as a material condensation of forest ecology, state finance, and peasant labor. The production of money depended upon an extensive regulatory apparatus involving Amiras, state officials, and restriction on accessed to woodland resources. The mint therefore functioned not merely as a distant fiscal institution but as an agent of ecological and social transformation in the rural

communities that supplied it. Debasement, warfare, and recurrent fiscal crises acquired concrete ecological consequences as intensifications in mint production translated into mounting demands upon Bardizag's forests and upon the households whose labor transformed those forests into charcoal. Monetary history thus becomes, at the village level, a history of forests, labor, and household reproduction.

Chapter three turns to the nineteenth century as a period of semi-proletarianization, during which fiscal reform, the introduction and expansion of taxes such as the charcoal tax, the road tax, and the military service exemption tac, and the Ottoman Public Debt Administration's monopolization of sericulture and tobacco progressively undermined the viability of subsistence agriculture. Yet these transformations did not produce a straightforward transition from peasant agriculture to wage labor. Instead, Bardizag villagers responded by combining agricultural production with seasonal and circular wage labor in Izmit, Adapazari, and Istanbul. The result was a household economy situated between subsistence and wage labor, in which different forms of work were combined to secure reproduction under increasingly difficult conditions. The chapter therefore treats semi-proletarianization not as a transitional stage on an inevitable path toward full proletarianization, but as a durable social formation in its own right. (daha iyi ifade eder misin?

The chapter also foregrounds the gendered character of this transformation. Women's factory labor, domestic service, agricultural work, and other forms of remunerated and unremunerated labor became increasingly important to household survival, while illicit strategies allowed villagers to negotiate the restrictions imposed by taxation and monopoly regimes. These practices reveal the limits of models that conceptualize commercialization primarily through formal markets and male wage labor. They also complicate historiographies of the Ottoman east,

“where Kurdish landlordism has often occupied a disproportionately central place in accounts of rural political economy. Bardizag demonstrates that Armenian villages situated closer to the imperial capital experienced processes of fiscal incorporation, commercialization, labor mobility, and class differentiation that demand a broader geographical and analytical framework.

Chapter Four shifts the analysis from economic extraction to political mobilization, examining revolutionary organizing, cooperative economic institutions, and communal solidarity in Bardizag during the decades preceding the First World War. Drawing on Beverly Silver’s theorization of hegemonic transition and social conflict, the chapter interprets the activities of local Armenian Revolutionary Federation committees, cooperative retail enterprises, and networks of tax resistance and outlawry as evidence of a peasantry and emerging working class actively contesting the terms of their incorporation into imperial and capitalist structures. Political mobilization did not therefore emerge independently of the economic transformations examined in the preceding chapters. Rather, revolutionary politics developed within the same social world produced by taxation, wage labor, migration, commercialization, and changing relations of authority.

This chapter consequently challenges interpretations of Armenian revolutionary politics that locate political radicalization primarily within urban intellectual or organizational networks. In Bardizag, political consciousness was also produced through the material experiences of households confronting taxation, indebtedness, labor discipline, and unequal access to economic resources. Cooperative institutions provided an alternative means of organizing economic life (confirming literature on Armenian mutual aid), while tax resistance and outlawry represented more confrontational forms of contestation.

Chapter Five analyze the deportation and destruction of Bardizag's Armenian community in 1915 through the concept of the colonial boomerang: the return of coercive techniques developed on imperial frontiers against a population situated within the political and geographic shadow of the imperial capital. The chapter draws upon Nancy Fraser's distinction between exploitation and expropriation and Saidiya Hartman's analysis of freedom's constitutive relationship to unfreedom to conceptualize genocide as a violent economic reorganization. Disarmament, deportation, the forced liquidation of property, and the seizure and resale of Armenian women transformed existing relations of economic extraction into mechanisms of dispossession and destruction.

This is why İbrahim Bey matters to the history of Bardizag. His position as a prison director and his appearance as an agent of violence in the village reveal the continuity between seemingly distinct sites of state power. The prison was not simply where the state placed its opponents; it was part of a broader infrastructure through which political authority was exercised, challenged, and reproduced. Looking at Bardizag through this infrastructure makes it possible to connect revolutionary repression to the wider histories of expropriation, labor, and capitalist inequality that structure this dissertation.

The argument of this dissertation emerged, in part, from looking at Bardizag through the history of those who struggled against these structures of power. It is therefore dedicated to those across the world who fought and died believing that another world was possible, and especially to the people of Bardizag whose struggles made another history imaginable.

Although the negotiations that ended the occupation secured safe passage for the occupiers rather than a general release of prisoners, the demand reveals the political significance of imprisonment itself. Freeing imprisoned Armenians was understood as part of the revolutionary

struggle. Thus, the prison thus occupied a double position within Armenian revolutionary politics. It was an instrument through which the Ottoman state sought to contain political opposition, but it was also a site at which that power could be challenged. The boundary between confinement and resistance was therefore porous: the state attempted to immobilize revolutionaries through imprisonment, while revolutionaries treated the liberation of prisoners as a legitimate object of political action. To understand Armenian revolutionary movements, then, the history of prisons cannot be separated from the history of the movements that sought to resist the state.

This also complicates how we understand the Ottoman state itself. The state was not a unified or monolithic actor imposing a coherent policy from above. It was constituted through overlapping institutions, officials, military forces, local authorities, and competing interests whose forms of cooperation and conflict shaped the exercise of power. Prisons, local administration, the Hamidiye regiments, and other coercive institutions belonged to this wider field of power. Their histories intersected with the regulation of labor and resources and with the production of social and economic inequality. The suppression of Armenian revolutionary movements therefore cannot be treated as a separate political history from the processes through which the state organized labor, property, and extraction.

This argument does not reduce genocide to economic motives, nor does it suggest that the preceding political economy mechanically produced the violence of 1915. Rather, it asks how institutions, administrative capacities, property relations, and coercive practices developed within an imperial political economy could be redirected toward genocidal ends. The destruction of Bardizag's Armenian community cannot therefore be analytically severed from the political economy reconstructed in the preceding chapters. Genocide constituted a radical transformation of existing relations of power, in which mechanisms previously used to extract labor and surplus

were repurposed to eliminate a population, appropriate its property, and dismantle the social structures through which it reproduced itself.

Taken together, these chapters argue that Bardizag's Armenian peasantry was never a static or self-evident social category. It was a historically contingent formation, continually produced and reproduced through changing configurations of land, taxation, monetary policy, ecological access, wage labor, migration, and political organization. Its incorporation into the Ottoman economy was neither a singular event nor a linear transition from subsistence to capitalism. It was an uneven and contested process in which households repeatedly adapted their economic strategies while simultaneously becoming more deeply entangled in imperial systems of extraction and global circuits of capital.

The violence of 1915 must be situated within this longer history without being reduced to it. The genocide was neither simply the culmination of an inevitable process of capitalist transformation nor a complete rupture with the economic and administrative structures of the preceding centuries. It was a historical conjuncture in which existing capacities of taxation, regulation, surveillance, property administration, transportation, and coercion were reorganized toward the destruction of an Armenian population. The same imperial infrastructures that had long incorporated Bardizag into circuits of labor, revenue, and production could therefore be redirected toward its dispossession.

Understanding 1915 thus requires more than placing the genocide at the end of a narrative that begins in the seventeenth century. It requires reconstructing the changing political economy through which Bardizag's Armenian community was made, transformed, and ultimately unmade. By placing the peasant household at the center of that history, this dissertation seeks to connect questions that are too often treated separately: the history of

Ottoman fiscal extraction, the commercialization of rural economies, the formation of wage labor, Armenian political mobilization, and the economic dimensions of genocide. The three centuries preceding 1915 were not merely a prehistory to catastrophe. They constituted the social, economic, and institutional terrain upon which the catastrophe unfolded.

## I. Ottoman Peasant Historiography and the Armenian Gap

In his influential discussion of Ottoman peasant historiography, Fikret Adanır traces both shifting interpretations and the empirical foundations of rural life. Early post–World War II Marxist scholarship viewed the Balkan countryside as marked by widespread peasant expropriation and commercialization. Later Western research challenged this, arguing that peasants largely retained land and that the absence of expropriation reflected regional underdevelopment rather than exploitation. These debates became entangled with dependency theory, particularly Immanuel Wallerstein's world-systems framework, which positioned the empire as a peripheral component of global capitalism.

Adanır grounds these interpretive disputes in the administrative sources that make Ottoman rural history legible: kanunnames, tax registers, and court records. These reveal a system in which land was largely miri (state-owned) and revenues distributed through the timar hierarchy to military and administrative elites, tying agrarian production directly to imperial governance.[3] The field was further transformed by the Annales school and historians such as Halil İnalcık and Suraiya Faroqhi, who used cadastral surveys and fiscal records to reconstruct agrarian structures, emphasizing state control over land and regional variation.[4]

A central question in this literature is whether European models; feudalism, commercialization, capitalist integration, apply to the Ottoman case. Revisionist historians such as Huri İslamoğlu-İnan argue that the system was fundamentally state-centered and resists feudal

[3] Fikret Adanir, "Ottoman Peasantries,"

[4] (Ed.). Halil Inalcik, Suraiya Faroqhi, (et.al.) *An Economic and Social History of the Ottoman Empire, 1300-1914.* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1997).

categories, while Marxist and world-systems scholars stress its absorption into global capitalism.[5] Adanır offers a critical synthesis, rejecting both nationalist and deterministic readings. He emphasizes continuity with pre-Ottoman structures, strong state regulation, and the relative autonomy peasants exercised through usufruct rights. His analysis of the transition from timar to tax farming (*iltizam and malikane*) and the rise of provincial elites (*ayan*) identifies mounting pressures on the peasantry without, crucially, wholesale dispossession.

On the question of commercialization and the spread of large estates (*çiftliks*), Adanır resists the language of proletarianization, introducing instead the concept of "titular dispossession": peasants remained on the land but grew increasingly dependent through market forces and debt. Taken together, his work demonstrates how continuity, regional diversity, and enduring smallholding shaped Ottoman rural society's long-term trajectory and why the Ottoman agrarian system must be understood as a distinct, state-centered formation rather than a variant of European experience.

In his article “Bringing the Peasants Back In,” Elias Kolovos observes that Ottoman peasants have largely disappeared from recent historiography. Since the mid-1990s, few major monographs have focused explicitly on rural society, marking a notable departure from earlier scholarship that treated peasants as foundational to the Ottoman social and economic order. Halil Inalcik famously characterized the Ottoman empire as a “peasant empire,” yet much twenty-first century scholarship has increasingly reframed the empire as an “empire of difference, ” prioritizing questions of identity, culture, and diversity over socioeconomic structures and rural relations. [6]

[5] Huri Islamoglu-Inan, *State and Peasant in the Ottoman Empire: Agrarian Power Relations and Regional Economic Development in Ottoman Anatolia during the Sixteenth Century*. (Brill, 1994).

[6] Halil Inalcik, Karen Barkey

This shift can be tied to the broader "cultural turn" in Ottoman historiography. As Suraiya Faroqhi notes, because villagers prior to the late nineteenth century left relatively limited cultural records, the increasing emphasis on culture and identity has rendered rural populations less visible in historical analysis.[7] As a result, peasants have been marginalized not because of a lack of historical significance but because of methodological priorities that privilege sources produced by urban and elite actors. The consequences of this shift have been particularly pronounced for the study of non-Muslim rural populations. These communities have often been approached by primarily through communal, ecclesiastical, or nationalist framework rather than examined as part of the empire`s agrarian and socioeconomic structures.

Ottoman Armenian studies also reflect this broader historiographical tendency. Scholarship on Ottoman Armenians has overwhelmingly focused on urban elites, ecclesiastical institutions, intellectual networks, and most prominently the revolutionary movements and the genocide. While these topics are indispensable, this emphasis has obscured the fact that the majority of Ottoman Armenians lived as peasants embedded in rural economies and imperial fiscal structures.

As a result, Armenian peasants have largely disappeared from both Ottoman social history and Armenian historiography. They occupy an ambiguous position between imperial studies, which rarely foreground non-Muslim rural communities, and nationalist historiographies, which tend to privilege political mobilization and catastrophe over economic life. This dissertation intervenes directly in this dual absence by centering the Armenian peasantry of Bardizag. It argues that the marginalization of Armenian peasantry reflects not a scarcity of sources, but a lack of questions directed toward rural social relations, labor practices, and environmental interactions.

[7] Elias Kolovos, " Bringing the Peasants Back In?," in *Ottoman Rural Societies and Economies, Halcyon Days in Crete VII, A Symposium Held in Rethymno, 13-15 January 2012.* (Crete University Press, Rethymno, 2015).

## II. Methodological Foundations: Sources, Categories, and Approach to Armenian Peasantry

Donald Quataert`s work provides an important methodological foundation for such an approach. In *Workers, Peasants, and Economic Change in the Ottoman Empire, 1730-1914*, Quataert argues that Ottoman archival documents rarely provide a sufficient basis for understanding social history when used in isolation.[8] State records must therefore be read alongside a wide range of non-state sources to bring workers and peasants into clearer analytical focus. At the same time, Quataert warns that even sources that appear to provide access to "history from below," such as court registers or waqf records, must be interpreted critically. These documents record forms of legal engagement that were unevenly available across Ottoman society, often privileging urban and relatively affluent actors. Consequently, they cannot be read as unmediated representations of subaltern experience.

This dissertation adopts Quataert's methodological insight by combining Ottoman fiscal records with Armenian communal archives and local documentation. By integrating these materials, it reconstructs the economic practices and social organization of Armenian peasants while avoiding a purely state-centered perspective. Bringing peasants back in through environmental history has particular significance for Ottoman Armenian studies. A long-standing emphasis on urban elites, ecclesiastical institutions, and political catastrophe has obscured a basic fact: most Ottoman Armenians were rural producers whose lives were organized around land, forests, and seasonal labor. By centering Armenian peasantry as environmental actors, positioned at the intersection of provisionism and monetary instability, this first chapter situates them within the dynamics of Ottoman political economy rather than confining them to narratives of communal identity or victimhood. Armenian rural communities were neither marginal nor passive, but

[8] Donald Quataert, *Workers, Peasants, and Economic Change in the Ottoman Empire, 1730–1914,* p.xiv-xv.

indispensable participants in an extractive imperial system that depended on their labor and ecological knowledge.

The term *peasantry*, as I employ it in this dissertation, denotes a rural social category defined not by a single, uniform legal status, but by a constellation of relationships to land, labor, and political authority. In Ottoman usage, the peasantry broadly corresponded to the *reaya* — the tax-paying rural subjects of the empire, a term that encompassed a wide spectrum of conditions without prescribing a single legal form. More generally, the word peasant refers to rural cultivators who possess some form of access to land, whether through ownership, communal right, or customary usage, but who do not control the full conditions of their labor or the full product of their work. What distinguishes peasants from slaves is the formal retention of personal legal status; what distinguishes them from free smallholders or wage laborers is the existence of surplus-extracting obligations — whether in the form of rent, taxes, labor services, or, as in this case, administratively compelled commodity production. Peasantry, in this sense, is not a fixed legal category but a relational position, defined by the terms on which a rural community is incorporated into broader structures of political and economic power.

In the context of late seventeenth- and eighteenth-century Armenian communities in Bardizag, peasantry is understood as a condition characterized by limited but legally recognized access to productive resources, alongside obligations to external powers that structured and constrained the terms of that access. Armenian peasants in this period relied in part on communally held gardens and, in certain cases, on usufructuary rights to large estates, that is, legally recognized entitlements to use land and extract its resources without holding formal ownership. This arrangement must be analytically distinguished from two adjacent and often conflated social categories: *serfdom*, in which the laborer was legally bound to a lord, transferable as property, and

stripped of the right to mobility; and *debt bondage*, in which the peasant's freedom of movement and labor was effectively suspended through indebtedness, foreclosing the possibility of seeking wage employment elsewhere. The Armenian peasantry of Bardizag occupied neither of these positions in their full legal sense. They retained a meaningful, if circumscribed, degree of mobility and exercised a degree of agency over the disposition of their labor.

Yet this relative freedom should not be mistaken for substantive freedom from extra-economic compulsion. The apparent latitude enjoyed by Armenian peasants operated within and was ultimately subordinated to a framework of imperial extraction rooted in the structural logic of pre-capitalist surplus appropriation. Their obligations to the Ottoman Imperial Mint, particularly in the domain of charcoal production, were defined entirely by administrative fiat: both the required output and the unit price were fixed by the imperial authorities, leaving no space for negotiation, market participation, or contractual flexibility. Their freedom was thus conditional and contingent permitted insofar as it served the productive requirements of the state, and bounded by obligations that could not be refused or renegotiated.

Armenian peasantry in Bardizag maintained a degree of mobility and control over their labor. This relative freedom complicates, rather than overturns, interpretations that stress the hierarchical and extractive nature of Ottoman provincial society. Indeed, the apparent autonomy of Armenian peasantry may be understood as masking deeper structural inequalities. Their freedom was conditional and contingent, exercised only insofar as they fulfilled the requirements imposed by the Ottoman Imperial Mint. In this sense, their position invites debate; *Were they meaningfully free economic actors, or were they operating within a tightly constrained system that merely allowed limited flexibility?* These are the main questions that I try to answer in this dissertation broadly.

Atilla Aytekin's work offers a key intervention. While rural indebtedness in the nineteenth-century Ottoman Empire is well established, Aytekin reconstructs its grassroots structure and embedded social relations. Drawing on detailed debt registers from Mihaliç and Kirmastı in western Anatolia, he shows how collective indebtedness operated at the village level and was deeply woven into quotidian rural existence. Crucially, he challenges the assumption that the Ottoman state functioned as a protective buffer against peasant indebtedness. Instead, he demonstrates that nineteenth-century policy reflected a fragmented ruling elite increasingly entangled with moneylending interests, producing indifference and largely ineffective intervention. Read in this context, Armenian peasant experience exposes the limits of a legalistic framework: formal non-Muslim rights offered little protection against debt, taxation, and local hierarchies. Aytekin thus redefines "freedom" in material rather than juridical terms, calling for a continuum of constraint shaped by economic vulnerability and uneven state power.

Reproduction, Labor, and Value:

**III. The Material Conditions of Armenian Peasantry in Bardizag:**

The status of Armenians as a non-Muslim community in Ottoman historiography has largely been framed through a legalistic lens, emphasizing formal rights such as marriage, mobility, and communal autonomy. Earlier scholarship treated these juridical distinctions as primary markers of status and freedom. Yet, following the cultural turn and the expansion of Ottoman social and regional history, attention to freedom as a lived material condition has receded. As a result, debate remains fragmented on how peasant life; particularly among non-Muslim communities such as Armenians, should be situated along a spectrum of autonomy and constraint. This gap obscures how formal rights coexisted with, and were often undermined by, localized regimes of labor obligation, fiscal extraction, and state intervention shaping everyday rural life.

Armenian monographs on Bardizag suggest that Armenian peasants operated within a rural structure comparable to that identified by Huri-Cihan İslamoğlu for the broader Ottoman countryside. Agricultural production remained organized around family labor and smallholdings, with peasants retaining a degree of economic autonomy even amid expanding commercialization. In this sense, the Bardizag case supports İslamoğlu's argument that market integration in the Ottoman agrarian economy did not necessarily produce land concentration or widespread peasant dispossession. Rather, it demonstrates how rural communities could be incorporated into market networks while the structural predominance of smallholder land use persisted.

Scholarship on Ottoman rural society has highlighted the structural characteristics and persistence of small-scale production within the agrarian economy. In particular, the work of Huri Cihan Islamoglu challenges older narratives that link commercialization in agrarian economies to the concentration of land and the emergence of large estates. Drawing on extensive archival research on Ottoman agriculture, Islamoglu demonstrates that the market-oriented production did not generally produce large-landed properties or a class of landless rural laborers. Instead, commercial agriculture was largely sustained by smallholding peasants who retained only control over their plots while participating in regional markets. [9] Rather than being absorbed into large agricultural estates or reduced to dependent laborers, Armenian villagers in Bardizag in the early modern era, appear to have maintained relatively small-scale agricultural productions. it often operated through household-based cultivation on small plots of land in the 18th century.

Agriculture formed the backbone of the early settler economy, with subsistence farming shaping daily life and patterns of land use.[10] Upon settling, Bardizag villagers cleared the surrounding forest, converting it into arable fields primarily used for grain cultivation. In oral

[9] Jairus Banaji, *A Brief History of Commercial Capitalism.* (Haymarket Books, 2020).

[10] Krikor Mkhalian,

accounts, areas later known for mulberry orchards were originally fields dedicated to subsistence grain production, with the harvest processed on communal village threshing floors. Over time, these once-central spaces such as the Upper Threshing Floor, St. Minas' Threshing Floor, Khasman's Threshing Floor, Amou's Threshing Floor, and the Bordj Oghlou's Threshing Floor; gradually lost their agricultural purpose and were transformed into playgrounds, symbolizing both demographic and economic change.

Beyond cereal cultivation, villagers maintained small household gardens that played a key role in subsistence. These gardens, located adjacent to homes, included fruit trees such as pear, apple, quince, fig, and cherry. Grapevines, trained along stone walls and wooden arbours, produced grapes for local consumption. One enduring vine near the narrator's home had spread across the Momdjons' barn and was reportedly still flourishing decades later. In time, vineyard cultivation expanded to the sunlit hills above the Upper Fields, reflecting a diversification of local production.

These house gardens were also sites for growing green vegetables, demonstrating how families integrated subsistence horticulture into domestic space. Such practices anchored rural livelihoods in a mixed economy that combined grain cultivation, orchards, and kitchen gardens. While limited in scale, these activities sustained households and reduced dependence on external markets, forming an essential component of the village's early economic structure. The transformation of fields into orchards and play areas also suggests shifts in the agrarian economy, land tenure patterns, and generational change over time.

**IV. From Sebastia Bardizag to Nicomedia Bardizag: Origins of Settlement**

https://upload.wikimedia.org/wikipedia/commons/3/32/Le_Tour_du_monde-03-p147.jpg?utm_source=fr.wikisource.org&utm_campaign=imageinfo&utm_content=original

**M. J. E. Dauzats**

**Excursion agricole dans le nord de l'Anatolie**

*Le Tour du monde*, Volume 3, 1861 (p. 145-160).

Burada map var.



11

11

Ryan Gingeras, Sorrowful Shores, p.3. (introduction iyi oku.)

The South Marmara at the turn of the century was also the home of the two largest native Christian populations of Anatolia: Armenians and native Greeks (or Rum in Turkish). Like Circassians and Albanians, Rum and Armenians were also seminal actors in the construction of the Ottoman state. Known for their contributions to the fields of commerce and industry, these two groups often straddle the nexus between Ottoman society and the wider Western world. In the midst of war and political chaos in the years between the Balkan War and the establishment of the Republic of Turkey, all four of these polities came under extreme state scrutiny. By the end of the war years, violence would decimate each of these communities in the South Marmara.

Scholars offer differing explanations for the origins of Armenian settlement of Bahcecik in the Nicomedia region. Avni Ozture situates the emergence of Armenian communities around Izmit within a broader, multi-phase migration process extending from the late fourteenth to the seventeenth century. He traces the earliest movement to the collapse of the Cilician Armenian Principality in 1375, after which Armenian refugees settled in the western and southwestern districts of Nicomedia, including present-day Karamursel, Defne and Tepekoy. [12] According to Ozture, a second wave followed Timur`s campaign in eastern Anatolia, bringing migrants from Erzurum, Erzincan, Sivas, Bitlis and Van: he supports this argument, by linking Armenian place names in the region to toponyms from these areas. Subsequent migration occurred during the Ottoman-Persian conflicts of the early sixteenth century and, most significantly during the the

[12] Oguz Polatel, "Izmit Kazasi`nda Ermeni Yerlesiminin Baslangici ve Ermeni Yerlesim Yerleri," p.28

*Celali* rebellions of the late sixteenth and seventeenth centuries, whose migrants are described as formed the core of the Armenian population in the district. [13]

Within this broader framework, Armenian historians have proposed more specific explanations for the foundation of Bardizag itself. Mkhelyan attributes the origins of the settlement to migrants from Bardizag in the Sebastia region. His arguments rests primarily on linguistice evidence: the phonetic and grammatical features of the Armenian dialect spoken in Bardizag closely resemble those of Armenians from Sivas. Krikor Mkhelyan further suggests that migrants transferred the name Bardizag from their original village to the new settlement, a claim supported by a 1625 imperial decree issued during the reign of Murad IV in which the name Bardizag appears. Althought the document reportedly survived into the nineteenth century; it was lost during the genocide.

Kasapyan provides a more detailed migration narrative linking the settlement directly to the upheavals of the Celali rebellions. According to his account, seven Armenian families fleeing the Sivas region first settled on the farm (ciftlik) of Halil Pasha in western Bahcecik, where they worked as farmers. Nineteen additional Armenian families soon joined them under Halil Pasha`s protection, forming the core of the settlement. Halil Pasha; who served several times as Grand Armiral, and twice as Grand Vizier, was born near Kayseri and was reportedly of Armenian origin. Recruited through the devshirme system and educated in the Enderun palace school, he later established a vakif that included villages around Bahcecik. Hrand der Andreasyan similarly notes that the cleric Vardapet Hagop, mentioned in Father Grigor`s *Chronology*, was able to assist Armenian migrants fleeing Anatolia partly through familial and regional ties with Halil Pasha.

[13] Henry R.Shapiro, "The Great Armenian Flight: Migration and Cultural Change in the 17th century Ottoman Empire", *Journal of Early Modern History*, 2019, p.67.

A different explanation has been advanced by Oğuz Polatel, who argues that the founders of Bahçecik may have been laborers brought to the region in 1591 for a canal construction project intended to connect the Sea of Marmara with the Sakarya River. Ottoman decrees ordered the the beylerbeyis of Anatolia, Karaman, Sivas, Maraş, and Erzurum to provide workers, and approximately 30,000 laborers were reportedly assigned to the project. The canal was soon abandoned, however when naval preparations took priority, and subsequent decrees ordered the laborers to return to their original places.[14] Since no Ottoman archival evidence indicates that these workers remained in the Izmit region, the hypothesis linking Bardizag`s foundation to migration from the Sivas region remains more convincing .[15]

The timing of this migration corresponds to the broader disruptions that affected Anatolia in the late sixteenth and early seventeenth centuries. The Celali rebellions devastated large parts of the interior, producing widespread violence, rural abandonment, and population displacement. Many Armenians from inland regions migrated toward the relatively secure Marmara zone, where new settlements such as Bardizag, Dongel, Ovacik and Arslanbeg emerged near Izmit. [16]

Environmental condition likely reinforced these movements. The Sivas region, characterized by high elevation, harsh winters, and limited agricultural productivity, was particulary vulnerable to short-term climatic fluctuations.[17] Dendrochronological evidence indicates drought episodes in 1607-1608, 1610-1611, and 1623-1624, which would have

[14] Based on Mustafa Akdag`s Celali Revolt analysis Sam White reminds that some of the peasants from Sivas, Maras, and Karahisar-i Sarki fled as far as Gurcistan. Sam White, The Climate of Rebellion the Early Modern Ottoman Empire, p.255.

[15] Nahide Simsir, Sebahattin Simsir "XVIII.Yuzyilin Ikinci Yarisinda Kocaeli Sancagi`ndan Tarihi Kesitler," *Uluslararasi Gazi Suleyman Pasa ve Kocaeli Tarihi Sempozyumu-III*, 2017 Kocaeli Buyuksehir Belediyesi Kultur ve Sosyal Isler Dairesi Baskanligi Yayinlari No:38, p.35-36.

[16] Virtual Genocide Memorial, nahiye-bardizag-bahcecik, Accessed Time (Sunday, November 16, 2024).

[17] Onur Usta, "In Pursuit of Herds or Land? Nomads, Peasants and Pastoral Economies in Anatolia from a Regional Perspective 1600-1645," (Unpublished Dissertation: University of Birmingham, 2016), p.191

intensified already fragile subsistence conditions. [18] Combined with insecurity created by Celali Rebellions, these environmental stresses contributed to rural displacement. In contrast, Bardizag offered a milder climate, proximity to maritime trade networks, and relative political stability, making it an "attractive" (synonym) destination for displaced Armenian populations. [19]

Ottoman archival sources indicate that the Celali Rebellions produced significant population mobility in the İzmit region. Narrative and administrative records note that a considerable number of Armenian households temporarily relocated to the region during this period of instability and that, once order was restored, these households were instructed to return to their places of origin.

More systematic demographic evidence is provided by a *mufassal* register dated 1045/1636, which records 47 non-Muslim taxpayers in the urban center affiliated with the Yakup Pasha waqf and 19 non-Muslim taxpayers in Ovacık/Yuvacık. Although this register does not specify confessional affiliation beyond the category of non-Muslim, contextual evidence suggests that the population recorded in Yuvacık was predominantly Armenian.[20]

By the late seventeenth century, cizye registers allow for a more differentiated view of non-Muslim settlement patterns in the İzmit district. A poll-tax register dated 1104/1693 records a total of 1,780 non-Muslim taxpayers in the city of İznikmid/İzmit, including 330 Armenians and 168 Greeks (Rum).[111] Within the rural hinterland, Greek (Rum) taxpayers predominated in several villages—140 in Yeniköy, 11 in Kayranca, 32 in Darlık, 28 in Kürdderesi, 58 in Zeytinburnu, and 69 in Mihaliç—indicating a largely Rum rural presence at this time.

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[18] Ibid, p.193.

[19] Ibid. Sam White, p.255

[20] Raif Kaplanoglu, *Kocaeli Livasi Tahrir Defteri Iznikmid Kazasi (Izmit, Golcuk, Kartepe ve Basiskele Ilceleri)*. p.41-42. On the earlier official registers from Iznikmid, see p.340. Leila Erder and Suraiya Faroqhi, "Population Rise and Fall in Anatolia 1550-1620," *Middle Eastern Studies*, Oct. 1979, Vol.15, No.3, p.340.

Bardızag (*Bahçecik*), however, stands out as a particularly significant Armenian settlement. According to the same cizye register, 91 Armenian taxpayers were recorded in Bardızag, a figure that exceeds those of most surrounding villages and underscores the village's centrality within the Armenian settlement network of the İzmit district. Additional Armenian taxpayers were registered in Döngel (28), Yuvacık (103), Arslanbey (30), and Dağköy (13), suggesting a pattern in which Bardızag functioned as an anchor community within a broader constellation of Armenian rural settlements. Taken together, these registers point to Bardızag's early prominence and to the role of Armenian villages in shaping the demographic and fiscal landscape of the İzmit hinterland by the late seventeenth century.

Introduction

The history of Bardizag, an Armenian village in the İzmit region located only fifty-six miles from Constantinople, poses a problem for conventional histories of both Ottoman capitalism and Armenian political mobilization. By the late nineteenth century, Bardizag was deeply integrated into regional and international circuits of production and exchange. Its households combined agriculture with wage labor, artisanal production, textile work, sericulture, and commercial activity, while its schools, churches, and communal institutions connected the village to broader Armenian networks extending from İzmit and Adapazarı to Constantinople and beyond. Yet this economic and institutional integration did not protect Bardizag from increasingly coercive forms of state extraction. On the contrary, the very processes that incorporated Armenian households into changing circuits of production also generated new conflicts over taxation, military service, mobility, labor, and political authority. Bardizag therefore offers a particularly productive site for examining how capitalist transformation,

imperial governance, and Armenian revolutionary politics developed not as separate historical processes but as mutually constitutive forms of social conflict.

This dissertation approaches these transformations from the material conditions of everyday life. Rather than treating Armenian revolutionary politics primarily as the product of nationalism, ideological radicalization, or the diffusion of revolutionary ideas from European centers, I ask how changing relations of labor, property, and state extraction shaped the political possibilities available to Armenian peasants and workers. In Bardizag, resistance frequently emerged before it acquired an explicitly revolutionary vocabulary. Peasants hid young men from military recruitment, evaded taxation, negotiated with local officials, mobilized communal resources to purchase exemptions, and developed other forms of what might be understood as everyday resistance to the alienation of their labor and bodies. The history of conscription in Bardizag makes this particularly visible: military service was experienced not simply as a civic obligation but as an additional form of extraction that threatened household productive capacity. Families with several sons were targeted for recruitment, while wealthier members of the community could mobilize money to hire substitutes. The resulting conflict exposed both the coercive power of the state and the class divisions within the Armenian community itself.

These struggles unfolded within a broader transformation of labor. Bardizag was not simply a peasant community gradually displaced by capitalism. Its households occupied an unstable position between subsistence production, artisanal labor, wage labor, and commodity production. This semi-proletarianized condition was fundamental to the region's economic development. Capital could draw upon household labor without immediately eliminating older forms of production, while families themselves remained dependent upon access to land, domestic production, communal resources, and wage income. The transition from handloom

production toward mechanized silk production demonstrates how this process could deepen. Machinery and factory organization increasingly reorganized the labor process itself, drawing women and girls into more regimented forms of commodity production and making workers increasingly dependent upon wages. Yet capitalist production remained dependent upon forms of labor that existed outside the wage relation, including agricultural work, domestic labor, and the reproduction of households. The history of Bardizag therefore requires an analysis of capitalism that moves beyond the factory and asks how the reproduction of labor itself became part of the political economy of the region.

This perspective also changes how Armenian revolutionary movements appear within the history of the late Ottoman Empire. Revolutionary organizations did not enter an otherwise politically passive community from outside. They encountered a population already negotiating the coercive demands of the state, local elites, landlords, employers, and emerging capitalist markets. The political language of revolution could therefore intersect with older practices of evasion, collective action, communal self-defense, and resistance to extraction. The transformation of these practices into organized revolutionary politics was neither linear nor inevitable. It emerged through the convergence of local struggles with transregional Armenian political networks and the increasingly violent efforts of the Ottoman state to monopolize legitimate violence. The growth of revolutionary organizations, their attempts to arm communities, and the state's response to them must consequently be understood within the longer history of struggles over who possessed the right to control Armenian labor, mobility, property, and bodily existence.

This history becomes particularly important after the intensification of Ottoman fiscal and political crisis in the late nineteenth century. The expansion of state extraction, the

reorganization of provincial administration, the growing burden of public debt, and the increasing incorporation of provincial economies into international markets altered the relationship between the Ottoman state and its Armenian subjects. The state sought new forms of revenue, labor, military manpower, and administrative control at precisely the moment when Armenian households were becoming more deeply integrated into commercial networks. Resistance to taxation and conscription, therefore, cannot be separated from the larger transformation of the Ottoman political economy. Nor can revolutionary politics be understood solely through the category of nationalism. The struggles documented in Bardizag reveal conflicts over the material conditions through which households reproduced themselves and through which the state sought to appropriate their labor.

The relationship between labor and violence becomes even more consequential when the history of revolutionary mobilization is connected to 1915. Chapter 5 argues that the destruction of Bardizag should not be understood solely as the annihilation of an ethnic or religious community. It was also a process of economic reorganization in which Armenian property, labor, productive capacities, and social relations were violently transferred to others. Drawing on Nancy Fraser's distinction between exploitation and expropriation, I understand this process as a form of violent accumulation that operated beyond the wage relation through confiscation, coercion, deportation, forced labor, and the appropriation of persons. Anahit Astoyan's emphasis on expropriation as extending beyond the seizure of material property to the destruction and appropriation of human capacities is particularly useful here. The question, therefore, is not simply what happened to Armenian property after 1915, but what happened to the laboring capacities, knowledge, skills, bodies, and social institutions through which Armenian economic life had been reproduced.

The concept of the colonial boomerang provides a further way to connect these histories. The violence ultimately directed against Bardizag did not emerge suddenly in 1915. Techniques of coercion, repression, and irregular violence had been developed and refined elsewhere and were carried by state personnel into new spaces. Yet Bardizag complicates the conventional colonial-boomerang model because the violence did not simply travel from a colonial periphery back toward an imperial center. Instead, the Ottoman state could transform a community previously integrated into the empire's economic and administrative order into an internal periphery at the moment of violence. The destruction of Bardizag thus demonstrates how populations could be simultaneously central to imperial economic life and rendered politically disposable.

Finally, this dissertation asks what happens to labor when the conditions that made collective life possible are destroyed. The expropriation of Armenian men through conscription and deportation was accompanied by the appropriation of women's and children's labor, the confiscation of property, the dismantling of communal institutions, and the forced incorporation of survivors into new domestic and state-controlled labor regimes. In this sense, genocide was not external to the history of labor transformation that preceded it. It radically reorganized that history. The experience of Arshalous Patoogian demonstrates how this process continued after deportation through repeated seizure, sale, forced marriage, and incorporation into household economies. Her labor and bodily existence became resources through which other households reproduced themselves, illustrating what this dissertation calls the gendered and recursive character of expropriation.

The history of Bardizag therefore moves us beyond a binary between exploitation and violence, or between economic transformation and political radicalization. Capitalist

development, imperial extraction, revolutionary mobilization, and genocidal violence were historically entangled. The same population that was incorporated into expanding markets, subjected to new forms of labor discipline, and increasingly dependent upon commercial production was also subjected to intensified state extraction and political surveillance. The forms of resistance that emerged from these contradictions—from tax evasion and conscription resistance to organized revolutionary activity—were met with increasingly coercive forms of state power. By 1915, that coercion took the form of mass dispossession, deportation, and destruction, through which Armenian labor and productive capacity were not simply eliminated but redistributed and reorganized. Bardizag consequently reveals a history in which the transformation of labor and the destruction of a community were not separate processes. They were connected stages in the remaking of political economy, class relations, and social reproduction in the late Ottoman Empire.

## Chapter 2: Money, Extractivism and Rural Labor in Bardizag: Charcoal Production, *Amira*s and the Armenian Peasantry

arbitrage: amiralar bunu chapter`a ekle.

the Mint as an institution: **timar`in ilga edilmesi.**

Ayşe hocanin Region questiou`inini introductionda aciklyabilirsin, nasil bir region, istanbul`a iznik`e yakin olmasi nasil bir sans sagliyor?

**what did mean to be there: to be in close proximity.**

**diger institutionlarin yonetimi ve mint`in pozisyonu uzerine tartis.**

humbarahane.

In 1831, in İzmit, a group of Armenian villagers drafted a petition they could not ignore. For generations, their fathers and grandfathers had climbed into the forests of Bahçecik and Yuvacik, swung their axes, and fed the charcoal kilns that kept the Ottoman Empire's mint alive. The Ottoman state had promised them something in return; exemption from the crushing weight of

extraordinary taxes; the *tekalif-i orfiye*, a deal struck long ago and sealed with an imperial rescript, a *hatt-i humayun*. Their only recognized fiscal obligation was the *cizye*, the poll tax that marked them, like all non-Muslim subjects, as tolerated outsiders in the empire they helped sustain. By 1831, however, these obligations had expanded beyond their original terms.

According to the petition, villagers were now required to supply charcoal not only to the Mint (*Darbhâne-i Âmire*) but also to the Imperial Bombardiers' Corps (*Humbarahane*) within the same time frame. [21] The petitioners; men such as Kirkor, Agop, and Serkis and many others, described themselves in the formulaic language of imperial subjects as poor subjects (*reâyâ-yı fukarâ kulları*), yet their complaint was clear: the combined demands of production and transport had exceeded what could reasonably be fulfilled. What appeared in administrative records as a regulated obligation was experienced in practice as an expanding and unsustainable labor burden. Read in this light, the petition shifts from a record of grievance to evidence of the labor and extraction underpinning monetary production, aligning with recent scholarly approaches to money.

Recent scholarship in European financial history has undergone a "monetary turn," in which money is no longer treated as a technical medium of exchange but as social, political and institutional construct. Historians such as Christine Desan have emphasized the role of the state in constituting monetary systems, while David Graeber has foregrounded the social and moral dimensions of debt and value.[22] This body of work has expanded our understanding of money beyond its metallic content or fiscal function, revealing its embeddedness in relations of power, ecology, and labor regimes dimensions that earlier monetary histories largely overlooked.[23]

[21] BOA.C.DRB.00054.0.2662.001. (Date).

[22] Christine Desan, *Making Money : Coin, Currency, and the Coming of Capitalism*. First edition. Oxford, United Kingdom: Oxford University Press, 2015. David Graeber, *Debt : The First 5,000 Years*. Brooklyn, N.Y.: Melville House, 2012.

[23] For instance, see: Philip Rossner, "Peasants, Wars and Evil Coins: Towards a Monetary Turn in Explaining the Revolution of 1525," *German History*, Vol.43, No.1, p.3. Friedrich Engels, *The Peasant War in Germany*. European

By applying a 'monetary turn' to the Ottoman context, I think, we can move beyond viewing money as a mere technical medium of exchange and instead see it as a social and institutional construct embedded in relations of power and labor. The Bardizag case, as this chapter argues, both fits within and extends this trajectory. Existing scholarship on the Mint has tended to focus on institutional and administrative history, leaving aside the question of how monetary production was materially grounded in laboring bodies and ecological resources. Bardizag, I argue, brings this dimension into sharper focus. The charcoal that fueled the Mint's furnaces was not acquired through open markets but supplied by Armenian peasants under fixed obligations and regulated prices. In this sense, monetary production appears not as an abstract financial process but as one embedded in systems of extraction operating at the level of everyday rural life.

In this context, Nilay Özok-Gündoğan conceptualizes Ottoman mining and minting within a framework of extractive colonialism, distinguishing it from settler colonialism. In the absence of settler component, she argues, extractive colonialism is predicated on an interdependent yet fundamentally oppressive and exploitative relationship with the locality.[24] Large-scale extractive projects like mining generate specific institutional forms, social relations, and subjectivities oriented toward maximizing resource extraction.[25] From this perspective, situating extraction at the center of analysis reveals how regions often treated as peripheral were in fact vital to the Ottoman state's military and fiscal needs.

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Politics Books, 2000.

[24] Nilay Özok-Gündoğan, "Extractive Colonialism and State Making in Early Modern Kurdistan," *South Atlantic Quarterly*, Vol.123, Issue 4, p.666.

[25] Halil Sahillioglu, "The Role of International Monetary and Metal Movements in Ottoman Monetary History 1300-1750," Studies in Ottoman Economic and Social History, IRCICA, Istanbul, (1999), p.47.

Her analysis foregrounds how regions such as Kurdistan were integrated into imperial structures through regimes of labor, coercion, and provincial resource mobilization oriented toward silver production for the mint. She brings Potosí mine as an analytically distinctive case, not only its structure of domination but its role in generating a vast commodity frontier: its silver circulated through global markets, reorganizing trade, labor systems, and patterns of accumulation far beyond the site of extraction. Approaching the Ottoman material through this lens opens a productive line of inquiry, yet it also invites further refinement when considered alongside evidence from Bardizag and other regions. The available documentation suggests that resources such as silver and charcoal were directed primarily toward the Imperial Mint, where they were transformed into coinage serving fiscal and military purposes, rather than entering broader commodity circuits. More broadly, this invites comparison with what has been described as commodity frontiers: zones in which environmental exploitation underpinned production and linked localized extraction to the wider expansion of capitalist space through goods such as sugar, silver, gold, tobacco, and grain did in Americas.[26] Seen in this light, the Ottoman case raises the further question of whether its extractive regimes operated within such expansive circuits or remained largely contained within imperial fiscal structures.

Bardizag contributes to this discussion with clarity because once consumed in the Mint's furnaces, its value was realized entirely within the process of coin production in the late 17th and 18th century. This foregrounds a form of extraction that operated less through market expansion than through direct incorporation into state processes **(elaborate more on the class characteristic of the State)**. By shifting attention from mineral wealth to energy and ecological labor, Bardizag broadens the analytical lens and highlights the need to examine how different types of resources

[26] Jason W. Moore, " Sugar and the Expansion of the Early Modern World-Economy: Commodity Frontiers, Ecological Transformation, and Industrialization," *Review (Fernand Braudel Center)*, Vol.23, No.3 (2000), p.411

shaped the relationship between empire, economy, and environment. This argument directs our attention to the material foundations of monetary production, beginning with the ecological landscape that made sustained extraction possible.

While money is understood as a social and political construct, such constructs nonetheless depend on material conditions. In Nicomedia, those conditions were ecological: charcoal derived from the region's forests was an indispensable input in the minting process, making forest management inseparable from monetary production.

**The Forest Ecology of the Nicomedia Region**

The region surrounding Nicomedia (current day Kocaeli/Izmit) was historically one of the most densely forested landscapes of northwestern Anatolia.[27] The mountains and valleys of the Kocaeli peninsula were covered with extensive woodlands composed of pine, oak, juniper and linden, forming an ecological environment well suited to the production of both timber and charcoal. The dense of woodlands of the Nicomedia region, famously described as "Sea of Trees" (*Agac Denizi*), functioned as a strategic ecological hinterland that linked rural landscapes directly to the material reproduction of the imperial capital.[28] This characterization appears in the travel account of Evliya Celebi, who recorded his impressions while traveling through the region in the seventeenth century. After crossing the bridge north of Izmit along the Sakarya River, he described entering an immense forest whose dense shade disoriented travelers unfamiliar with its terrain. According to Celebi, those who lost their way in this wooded expanse sometimes fell prey to wild

[27] Berk Koc, "Locals and Migrants in the late Ottoman Empire: A Study of State-Society and Intercommunal Relations in the Izmit District, 1877-1914," Unpublished Dissertation, Bogazici University, p.195.

[28] Resul Narin, "Osmanlidan Cumhuriyete Agac Denizi Kocaeli," p.971-5. Selçuk Dursun, "Forest and the State: History of Forestry and Forest in the Ottoman Empire," (Unpublished Dissertation, Sabanci University, 2007), p.126-128.

animals, while the air itself was thick with the scent of laurel, juniper, pine, and linden blossoms.[29] His account captures both the scale and the ecological richness of the forests that covered the Nicomedia hinterland. The forest that appeared to outside travelers as a disorienting wilderness was, for local inhabitants, a deeply familiar landscaped of labor and subsistence. This contrast between external perception and local knowledge would become increasingly consequential as imperial demands on the region intensified.

From the perspective of the Ottoman state, these forests were not merely a wilderness but a vital reservoir of timber and fuel that required strict administrative regulation to ensure the stability of the Imperial institutions. As Resul Narin notes, the Kocaeli region long stood out for its abundant woodland resources, which made it one of the empire's principal zones of timber extraction. For centuries these forests supplied the timber required for naval construction for the Imperial Shipyard (*Tersâne-i Âmire*), as well as for other state-affiliated shipyards and workshops. Studies by Idris Bostan likewise emphasize the centrality of the Kocaeli forests to provisioning of Ottoman naval infrastructure.[30] Timber extraction and trade therefore constituted one of the principal economic activities in the region. From the perspective of the Ottoman state, however, timber was not merely a commodity but a strategic resource. To safeguard its supply, the government imposed strict regulations prohibiting the sale of timber abroad or to private merchants; measures that, while aimed at securing state access to essential materials, also generated widespread smuggling, particularly in inland areas where administrative oversight was limited.

[29] Umit Ekin, " Evliya Celebi Seyahatnamesi'nde Kocaeli," Madde no:445, *Kocaeli Ansiklopedisi.* https://kocaeliansiklopedisi.com/Default/MaddeDetay/445 (Accessed Date: 10/05/2026)

[30] Idris Bostan*, Osmanli Bahriye Teskilati: XVII. Yuzyilda Tersane-i Amire.* (Ankara: Turk Tarih Kurumu Basim Evi, 1992).

Beyond shipbuilding, the forests of Kocaeli sustained the everyday rhythms of the imperial capital itself. The region served as one of the principal supply zones for Istanbul's firewood, providing fuel for domestic heating, bakeries, and a range of artisanal workshops. Forest products were also allocated to specific groups of craftsmen and used in the manufacture of household goods. In this sense, the forests of the Nicomedia hinterland formed an essential ecological hinterland of the Ottoman capital, linking rural landscapes directly to the material reproduction of urban life. Within this broader forest economy, Bardizag occupied a particularly advantageous position. Located within the wooded uplands of the Kocaeli peninsula close to the Sea of Marmara, the village combined abundant access to forest resources with relatively easy maritime transport to the capital. Pine wood from the surrounding mountains could be converted into charcoal and shipped efficiently to Istanbul, making Bardizag an ideal supply zone for the fuel demands of the Imperial Mint. The forests of the Nicomedia region thus formed the frontier of a wider imperial energy system in which woodlands, rural labor, and urban institutions were tightly and durably interconnected.

The patterns of extraction, conflict, and depletion visible in the Nicomedia region were not unique to Nicomedia; they reflect a broader dynamic that has increasingly drawn the attention of Ottoman environmental historians. To understand what these pressures meant specifically for Bardizag's peasant community, it is necessary to examine the legal categories that structured forest across the empire more broadly. Recent scholarship in Ottoman environmental history has shifted focus toward the governance of natural resources, particularly forests, and the ways forest policies restructured rural livelihoods. Central to this literature is the distinction between forest categories and their associated rights. *Cibal-i mubaha* forests; unenclosed; publicly accessible state-owned lands, functioned as commons that supported subsistence activities such as grazing, fuelwood

collection, and small-scale production. Even though legally held by the state, they were traditionally open to local use, reflecting a regime of permissive, customary access. Scholars including Selçuk Dursun, Önder Eren Akgül, and Başak Akgül have demonstrated that nineteenth century Ottoman reforms progressively redefined these forests as economic and strategic assets, restricting customary use and transforming formerly open-access lands into legally defined state property. [31]

Ottoman environmental governance relied on hierarchical legal categories, such as the distinction between state and commons, to prioritize state extractive needs over local customary access. The experience of Armenian peasants in Bardizag both complicates and extends this historiographical narrative. Unlike communities relying on commons, Bardizag's peasants depended on *cibal-i şahâne* or mostly known as *miri* forests, a category of state-owned woodland under direct imperial control, where access was formally restricted than customarily permitted. Seasonal grazing one of the central pillars of Bardizag's rural economy was explicitly prohibited in these miri forests.[32] The conflict over forest access in Bardizag thus reveals that environmental dispossession was not solely a product of privatization or commercialization, but also of the enforcement of hierarchical legal categories that determined who could access essential ecological resources and on what terms.

The enforcement of restricted access in Bardizag illustrates that environmental dispossession was often driven by the state's need to secure essential ecological resources for its metallurgical operations. Integrating Bardizag into this broader debate makes clear that Ottoman

[31] Onur Inal, "Environmental History as an Emerging Field in Ottoman Studies: An Historiographical Overview," p.22, Önder Eren Akgül, "Bati Anadolu'da Keresteciler, Koyluler ve Musterekler: Koskoca Bir Ormanin Tahribi ve Imhasi,", *Toplumsal Tarih*, p.50-57. Başak Akgül Kovankaya, " Negotiating nature: ecology, politics, and nomadism in the forests of Mediterranean Anatolia, 1870-1920," (Unpublished dissertation, Leiden University, 2019), p.58.

[32] Süleyman Pekin and Murat Bayram. *Bahçecik Tarihi*. (Ankara: Berikan yayıncılık, 2011), p.56.

Forest administration cannot be understood merely as a technical or economic reform. It was, rather, a. state-mediated process of environmental governance that reshaped customary rights and subsistence strategies in ways that varied significantly according to forest classification and local social structure. The natural conditions of the Nicomedia region its dense forests, accessible coastline, and proximity to Istanbul made Bardizag uniquely suited to supply the fuel that sustained the metallurgical operations of the Imperial Mint. [33] Yet those same conditions drew the village ever more deeply into an imperial system that, over time, eroded the customary foundations on which its rural economy depended.

The 1803 decree exempting Bardizag with Yuvacık and Yeniköy, from firewood delivery to Istanbul, was not a neutral administrative act but an instrument of proto-industrial labor discipline designed to bind the village exclusively to charcoal production.[34] This exemption reveals the village's strategic place within the Ottoman imperial provisioning and energy regime, particularly in relation to the Imperial Mint. While many settlements in the İznikmid region were mobilized to cut and transport firewood to meet the capital's growing fuel demands, Bardizag was reserved to produce pine charcoal (*kömür istihsali*), a specialized fuel required for metallurgical processes at the mint. Expressed in the absolutist legal idiom of forbidden in every respect (*min kulli'l-wujūh mamnū'*) the prohibitions (*men' ve ref'*) against firewood cutting and transport (*hatab kat' ve nakli*), and the felling of trees of any kind were not incidental regulations but instruments of labor control. Their purpose was precisely to prevent the diversion of productive capacity away from the state's extractive priorities. The villagers were not free to respond to alternative demands, local needs, or market incentives; they were bound to a single, imperially determined use of their

[33] BOA: C.DRB. 12/2/1190, BOA: C.DRB. 09/B/1204, BOA: C.ML. 29/L/1240

[34] Nurullah Demir, *219 Nolu Muhimme Defterinin Transkripsiyon ve Degerlendirilmesi.* (Ed.) Dr.Kazim Kartal, Serpil Sevim Kartal, (Ankara: Iksad Yayinevi, 2019), p.188.

labor and their environment. That the Sultan explicitly declared zero tolerance for any disruption to this supply chain only underscores the stakes: the reproduction of the Ottoman monetary order was understood to depend directly on the unfreedom of these communities. (Armenian soldiers returning official document ekle) These restrictions reveal a clear logic of proto-industrial labor discipline, in which the state actively organized and fixed rural populations into specialized productive roles. Rather than reflecting a neutral administrative rationality, this arrangement underscores the extent to which the Ottoman provincial economy was structured to extract and stabilize resources essential to the reproduction of imperial power.

Viewed through the lens of environmental and labor history, the decree points to a differentiated regime of resource extraction and labor allocation. Ottoman authorities did not treat forests merely as reservoirs of raw materials; rather, they governed them as productive landscapes in which specific communities were assigned specialized tasks. By restricting the villagers' participation in alternative seasonal work and binding them exclusively to charcoal production, the state structured the temporal rhythms and spatial organization of rural labor. The decree also illuminates a stark hierarchy within the Ottoman provisioning system: even as Istanbul faced an acute shortage of firewood, the uninterrupted supply of charcoal for mint operations was deemed more critical still. Bardizag thus emerged as a controlled node within the empire's energy infrastructure, a place where the management of forests, fuel, and labor converged to sustain the fiscal and metallurgical operations of the imperial state. The forest supplied the fuel, but fuel does not move itself. The Amiras are the missing term in that equation; the human infrastructure through which timber became charcoal, charcoal became coin, and a landscape became a monetary system.

The 1803 decree exempting Bardizag, together with Yuvacık and Yeniköy, from the delivery of firewood to Istanbul was not a neutral administrative act but an instrument of labor

discipline designed to bind the village more tightly to charcoal production.[14] This exemption reveals the village's strategic place within the Ottoman imperial provisioning and energy regime, particularly in relation to the Imperial Mint. While other settlements in the İznikmid region were mobilized to cut and transport firewood to meet Istanbul's growing fuel demands, Bardizag was increasingly reserved for the production of pine charcoal (*kömür istihsali*), a specialized fuel required for metallurgical operations at the mint. Expressed in the absolutist legal idiom of *min kulli'l-vujūh mamnū'*—"forbidden in every respect"—the prohibitions (*men' ve ref'*) against cutting and transporting firewood (*hatab kat' ve nakli*), as well as against felling trees, were not incidental regulations but instruments for controlling the allocation of rural labor and ecological resources. Their effect was to prevent villagers from diverting their productive capacity toward alternative forms of subsistence, exchange, or resource use. The decree therefore did more than regulate forests: it organized the social conditions under which peasant labor could be performed.

This distinction between the labor process and the social relations governing that labor process is crucial for understanding the character of charcoal production in Bardizag. The immediate labor process remained largely preindustrial: pine was cut, stacked, carbonized, transported, and loaded onto ships using techniques that did not require a factory or mechanized production. What changed was the organization and social purpose of that labor. The state increasingly determined what was to be produced, how much was required, when it had to be produced, where it had to be delivered, which communities were responsible for supplying it, which forests could be used, and the terms under which producers would be compensated. The peasants thus remained direct producers, retaining substantial control over the immediate techniques of production, while increasingly losing control over the conditions and purposes toward which their labor was directed. The distinction is significant: the Ottoman state did not

industrialize the charcoal-producing labor process technologically; it increasingly subordinated that labor process to an externally imposed regime of imperial provisioning.

The earlier documentary record makes clear that this organization of labor preceded the 1803 decree. The archival document dated **H. 12.02.1190**—more than a decade before the 1803 regulation—already presents charcoal provisioning as a long-established and administratively structured obligation. The document places the production of pine charcoal among the **"azam-ı umûr"** of the Darbhâne-i Âmire, and explicitly identifies the inhabitants of **Kocaeli Sancağı, Bahçecik, Yeniköy, and other villages** as communities that had long been engaged in cutting charcoal from the mountains, transporting it according to established arrangements, loading it onto ships, and sending it to the *Âsitâne-i Saâdet*. The language is significant because the villagers are not described as independent producers who happened to participate in a charcoal market. Their labor is presented as part of an established provisioning relationship connecting named villages to specific imperial institutions. The document further warns that failure to provide sufficient quantities could result in **"tatil-i kâr,"** a suspension or disruption of the work, thereby making clear that the regularity of production was itself an administrative concern.

Most revealingly, the document specifies an annual requirement of **20,000 abâr of pine charcoal**, requiring that the quantity be prepared and brought to the port **before winter**, loaded onto ships, and dispatched to Istanbul. The producers were to receive their **customary payment in full**. These details expose the organizational structure of the labor process with unusual clarity. Production was not simply encouraged by the state; it was quantified, temporally regulated, spatially directed, and connected to a fixed circuit of transport and payment. The phrase specifying that not even a negligible shortfall was to occur—**"mikdâr-ı zerre taksîrât"** in the terminology of the document—further underscores the expectation of complete

fulfillment. The annual quota therefore functioned not merely as a measure of fiscal revenue but as a mechanism through which the state synchronized dispersed household labor with the material requirements of imperial institutions.

The document also makes visible the logistical infrastructure through which this labor was organized. Charcoal had to move from forest production sites to the port, from the port onto ships, and from there to Istanbul. The receiving institutions extended beyond the Darbhâne-i Âmire itself to include the **Tophâne** and **Simkeşhâne**, demonstrating that Bardizag's charcoal production formed part of a broader network of imperial metallurgical and manufacturing establishments. The state therefore depended upon a chain linking forest resources, village households, transport routes, ports, shipping, and urban workshops. What appears at first glance to be a simple commodity—pine charcoal—was in fact the product of a highly differentiated labor process extending across rural and urban space.

The record further names the individuals who stood between the state's requirements and rural production. **Beyzullah Ağa of Karamürsel**, who had undertaken the work before his death, was responsible for cutting and preparing the charcoal, bringing it to the port, loading it onto ships, and sending it to Istanbul. After him, **Ömer Reis**, together with the inhabitants of Karamürsel, assumed the same responsibilities, undertaking to prepare the charcoal before winter, deliver it in accordance with the established arrangements, and receive the customary payment. These figures demonstrate that the extraction of labor and resources was mediated rather than accomplished through direct bureaucratic supervision of every household. Intermediaries organized the movement between imperial demand and dispersed rural production. The relationship was therefore neither a purely local exchange nor a simple

administrative command from Istanbul; it was a structured chain of command, coordination, and appropriation in which different social actors occupied distinct positions.

The later references within the same record to **1266 Muharrem 15** and **1276 Rebîü'l-âhir 15** further indicate the persistence of this institutional framework over time. These later dates should not be collapsed into the document's heading date of **H. 12.02.1190**; rather, they point to subsequent administrative arrangements through which the obligation to supply charcoal continued to be organized. Taken together, the dated references show that charcoal provisioning was not an episodic response to a temporary fiscal emergency. It was embedded in an institutional continuity through which the state repeatedly organized rural production around the requirements of imperial establishments.

What the 1803 decree therefore accomplished was not the creation of a new labor regime but the further specialization and spatial closure of an already established one. By exempting Bardizag, Yuvacık, and Yeniköy from the delivery of firewood while prohibiting alternative forms of wood cutting and transport, the state narrowed the range of productive activities available to these communities and reinforced their specialization in charcoal production. The earlier **H. 12.02.1190** document establishes the existence of the provisioning infrastructure; the 1803 decree demonstrates how the state increasingly protected and insulated that infrastructure from competing demands on village labor and forest resources. The two documents should therefore be read together: the earlier record reveals the organization of production, transport, quota, payment, and intermediaries, while the later decree reveals the increasingly coercive regulation of the conditions under which that production could occur.

Seen in these terms, Bardizag's charcoal economy was neither ordinary market exchange nor simply a form of taxation. It represented a mode of **imperial administrative discipline**

**imposed upon peasant production**. The coercive force of the system did not depend on transforming peasants into wage workers. Rather, it operated through legal restrictions on forest access, specialized fiscal obligations, administrative quotas, seasonal deadlines, regulated prices, and sanctions for failure to meet the state's requirements. This was **extra-economic coercion**: labor was secured not primarily through the worker's sale of labor-power, but through the political and legal authority of the state over land, forests, taxation, and village obligations. A household could therefore remain outside the wage relation while its labor was nevertheless subjected to increasingly systematic forms of external command.

(Socrates Petmesaz protoindustrial makale oku!)

This is why the language of **proto-industrial organization of peasant labor** is more precise than the claim that Bardizag peasants themselves had become "proto-industrial workers." The industrial quality of the system lay not in machinery or factory production but in the increasing regularity, specialization, coordination, and discipline of production. The household remained the immediate unit of labor, yet its labor was increasingly synchronized with the requirements of distant imperial institutions. The annual **20,000-abâr** requirement, the deadline **before winter**, the prescribed route from forest to port to Istanbul, the institutional destinations at the Darbhâne-i Âmire, Tophâne, and Simkeşhâne, and the expectation of full delivery without *taksîrât* transformed dispersed rural labor into a coordinated provisioning chain. The forest household was therefore incorporated into a larger division of labor without being fully proletarianized.

The distinction also complicates a linear model in which coercion necessarily produces factories, wage labor, and then capitalism. Bardizag demonstrates another historical possibility: **peasant production could be subjected to increasingly systematic labor**

**discipline without the disappearance of the peasant producer**. The state could extract labor from households while leaving intact many of the technical and social forms of peasant production. What changed was the degree to which those households could determine the allocation of their own labor and the purposes to which their ecological resources were put. The result was not capitalist wage discipline but a form of imperial labor discipline in which political authority reorganized peasant production around the material requirements of the fiscal and metallurgical state.

From this perspective, restrictions on forest use and obligations to produce charcoal were two sides of the same process. The state was not merely controlling a resource; it was reorganizing access to a **means of production** and, through that reorganization, shaping the conditions under which labor could be reproduced. The forest became an administratively governed productive landscape, while the village became a specialized laboring community within the imperial provisioning system. Bardizag's incorporation into the Ottoman monetary economy thus depended not on the displacement of peasant production by industry, but on the state's capacity to subordinate an existing peasant labor process to the demands of imperial extraction.

[14] Nurullah Demir, *219 Nolu Mühimme Defterinin Transkripsiyon ve Değerlendirilmesi*, ed. Kazım Kartal and Serpil Sevim Kartal (Ankara: İksad Yayınları, 2019), 188.

[15] BOA, C.DRB.0046-2281, **H. 12.02.1190**. The same document contains later chronological references to **1266 Muharrem 15** and **1276 Rebîü'l-âhir 15**.

**The Managers of Value : The *Amira*s and the Mint**

The Armenian amiras acted as a distinct class fraction that bridged the gap between the imperial center and rural periphery, reorganizing local economies to meet material requirements of

the mint. Armenian amiras, also, dominated imperial finance, international trade, and monetary administration, occupying a strategic position between the state, markets, and global flows of capital.[35] Their power did not derive simply from wealth but from their ability to manage the contradictions inherent in money itself, between commodity and state, value and circulation, trust and coercion. Following Suleiman, the Magnificent's 1554 campaign against Persia, Armenian bankers of noble descent from the Armenian Kingdom of Van were relocated from Egin to Hasköy in Istanbul.[36] Wealthy and financially skilled, they secured privileged roles at the Ottoman court, as bankers and officials, including head of the Imperial Mint, while also gaining influence within Armenian community. In recognition of their service, they received honors and titles as "Hacı," "Hoca," and "Çelebi," and were known among Armenians as "Ishkhan," (Prince). [37]

The career of Artin Amira Kazaz highlights the convergence of financial authority and material control, showing how high-level monetary policies like currency debasement translated into intensified labor demands in the forests of Bardizag. Born in 1771, Kazaz attended the patriarchal school in Kumkapı from the age of seven, learning Armenian, calligraphy, and arithmetic.[38] He later apprenticed with a silk merchant in the Grand Bazaar, earning the nickname

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[35] Onnik Jamgocyan, *Les Banquiers Des Sultans : Juifs, Francs, Grecs et Arméniens de La Haute Finance : Constantinople, 1650-1850*. (Paris: Les Editions du Bosphore, 2013). *Finance et Diplomatie Dans Le Levant : Un Recueil d'Articles Sur L'historie Financière et Diplomatique Ottomane*. (Ed.) Sadık Müfit Bilge and Serkan Keçeci. (İstanbul: Kitabevi Yayinlari, 2024), p.99-105. Pascal Carmont, and Bernard Dorin. *The Amiras : Lords of Ottoman Armenia*. Translated by Marika Blandin. (London: Taderon Press., 2012). Archag Alboyadjian, Les Dadian, (Le Caire, 1965), p.39.

[36] Ali Yaycioglu, " Perdenin Arkasindakiler: Osmanli Imparatorlugu'nda Sarraflar ve Finans Aglari Uzerine Bir Deneme," *Journal of Turkish Studies*, Vol.52, December 2019, p.376-7.

[37] Saro Dadyan, "Osmanli Ermenilerinin Tarihindeki En Buyuk Filantrop Kazaz Artin Amira Bezciyan," *Toplumsal Tarih*, 225 Eylul 2012, p.22. Saro Dadyan, "Ermeni Cemaatinin Uc Asirlik Liderleri Amiralar ve Haskoy," Osmanli Istanbulu IV, p.271

[38] Arsen Yarman, and Ara Akinean. *Sultan II. Mahmud Ve Kazaz Artin Amira*. (Ed.) Ali Çakmak. Translated by T'ovmas T'erzyan. (İstanbul: Surp Pırgiç Ermeni Hastanesi Vakfı Kültür Yayınları. 2013).

"Kazaz" ; the silk merchant.[39] By the age of twenty-four he owned his own shop. In 1802, Ohannes Çelebi Düzyan, then head of the Imperial Mint, appointed him to manage the silk concession, drawing Kazaz into the circles of leading financiers and palace officials.[40] His ascent was rapid. Following the outbreak of the Greek rebellion in 1821, the formerly privileged Greek community lost its standing and was progressively excluded from the imperial bureaucracy. As Greek influence declined, Armenians rose to a more favored position, and Kazaz Artin's close relationship with Sultan Mahmud II contributed directly to Armenians being granted the designation of "Loyal Subjects". After returning from a period of exile, he was appointed to manage the Imperial Mint alongside Bogos Amira Bilezikçiyan, and by 1823 he held full responsibility for both the Imperial Mint and the Imperial Treasury. Appointed chief of the imperial mint (*ifrazcibasi*) in 1819 and serving simultaneously as *sarraf* of the Sultan's privy purse and imperial foundations, Kazaz was dismissed and reinstated multiple times; a pattern that itself reflects the structural dependence of the Ottoman state on financial expertise it could neither fully internalize nor dispense with.

His most consequential intervention came in the aftermath of the Ottoman–Russian War of 1828–1829. The reparations owed to Russia were divided into three installments.[41] Damat Halil Pasha was dispatched to Saint Petersburg with substantial gifts, and the tsar agreed to waive the first installment. When funds for the second installment could not be raised, Kazaz Artin responded by increasing the copper content of the coinage, effectively devaluing the currency and generating substantial revenue for the state, while simultaneously securing payment through loans negotiated

[39] Aviv Derri, The Ottoman Sarraf, Public Debt, and Usury Laws: Rethinking Capitalism and Empire beyond Anomalies, Comparative Studies in Society and History (2025), 67: 4, 916–942

[40] Hagop Levon Barsoumian, I*stanbul'un Ermeni Amiralar Sınıfı*. (İstanbul: Aras Yayincilik, 2013).

[41] Sevket Pamuk, "Debased European Coinage in the Ottoman Empire," p.351-6. Sevket Pamuk, *A Monetary History of the Ottoman Empire,* p.199.

with European bankers. In recognition of these services, Mahmud II awarded him the *Order of the Imperial Portrait*, the empire's highest distinction, making him the only non-Muslim in Ottoman history to receive this honor.[42] Rising through the ranks of the guild of moneychangers (*sarraf*), I argue, Kazaz embodied the social function that Marx attributes to money's managers: the capacity to mediate between market exchange and political authority, between the commodity form of money and its character as an instrument of state power.

In Bardizag, this meditating function took a concrete and consequential form. By the late seventeenth century, charcoal production had been introduced through the collaboration of Ottoman provincial authorities and local Armenian leaders. Over time, however, this activity was transformed from an auxiliary practice into a specialized and increasingly obligatory form of labor.[43] It was in the eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries, under the expanding coordination of the amiras, that this transformation acquired a more systematic and durable character. Production was no longer oriented toward local consumption or flexible exchange, but toward the regularized provisioning of a central institution: the Imperial Mint.

This reorganization involved several interrelated shifts. First, production was standardized through recurring cycles of timber extraction, carbonization, and transport. Second, it was centralized, with charcoal directed to a single state-controlled site of consumption. Third, and most significantly, it was administratively regulated: output quotas and prices were fixed, limiting producers' ability to respond to ecological conditions or market changes. In this sense, what

[42] Ibid.

43 Grigor Mkhalean, and Ara Stepan Melkonian. 2014. Bardizag and Its People. London: Gomidas Institute., p.107. Omerul Faruk Bolukbasi, *18. Yüzyılın Ikinci Yarısında Darbhâne-I Âmire*. 1. baskı. İstanbul: İstanbul Bilgi Üniversitesi Yayınları. 2013. "Reading Ottoman Mining Through Ottoman Imperial Mint Registers: Silver Production of the Ottoman Empire in the Second Half of the The XVIII. Century / Osmanlı Madenciliğini Darphane Defterleri Üzerinden Okumak: XVIII. Yüzyılın İkinci Yarısında Osmanlı Devleti'nde Gümüş Üretimi," Turkish Journal History, 2002.

appeared as fiscal privilege; tax exemption, was in fact a restructuring of obligation that bound local producers to a specific form of labor under externally imposed conditions.

The role of the amiras was critical to this process. Operating from the imperial center, they coordinated the alignment between monetary policy and material supply. Their activities encompassed not only financial management but also the organization of logistical networks through which resources such as charcoal could be mobilized, transported, and delivered in accordance with the needs of the mint. The career of Artin Amira Kazaz illustrates this function with particular clarity. Rising from the guild of moneychangers to occupy leading positions within both the Imperial Mint and the treasury, Kazaz embodied the convergence of financial authority and control over material provisioning.

While often treated in historiography as primarily monetary or fiscal measures, such policies had direct material implications. Through the coordinating mechanisms overseen by the amiras, these demands were transmitted to regions such as Bardizag, where production was correspondingly intensified. The apparent abstraction of monetary policy thus rested on a concrete expansion of labor and resource extraction at the local level.

From this perspective, Bardizag's integration into imperial monetary structures was neither incidental nor merely administrative. It constituted a process of spatial and social reorganization, through which a rural locality became a specialized zone of production within a broader system of accumulation. The amiras played a decisive role in this transformation, mediating between the coercive power of the state and the productive capacities of rural society. Their influence derived not simply from proximity to imperial authority, but from their ability to manage the relationship between circulation and production linking the mint as a site of monetary abstraction to the forest as a site of material labor.

This reorganization entailed several interrelated shifts. First, production was standardized through the imposition of recurring cycles of timber extraction, controlled carbonization, and transport. Second, it was centralized, insofar as charcoal was directed toward a single, state-oriented site of consumption. Third, and most significantly, it was administratively regulated: both output quotas and prices were fixed, eliminating any possibility of negotiation or market participation by the producers themselves. Nineteenth-century debasement did not merely alter the metallic content of coinage; it increased the volume of production required at the mint, thereby intensifying demand for charcoal. Meeting this demand required the concentration of fuel production in a region capable of sustained output, and it was through the coordinating mechanisms of the amiras that Bardizag was constituted as that dedicated supply zone. The success of the debasements of 1828–31 widely regarded by contemporaries as a stabilizing achievement — rested not simply on monetary policy but on the amiras' capacity to hold together the tension between money as a commodity grounded in labor and money as an instrument of state authority: a tension made concrete in the act of fixing the price of a kilogram of charcoal.

The amiras can thus be understood as key agents in the historical realization of the money form. Occupying a structurally indispensable yet politically subordinate position, they mediated between state authority and material production—coordinating mining outputs, mobilizing credit, and organizing the supply chains that linked provincial extraction zones such as Bardizag to the imperial center. Their influence derived not simply from proximity to imperial authority, but from their ability to manage the relationship between circulation and production, linking the mint as a site of monetary abstraction to the forest as a site of material labor. From the imperial center, they translated the abstract imperatives of monetary policy into concrete systems of rural extraction by regulating prices, enforcing quotas, and ensuring continuous delivery. In this configuration, the

mint emerges as an institution that organized not only resources but social relations, with administrative and financial elites at the apex, amiras at the center, and coerced rural and mining labor at the base. The case of Bardizag makes this relationship visible: the stability of imperial currency depended not only on fiscal policy or metallic supply, but on the ongoing reorganization of local economies and ecologies in service of the mint.

When Kazaz Artin adjusted the alloy ratios of Ottoman coinage to meet war reparation obligations, the decision was recorded as a technical fiscal measure. But monetary policy of this kind was never purely technical: it had a labor cost, and that cost was borne by specific people in specific places. A higher copper content required more smelted metal, more charcoal, more kilns, and more hours of human labor. In Bardizag, this was not experienced as a shift in alloy composition but as a direct intensification of working conditions: time diverted from subsistence agriculture, nights spent tending fires, bodies subordinated to the demands of imperial finance. Workers who had no voice in the reparation negotiations, and no stake in the monetary system their labor sustained, absorbed the cost of decisions made far above them. The following section examines how this labor dynamics operated in practice; who performed this work, under what conditions, and how the demands placed on charcoal producers shifted in response to monetary pressures beyond their control.

**The Labor of Money: Extraction vs. Subsistence**

This section examines how imperial provisioning functioned at the local level through the case of Bardizag's Armenian peasants. It argues what appeared in administrative terms as fiscal privilege and rational economic policy in fact concealed a system of indirect extraction grounded in coerced labor, ecological strain, and uneven burdens. By shifting perspective from imperial regulation to rural experience, the analysis reveals how provisioning depended not simply on

monetary policy, but on the continuous mobilization of labor and natural resources under increasingly fragile conditions.

At first glance, the relative exemption of the region's Armenian peasantry from certain standard tax burdens might appear, at first glance, to suggest a lighter form of subordination. In practice, however, the "fiscal privilege" of tax exemption (*muafiyet*) functioned as a mechanism of indirect extraction that reconfigured rural obligations into a specialized and grueling form of coerced labor. Bardizag's peasants were, in a sense, released from one regime of extraction only to be bound more tightly to another; one whose demands were inscribed not in tax registers but in the rhythms of agricultural work, charcoal production, and transport. The Bardizag case illuminates what a purely fiscal or monetary lens tends to obscure: that the stabilization of monetary systems depends, ultimately, on the organized exertion of human labor embedded in specific ecological conditions.

This restructuring operated through the system of conditional exemption, which functioned as a central mechanism of indirect extraction. Rather than imposing direct taxation, the state relieved certain communities of fiscal dues in exchange for specific productive services. In Bardizag, Armenian peasants were incorporated into imperial provisioning systems through regimes of compelled labor formalized as tax exemptions. These exemptions, known as *muafiyet*, did not relieve obligation but restructured it, binding households to the production and transport of charcoal. Through timber cutting, kiln work, and supply chains feeding the mint, peasant labor became the hidden energy base of monetary circulation.[44] The charcoal needed by the Imperial Mint was usually made from pine and oak, and sometimes from fir and alder. The mint required

[44] Omerul Faruk Bolukbasi, "Darbhane-i Amire`nin Yakacak Ihtiyacinin Temininde Kocaeli`nin Yeri ve Onemi," p.558-9.

20,000 units of charcoal annually. Sources indicate that a "unit" refers to a sack of charcoal, but the exact weight it corresponds to is not specified.

The stability of the Ottoman provisioning system rested on the assumption of “rural elasticity”, yet the overlapping demands of charcoal production and the agricultural calendar often pushed peasant households to their breaking point. As a result, peasant households faced competing claims on their labor, forced to divert time away from subsistence production to meet state requirements. What appeared administratively as a fixed obligation translated in practice into fluctuating and often intensifying pressures on rural labor, particularly in moments of heightened demand. At the local level, these policies also translated into intense pressures on time and labor. The burden of charcoal production was not solely economic but also temporal, intersecting directly with the agricultural calendar. Obligations frequently coincided with peak periods of cultivation and harvest, forcing Armenian peasant households to navigate competing demands on their labor. Time that would otherwise have been devoted to subsistence production was instead redirected toward meeting state requirements.

In this light, the petition does more than document local grievance; it exposes the limits of an extractive system predicated on the continuous conversion of forest resources and peasant labor into energy for the imperial center. The state’s capacity to maintain stable supply—and, by extension, the functioning of institutions dependent on that supply—rested on the expectation that rural communities could absorb escalating demands without structural breakdown. The voices from Bahçecik and Yuvacık suggest that by the mid-nineteenth century, this expectation was no longer sustainable. petition exposes a structural tension within the provisioning framework. While state policy treated charcoal supply as a stable and regulated component of imperial economy, rural producers experienced it as an increasingly rigid and burdensome service. Charcoal embodied

accumulated labor: the cutting of timber, the controlled burning of wood, and the costly transport of fuel to urban centers. Each delivery thus represented not merely a commodity, but the materialization of peasant labor time redirected toward sustaining imperial institutions in Istanbul.

Read alongside fiscal regulations, the petition reveals the asymmetry embedded in state-centered accounts of economic governance. Administrative records register compliance, delivery quotas, and price schedules; they rarely capture labor exhaustion, ecological degradation, or subsistence strain. The 1831 petition, by contrast, foregrounds precisely these dimensions, making visible the lived consequences of imperial policy. It demonstrates that the sustainability of provisioning systems depended on assumptions about rural elasticity—assumptions that peasants themselves explicitly contested.

These tensions are clearly articulated in a petition from 1831. identifying themselves as "poor subjects," the Armenian petitioners from Bahçecik and Yuvacık invoked their long-standing exemption from all taxes except the *cizye*. In practice, however, this nominal privilege imposed a disproportionate burden on Armenian shoulders: they were required to supply charcoal for the Imperial Mint while simultaneously being compelled to provision the *Humbarahane* within the same period. They argued that they lacked both the financial means and the labor capacity to meet this obligation—limitations they stressed were already known to the authorities. While their tone remained deferential, the petition capture labor exhaustion in the region.

Read in context, the petition reveals a fundamental contradiction. What the state framed as a stable and regulated supply, rural producers experienced as rigid and increasingly burdensome. Each delivery of charcoal embodied not just fuel, but the accumulated labor of cutting, burning, and transport. Yet fixed quotas and prices failed to adjust to changing conditions such as forest

depletion, rising costs, and monetary instability. As a result, what appeared as administrative order at the center translated into deepening impoverishment in the villages. This document foregrounds those lived realities, revealing that the sustainability of imperial provisioning depended on assumptions about the elasticity of rural labor and resources—assumptions that peasants themselves directly challenged.

A reproduction crisis emerged when the state's escalating demand for surplus extraction began to undermine the very material and social foundations required for rural life to sustain itself. Yet when surplus extraction undermined the material basis of rural life, its limits became visible. The peasants' appeal made explicit what administrative records concealed: the sustainability of imperial sovereignty depended on finite labor and finite forests. Although Armenian peasants in Bardizag benefited from certain fiscal privileges, including tax exemptions associated with charcoal production, these arrangements did not necessarily produce equitable outcomes. Archival petitions from villagers indicate that such privileges were frequently undermined by local intermediaries and regional elites. Moreover, the production quotas imposed on village households often exceeded their economic and time management capacity, placing considerable strain on both labor and local resources.

From this perspective, Bardizag complicates the harmonious image of provisionism often implied in the historiography. Rather than operating solely as a stabilizing mechanism designed to protect consumers and maintain economic balance, provisioning policies could also generate forms of extraction that placed disproportionate burdens on rural producers. The charcoal production regime demonstrates how imperial provisioning depended not only on administrative regulation but also on the mobilization of village labor and environmental resources.

Ottoman historiography has long interpreted imperial economic governance through the concept of provisionism. As defined by Mehmet Genç, provisionism sought to ensure the steady availability of essential goods for urban consumers and state institutions by maintaining abundance, acceptable quality, and affordable prices. In practice, the state rarely attempted to control production directly; rather, it intervened selectively when the supply of strategic commodities appeared threatened.[45] Within this paradigm, rural obligations to supply strategic goods such as charcoal appear as rational mechanisms designed to stabilize markets and prevent scarcity; instruments of economic balance viewed from the vantage point of imperial administration.

The experience of Bardizag reveals the limits of this framework when viewed from the perspective of rural producers. Provisionism, as an analytical model, assumes a degree of flexibility in its constituent elements: of resources, of labor, of rural society. It presumes that administratively fixed obligations can be maintained without regard to ecological depletion, demographic change, or shifts in production costs. It treats rural producers as a stable reservoir of supply whose capacity to respond to imperial demands can be taken for granted. What the Bardizag evidence demonstrates is that these assumptions did not hold — that the practical operation of provisionism could generate forms of extraction that were coercive, ecologically destructive, and socially destabilizing in ways invisible from the administrative center.

The state's categorization of local disputes is disruption (*fesad*), reveals that the Ottoman administration viewed any threat to charcoal production as a serious challenge to empire's fiscal and institutional stability (elaborate more about the incident; more details). This disruption was particularly significant because the coal was not merely a commodity but an essential resource for

[45] Kazuma Iwata, "Producing, Transporting, and Distributing Charcoal: From the View of the Charcoal Merchants` Guild in the 18th Century in Istanbul and Its Surrounding Regions," YILLIK: Annual of Istanbul Studies 5 (2023). p.124

state operations, including the production of coinage and the execution of imperial decrees. The failure to deliver coal on time threatened the smooth functioning of the mint, highlighting how local disturbances could propagate into broader administrative and fiscal complications.

The exile of a Bardizag villager, Papas Ayraham, underscores the state's reliance on a combination of surveillance and coercion to align provincial resource management with imperial needs.[46] Ottoman officials conducted a thorough inquiry, confirming that he not only orchestrated the immediate disturbance but was also implicated in other destabilizing activities within the village. His actions were classified under the category of disruption which necessitated formal disciplinary measures. By categorizing the behavior in this way, the Ottoman administration signaled that disturbances in local resource management were not minor infractions but serious threats to state authority and institutional function. The response combined punitive and preventive measures. Papas Ayraham and his family were permanently exiled to the Merzivan district under the supervision of the appointed official (*kavvas mubasir*), ensuring that the disruption would not recur and that the coal supply system could be stabilized. The involvement of senior scholars and administrative officials in approving and formalizing the decision through an imperial decree demonstrates the integration of legal, religious, and bureaucratic authority in Ottoman governance. This case underscores the empire`s approach to maintaining order in rural resource management: local actors were held accountable for actions that jeopardized state operations, while interventions aimed to restore administrative efficiency, secure fiscal interests, and provide a public example to deter future misconduct. Overall, this incident reveals how the Ottoman administrative apparatus functioned to align rural production with imperial and fiscal and institutional needs, balancing enforcement, punishment, and oversight to mitigate the risks posed by local disputes. It highlights

[46] BOA: C.DRB.00014.00678.001 (Date).

the empire`s reliance on both formal legal mechanism and social hierarchies to ensure smooth operation of critical state infrastructure, reflecting a governance model that combined coercion, surveillance and structural accountability.

**Conclusion**: This chapter explores the extractive labor regimes and ecological foundations of the Ottoman monetary system through the case of charcoal production in Bardizag. The relationship between monetary policy and environmental extraction becomes particularly visible in periods of fiscal crisis. As Şevket Pamuk has shown, episodes of debasement in the Ottoman Empire were closely linked to the financial pressures generated by warfare and mounting state expenditures. Debasement required the minting of larger quantities of charcoal. As mint activity intensified, demand for charcoal rose accordingly, transforming forested landscapes into critical energy reserves for the imperial monetary system.

The Ottoman case illustrates a specific variation on this dynamic. In regions supplying the Imperial Mint, forests were subject to strict state regulation rather than open market exploitation. Pine forests in the South Marmara region, including Bardizag, were placed under direct imperial supervision. Unauthorized cutting, gazing and smuggling were prohibited, while several intermediaries were granted privileges to control transportation and supply to the mint. In this sense, the Ottoman system functioned as a state-controlled extractive empire: it sought to monopolize access to energy resources, regulate accumulation rates with the help of *Amira*s and prevent third parties from profiting independently, rather than opening forests to unrestricted commercial exploitation. By integrating new forest zones into the infrastructure of minting, the state ensured that energy flows remained under its control, linking ecological management directly to monetary stability.

Ultimately, the mint functioned as a nodal institution that unified "surface and subsoil, forest and furnace" into a single, hierarchical regime of extraction. The miner in Keban, the charcoal producer in Bardizag, and the mint worker in Istanbul are linked not through the abstract equivalence of market exchange, but through a chain of dependency structured by the imperative to produce money. The Ottoman mint thus appears as an institution that unified surface and subsoil, forest and furnace, within a single regime of extraction that organized both the production and realization of value. The Ottoman coins, therefore, was not just a symbol of value but a material condensation of the congealed labor of miners, charcoal producers, and artisans, all subordinated to the imperatives of centralized monetary production. To trace the movement of silver from the mines of Anatolia to the furnaces of Istanbul is therefore to map a system in which money does not stand apart from social relations, but emerges directly from their organization: a material condensation of labor, power, and hierarchy within an imperial political economy.

The **Sanjak of Ismid (İzmit)** appears as a significant contributor to the regional silk economy: in 1895, it produced **617,813 kg of fresh cocoons**, valued at **1,925,325 francs**,

representing roughly **18% of total cocoon production** across the listed sanjaks. It also accounted for **22,893 ounces of silk seed**, indicating that İzmit was an important center of **sericulture and raw-material production** within the wider Bursa economic region.[47]

To modernize local silk production, the Ottoman Public Debt Administration—which collected the silk tithe—established a model silkworm-breeding institute (*magnanerie modèle*) in Bursa in 1888. Directed by a graduate of the Montpellier Sericulture Station, the institute provided theoretical and practical training and helped resolve the regional shortage of skilled silk-egg producers (*graineurs*). As growers in surrounding villages adopted better-ventilated rearing practices and replaced inferior foreign seeds with quality domestic varieties or controlled French imports, local seed production expanded alongside mulberry cultivation.

Statistics compiled by the Public Debt Administration for Bursa, Ismid, and Panderma between 1891 and 1896 document the effects of these reforms. Total silkworm-egg incubation rose from 120,188 ounces in 1891—94,602 domestic and 25,586 foreign—to a peak of 128,484 ounces in 1892, while domestic seeds increasingly displaced imports. Fresh cocoon production reached 4,610,884 kg in 1893, up from 3,426,027 kg in 1891, yielding an average of 42.55 kg per ounce of seed, before declining to roughly 3 million kg by 1896. Cocoon values likewise rose from 44,725,581 piastres in 1891 to 70,206,210 in 1893, when prices reached 15.22 piastres per kilogram and generated 7,020,621 piastres in tithe revenue. Although prices fell to 12 piastres per kilogram by 1896, export volumes remained substantial: between 1891 and 1894, annual

[47] Registre de la Correspondence du Vice-Consulat de la France a Brousse, du 1er Janvier 1896 au 11 Mai 1897, 120/PO1, p.48. Centre des Archives diplomatiques de Nantes (CADN), Nantes, France

raw-silk exports ranged from 79,391 to 127,408 kg, while cocoon exports ranged from 230,519 to 321,568 kg.[48]

Established in 1888 by the Ottoman Public Debt Administration and directed by Kevork Torkomian (a Montpellier alumnus), the Sericulture Institute of Bursa expanded from a small rented house to a purpose-built facility in 1894 located below the Imperial Kiosk. Constructed for 4,000 francs with an annual operating budget of 12,000 francs, the facility featured an amphitheater, incubation and microscope rooms, two ventilated *magnaneries*, and mulberry gardens.[49]

The tuition-free Institute admitted students of all religions (aged 18+) for a two-year program comprising 45 theoretical lectures and hands-on practical training. Students managed 20 ounces of silkworm seeds per season and received extensive instruction in microscopic selection via French-supplied Nachet equipment using Pasteur's method. Graduates passing the final jury-evaluated examination earned a formal diploma certifying them to produce disease-free silkworm eggs.

[48] Registre de la Correspondence du Vice-Consulat de la France a Brousse, du 1er Janvier 1896 au 11 Mai 1897, 120/PO1, p.125-127. Centre des Archives diplomatiques de Nantes (CADN), Nantes, France

[49] Registre de la Correspondence du Vice-Consulat de la France a Brousse du 11 Mai 1897 au 31 Dcembre 1899, p.27-28. Centre des Archives diplomatiques de Nantes (CADN), Nantes, France

## Chapter 3: The Political Economy of Armenian Peasant Households: Migration, Women's Labor, and Capitalist Transformation in Bardizag, 1830s–1914

**(burada is wage labor icin hareket yogunlugunun artmasinin tam tarihini yazabiliyor olman lazim Sahika!!!)**

### Introduction

On a Monday morning in the late 1870s, Protestant missionary Maria A. West and her companion, Mrs. Parsons, surveyed Bardizag for the first time, visiting families connected to the local Protestant community.[50] Despite Bardizag's proximity to Istanbul, Bursa, and Adabazar, West was struck by the poverty she encountered. Women and children walked barefoot or in wooden clogs along uneven stone paths; domestic work spilled into public space as bulgur was dried outdoors, flax was beaten in communal courtyards, and smoke from street hearths hung in the air as elderly women spun wool at doorways.[51] When West returned several years later, she found a village transformed yet still marked by hardship. A newly built silk factory employed dozens of Armenian young women, and household rooms were converted into sericulture spaces. Wage labor had expanded, even as illness and overcrowding persisted. In one exchange, women washing laundry in the street called out to Maria A.West: "You do not do such work; you are rich!" a remark that exposed a stark class divide and revealed how villagers themselves experienced structural poverty. [52]

[50] Bardizag (modern-day *Bahçecik*, Turkey) meaning little garden in Western Armenian, was founded in the 17th century by Armenians fleeing the original village of Bardizag in Sebastia (*Sivas*), which had become a battleground during the Ottoman-Safavid war. See: Henry R.Shapiro, "The Great Armenian Flight: Migration and Cultural Change in the 17th century Ottoman Empire", *Journal of Early Modern History*, 2019, p.67. Virtual Genocide Memorial, nahiye-bardizag-bahcecik, Accessed Time (Sunday, November 16, 2024).

[51] Maria A. West. *The Romance of Missions or Inside Views of Life and Labor in the Land of Ararat.* (New York: Anson D.F. Randolph & Company, 1875), p.10-11.

[52]

If West's outsider account emphasized poverty and domestic labor, Bardizag high school teacher and Armenian Genocide survivor Karnig Bodourian's memoirs reveal how locals understood these as effects of Bardizag's shifting place in the late Ottoman economy.[53] According to Bodourian, as opportunities for wage labor grew in Istanbul and İzmit, households recalibrated their survival strategies: men migrated for years to repay debts, and women entered domestic service or were sent as wet nurses to Istanbul to supplement family income.[54] Crafts such as weaving, carpentry, and tanning nearly disappeared under competition from cheaper European imports, while others including sewing, dyeing, and small trade survived mostly through a barter system with limited market exchange.

A native of the town, Bodourian confirms the unequal and uneven development West had observed during the Hamidian and Constitutional periods. Bardizag, he writes, was neither fully urban, lacking the institutions and architecture of nearby İzmit or Adabazar, nor a typical village dependent purely on subsistence.[55] Instead, it occupied a liminal economic space subject to the commodification of basic needs, decline of traditional crafts, and expanding urban labor markets. Bardizag is a critical site which exposes the material processes that drove semi-

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West, *Ibid*.

[53] Karnig Bodourian was among the first prominent figures from Bardizag to be arrested in the aftermath of 24 April 1915. This episode may be understood through Özgür Sevgi Göral's analysis of enforced disappearance in Kurdistan during 1990s, which highlights the deliberate production of uncertainty regarding victims' fates as a mechanism of political violence. Viewed through this lens, Armenian Genocide was not only a history of mass killing and deportation but also a regime of disappearance in which families were denied knowledge about their loved ones. Özgür Sevgi Göral, "Waiting for the disappeared: waiting as a form of resilience and the limits of legal space in Turkey.," *Soc Anthropol*, 29, 2021, 800-815. https://doi.org/10.1111/1469-8676.13096

[54] Գառնիկ Կ. Պօտուռեա. *Խմբագիր, յառաջաբանի եւ ծանօթագրութիւններու հեղինակ Միհրան Ա. Մինասեան* = Memoirs of the deportee 1915-1917 / Karnik G. Bodourian ; editor, author of the preface and references Mihran A. Minassian, p.105. Similarly, Keri Topuzian's oral history with his father corroborates this argument. According to this interview, his father`s grandfather, Minas traveled from Bardizag to Constantinople to earn additional income, undertaking a two-to-three-day journey by land and sea. I would like to thank Keri Topuzian for allowing me to use his interview in this paper. Keri Topuzian, "My Grandmother and the Death March," *Perfect Armenian*, http://www.perfectarmenian.com/authors-journal/ (accessed March 21, 2026).

[55] *Ibid.*

proletarianization in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, as a self-sufficient peasant economy became increasingly unsustainable.

This article examines the Bardizag region between 1830s and the First World War. During this period, the village became an important center of tobacco cultivation and silk production while maintaining a predominantly peasant household structure. Rather than experiencing full proletarianization through the loss of land, Bardizag's households increasingly relied upon multiple sources of income: small-scale farming, seasonal migration, industrial employment, and the wage labor of women in filatures. By situating Bardizag within the broader political economy of the late Ottoman Empire, this study contributes to debates on capitalist transformation, labor history, and gender in the southern Marmara region. It suggests that capitalist development in the Ottoman countryside was neither uniform nor teleological. Instead, rural households negotiated incorporation into global markets through flexible labor strategies that preserved elements of peasant production even as they deepened dependence upon wage labor.

The Ottoman *nüfus defterleri* (population registers) reveal the considerable mobility of Bardizag's population. The town comprised 34 neighborhoods and recorded 2,080 males in 1831, a figure that fell to 1,716 the following year.[56] By 1841, the registers recorded 23 neighborhoods, 509 households, and 1,427 males; just two years later, Bardizag had again expanded to 34 neighborhoods, 761 households, and 2,004 males. Because the *nüfus defterleri* counted men but did not enumerate women, these figures cannot be read as measures of total population. Their sharp fluctuations instead reveal the movement of male inhabitants into and out of Bardizag. As

[56] Ferhat Berber, "19.Yuzyilin Ilk Yarisina ait Nufus Defterleri ve Izmit Kazasinin Nufusu," Uluslararası Çoban Mustafa Paşa ve Kocaeli Tarihi-Kültürü Sempozyumu Kocaeli, Turkey) 2017 : 2018. *Uluslararası Çoban Mustafa Paşa Ve Kocaeli Tarihi-Kültürü Sempozyumu IV Bildirileri = International Symposium on Çoban Mustafa Paşa and History-Culture of Kocaeli IV : Proceedings*. Edited by Haluk Selvi. Kocaeli: Kocaeli Büyükşehir Belediyesi. Cilt 1, p.474-478.

Ferhat Berber observes, individuals moved within and beyond the İzmit district, making mobility a defining feature of Bardizag's rural economy**.** The registers thus capture a community whose households were not territorially fixed but depended on movement between village agriculture and wider regional labor network.

Recognizing these hybrid forms of labor broadens our understanding of how capitalism reshaped provincial societies on the eve of the empire's collapse. Drawing upon missionary accounts, Armenian memoirs, and Ottoman administrative records, this article argues that Bardizag experienced a process of semi-proletarianization in which peasant households remained attached to the land while becoming increasingly dependent upon wage labor and market exchange. Rather than viewing peasant agriculture and industrial labor as opposing economic forms, the Bardizag case demonstrates how they became mutually reinforcing components of household survival. Men's seasonal migration and women's factory employment were not temporary adaptations but structural responses to the combined pressures of fiscal extraction, commercial agriculture, and global industrial demand.

**The Semi-Proletarianization Thesis**

Scholars have given much attention to the social implications of labor migration, focusing particularly on notions of being away from home and homesickness, or *pandukhts*. However, Western and Turkish scholarship on Ottoman Armenians has long neglected sustained class analysis, leaving significant gaps in our understanding of the Armenian peasantry. Classical Marxist theory provides some of the tools to fill these gaps, emphasizing the separation of rural producers from the land and the emergence of "free" wage laborers, the proletariat.[57] However, this perspective is limited in explaining the social dynamics in peripheral regions, and by the

[57] At its core, the proletarian condition is defined by the loss of direct access to the means of production and subsistence, forcing individuals to commodify their labor-power for wages. Karl Marx*, Capital, Vol*. I, 900-920.

1970s scholars challenged the notion that capitalism universally produces fully proletarianized labor forces, highlighting instead recurring patterns of circular migration between rural and urban labor markets. This gave rise to the semi-proletarian thesis, articulated by Giovanni Arrighi and others, which emphasizes households that combine subsistence farming with intermittent wage labor.[58]

Semi-proletarianization allowed capital to shift a portion of the costs of labor reproduction onto households, suppressing wages, and expanding profits in line with prevailing political and economic interests.[59] In the Ottoman Empire, this process was affected through the devaluation of rural labor, the marketization of family farming, and shifts in township and village enterprises. Older generations remained in agriculture, while the rural youth migrated to urban centers and industrial zones, providing cheap and flexible labor to expand industry.[60] Immanuel Wallerstein further demonstrates that semi-proletarian households are historically common within global capitalism: they are not "traditional" remnants of a previous economic formation, but adaptive units shaped by state, market, and employer pressures.[61] The household, thus, I argue, serves a critical adaptive function in these shifting landscapes.

There was already a well-established search for wage work in early modern Ottoman Empire, as demonstrated by the work of Aleksandar Shopov.[62] More broadly, the Marmara

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Giovanni Arrighi, "Labor Supplies in Historical Perspective: A Study of Proletarianization of the African Peasantry in Rhodesia" *The Journal of Development Studies* 6 (3), 1970, 197–234.

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Michel Boraway, "Migrant Labor: Functions and Reproduction," *AJS Volume 81*, Number 5. p.1051.

60 Karl Kautsky, *The Agrarian Question, Vol. I*, (Zwan Publications, London, 1988), p.15–19.

61

Immanuel Wallerstein, "Semi-Peripheral Countries and the Contemporary World Crisis," *Theory and Society*, Vol.3 No.4, p.467-483. Wilma Dunaway, The Semiproleterian Household over the Long-Duree of the Modern World System, https://www.academia.edu/4685380/The_Semiproletarian_Household_over_the_Long_Duree_of_the_Modern_World_System p.4

62

region, including Constantinople, Bursa, Iznik, and Adapazari, formed a dynamic labor market that attracted workers from the Balkans as well as other parts of the Ottoman Empire.[63] Recognizing these earlier patterns is important, as it cautions against drawing an overly sharp distinction between the early modern and modern periods.

What distinguishes the nineteenth century, therefore, is not emergence of wage labor itself but its multiplication, diversification, and reorganization. Industrial enterprises such as the Hereke Factory, the expansion of the filatures in the surrounding villages, and the increasing number of mechanized factories in Istanbul generated new forms of wage employment while intensifying labor discipline and expanding the scale of production and profit.[64] Rather than marking a complete rupture with the early modern past, these developments represent an acceleration and reconfiguration of longer-term processes. My aim is therefore not to claim the uniqueness of the nineteenth century, but to explain how existing patterns of labor mobility and wage employment were transformed by industrialization, changing production regimes, and the growing integration of regional labor markets.

Capital benefited from this arrangement by keeping wages low and shifting the costs of social reproduction onto households, where they were borne especially by women.[65] Women's labor was not supplementary but foundational to household survival. Women and children

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Aleksandar Shopov, "Between the Pen and the Fields: Books on Farming, Changing Land Regimes, and Urban Agriculture in the Ottoman Eastern Mediterranean ca.1500-1700," (Unpublished Dissertation, Harvard University, 2016), p.43-78., p.156, p.354, p.369-410.

[63] Cengiz Kırlı, "A Profile of the Labor Force in Early Nineteenth-Century Istanbul," *ILWCH,* 60, Fall 2001, pp.125-140.

[64] Kristen J. Alff, "Landed Property, Capital Accumulation, and Polymorphous Capitalism in Egypt and the Levant, 1850-1920" in eds. Joel Beinin, Bassam Haddad, Sherene Seikaly, *Critical Political Economy of the Middle East and North Africa*, (Stanford University Press, 2021).

[65] Nancy Fraser, "Behind Marx's Hidden Abode," *NLR* 86, April 2014. https://newleftreview.org/issues/ii86/articles/nancy-fraser-behind-marx-s-hidden-abode (Accessed Date: 01/12/2025).

labored in the fields and at home, preparing winter supplies, washing and spinning wool, weaving, and making clothing and bedding, often singing as they worked. The precarity that resulted from temporary, low-wage labor reinforced the unstable, underpaid, and often unacknowledged labor upon which semi-proletarian households depended. Because the burden of social reproduction including childcare, food preparation, textile work, and seasonal agricultural support continued to fall primarily on women, their historically unwaged labor sustained the workforce at minimal cost to the state and capital.

By focusing on the material processes of semi-proletarianization, this paper engages with recent historiographical debates that seek to decenter the "wealthy elite" narrative of Ottoman Armenians. As scholars like Stephen Astourian and Yasar Tolga Cora have argued, provincial Armenian communities were not homogenous blocks but were deeply stratified by class and access to resources.[66] In Bardizag, "Armenianness" was not a singular experience of prosperity; rather, it was defined by the international exploitation of the peasantry by local Armenian elites and the external extraction of the state through a series of aggressive fiscal regimes.

Further expanding these insights, Dzonivar Derderian highlights how violence against Armenian peasants in Kurdistan and exploitative labor arrangements shaped migration as a crucial component of local survival strategies.[67] Derderian shows how Armenian peasants extended these strategies into urban circuits. By the mid-nineteenth century, peasants traveling to cities such as Istanbul and Aleppo worked as porters, construction laborers, bread bakers, and

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[66] Stephan Astourian, "The Silence of the Land: Agrarian Relations, Ethnicity, and Power," in *A Question of Genocide: Armenians and Turks at the End of the Ottoman Empire.* Ronald Grigor Suny (ed).et.al. p.58. Yasar Tolga Cora, "Osmanlı Taşrasındaki Ermeniler Üzerine Olan Tarihyazımında Sınıf Analizinin Eksikliği," No.39. *Praksis,* 2015.

[67] Dzonivar Derderian, "Nation-Making and the Language of Colonialism: Voices from Ottoman Van in Armenian Print Media and Handwritten Petitions (1820s-1870s)," (Unpublished Dissertation, University of Michigan, 2019), p. 202.

fruit vendors.[68] Newspapers portrayed them as destitute and melancholic, yet their wages were vital for sustaining village households and meeting tax obligations, an experience similar to that of Armenian peasants in Bardizag. *Pandukhts* relied on communal networks in khans, coffeehouses, and churches while enduring precarious urban labor.[69] Fiscal pressures, state interventions, and regional instability including the Hamidian massacres of 1895–96 and recurring famines further compelled households to combine local labor, migration, and coordinated household strategies to survive**.**

By the late nineteenth century, the term *pandukhts* increasingly signified working-class migrants from the eastern provinces seeking employment in Constantinople, İzmir, Aleppo, and Tbilisi. Yet debates over the processes and implications of semi-proletarianization remain underdeveloped, and a detailed reading of why peasants chose to leave their hometowns for waged work is still missing. The transition of Bardizag, I argue, must be analyzed through the lens of "uneven integration into global capitalism," a framework which acknowledges that capitalist development in the periphery deliberately maintains non-capitalist forms of production; such as subsistence and barter, to externalize the costs of social reproduction. This structural logic allowed the burden of sustaining the workforce onto the household. Specifically, Maria West's observations of unwaged domestic labor illustrate the foundational labor that sustained a low-wage industrial workforce at a minimal cost to capital.

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[68] Florian Riedler, "Armenian Labor Migration to Istanbul and the Migration Crisis of the 1890s," in *The City in the Ottoman Empire: Migration and the Making of Urban Modernity*, ed. Ulrike Freitag, Malte Fuhrmann, Nora Lafi, and Florian Riedler (London: Routledge, 2011), 160–76.Akın Sefer, Aysel Yıldız, and Mustafa Erdem Kabadayı, "Labor Migration from Krusevo: Mobility, Ottoman Transformation and the Balkan Highlands in the 19th Century," *IJMES,* Vol.53, 2021,p.74 .Daniel Ohanian, "Ottoman Istanbul and Its Armenian Inhabitants: Population Data and Maps, 1830s-c. 1907," (May 6, 2019) https://www.houshamadyan.org/en/mapottomanempire/vilayet-of-istanbul/locale/demography.htm

[69] Yasar Tolga Cora, "Institutionalized Migrant Solidarity in the Late Ottoman Empire: Armenian Homeland Associations (1800s–1920s)." *New Perspectives on Turkey* 63 (2020): 55–79. https://doi.org/10.1017/npt.2020.16.

In alignment with the Arrighi/Wallerstein thesis, by the late19th century, the Bardizag peasantry emerged as semi-proletarian households; these were adaptive units that combined small-scale mulberry or tobacco farming with seasonal migration of men to urban center. Gregory Gabriel Dabraskian, the first Armenian student from Nicomedia to attend University of Illinois, provides a window to the peasant economy.[70] Dabraskian studied agriculture at the University of Illinois and, during his senior year, wrote an essay entitled *Agriculture in Asia Minor*. His discussion of agricultural production emphasizes the importance of vegetable gardening, fruit growing, and silk raising among Armenians.[71] After graduation, he returned to Bardizag and continued his career as a farmer.

This economic shift was further propelled by the "bourgeoization of Ottoman land law" through the 1858 Land Code, which dismantled communal protections and utilized cadastral surveys to facilitate the concentration of land within a handful of elite Armenian families, including the Saroukhians and Mgerians, who eventually controlled nearly three quarters of village resources. Finally, the autonomy of the rural producer was completely undermined by commodity monopolization, as the Ottoman Public Debt Administration and the Régie dictated a transition from self-sufficiency to monocultural cash-crop production, transforming peasants into contract-bound suppliers for foreign-dominated syndicates.

**Ottoman Fiscal Crises and the Expansion of Taxation**

Between the 1760s and 1830s, successive military defeats and territorial losses drastically reduced the Ottoman state's tax base. These difficulties intensified during the Crimean War,

[70] "Illini Everywhere: Armenian Illini, Since 1871," *University Library Student Life and Culture Archives*, 05/28/2017, https://www.library.illinois.edu/slc/illini-everywhere/armenian-illini/ (accessed date: 09/21/2026).

[71] Gregory Gabrialial Dabraskian, "Agriculture in Asia Minor," *Daily Illini*, 1 June 1874, p.16.

when the government borrowed unprecedented sums from European creditors to cover military expenditures. The subsequent debt default of 1875–76 further eroded Ottoman fiscal autonomy, placing key sectors of the economy under foreign control.[72]

The empire's fiscal crisis directly reshaped rural life. To compensate for lost revenues and rising debt, the state imposed increasingly aggressive taxation, with non-Muslim communities such as Armenians bearing a disproportionate share of the burden.[73] Talin Suciyan's work, *Outcasting Armenians*, shows how villagers in places like Bardizag frequently appealed to the Armenian Patriarchate of Constantinople to intervene on their behalf, voicing frustration over the heavy and multilayered taxes they faced.[74] Combined with the monetization of everyday transactions, these policies placed rural households under relentless strain. The Ottoman State historically imposed numerous taxes on its citizens, particularly on peasants, impoverished villagers, and other economically disadvantaged groups, who constituted the majority of the population.[75] Although the tithe (*aşar*) was the most significant fiscal burden, Armenian cultivators in the Bardizag region were subject to an extensive array of additional monetary taxes, both regular and irregular. These included the property tax (*emlâk*), land tax (*arazi*), animal tax (*ağnam*), income tax (t*emettü*), education tax (*maârif*), travel tax (*müruriyye*), hunting permit fees, and service taxes related to official transactions such as postal services, telegrams, stamps, and court expenses.[76]

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[72] Nadir Ozbek, "The Politics of Taxation and the Armenian Question during the late Ottoman Empire," 1876-1908". p.774.

[73] *Ibid,* p.775.

[74] Talin Suciyan, *Outcasting Armenians*. (Syracuse University Press, 2023), p.74-75.

[75] *Ibid.*

[76] Grigor Mkhalean, and Ara Stepan Melkonian. 2014. *Bardizag and Its People*. London: Gomidas Institute., p.210.

Fatma Melek Arıkan further notes that difficulties in collecting taxes from border regions, e.g. Kurdistan, led to disproportionately heavier burdens on more prosperous areas such as Bursa; a big city close to Bardizag.[77] Archival records suggest that Arıkan's observations also apply to the Bardizag region. Most taxes were paid collectively rather than by individual households as peasant families could not afford the taxes on their own. In his study on the history of Armenians in Nicomedia, Kasabian provides valuable quantitative insights into the fiscal pressures endured by the population of the İzmit region in l910.[78] He records that the region paid a total of 252,000 piasters (*kuruş*) for the military exemption tax, 118,118 *piasters* for land taxes, and 41,860 piasters for the travel tax (*mururiye*). Altogether, these taxes amounted to a staggering 411,978 piasters, levied on a population of approximately 8,000 people, an annual average of roughly 51.49 piasters per individual, a significant burden for peasant households operating barely above subsistence levels.[79]

Such figures highlight the heavy burden placed on rural communities, places of great economic precarity. As emphasized in the broader historiography of Ottoman taxation, certain taxes, particularly the tithe (*aşar*), were virtually inescapable. Excise officials regularly visited each village, meticulously surveying cultivated lands to assess and fix crop yields in advance, thereby ensuring that tax obligations were met. This system, which combined anticipatory taxation with direct oversight, further entrenched fiscal oppression at the local level, limiting the ability of peasants to negotiate or mitigate their tax burdens and often pushing them into cycles of indebtedness or migration for waged work.

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Fatma Melek Arikan, "Bati Anadolu Kırsalında "Ermeni Meselesi"nin Tanzimat Kökenleri", *Osmanlı Arastirmalari*, Cilt: 63 Sayı: 63, 2024, p.280-300.

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Minas Kasabian, *The Armenians in the Province of Nicomedia.* (London: Gomidas Institute, 2019), p.129.

79

*Ibid.*

Despite successive fiscal reforms in 1879, 1886, 1894, 1896, and 1902, the *iltizām* (tax-farming) system persisted, and local elites retained substantial control. Turkish aghas initially dominated local governance, but by the mid-nineteenth century, councils of locally elected elders (*ihtiyar meclisi*) assumed authority, with village heads (*muhtars*) overseeing tax collection and local administration.[80] These councils balanced nominal state oversight with entrenched elite influence, ensuring that provincial elites-maintained access to agricultural surplus while the peasantry bore the brunt of extraction.[81]

As the 1858 Land Code began to dismantle communal protections across the empire, its local impact in Bardizag manifested as a decisive shift in power toward handful of prominent Armenian families. While the law framed as modernizing property rights, it functioned on fluid terms where rights remained provisional and layered.[82] Rather than protecting peasant sustainability, these reforms enabled the ruling classes including the Saroukhians, Sahagians, Sinanians, Bedigians, and Mgerians, to leverage cadastral surveys and debt enforcement to facilitate the outright seizure of peasant lands.[83] This "bourgeoization" of Ottoman land law ensured the transfer of surplus from producers to propertied elites, linking peasant survival ever more tightly to the fiscal demands of the state.

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[80] Mehmet Gunes, "Osmanlı Köy ve Mahalle İdarelerinde Yeni Bir Dönem: İhtiyar Meclislerinin Teşekkülü," *Journal of History Studies*, Vol.6., Issue: 3. April, 2014.

[81] Dogu Ergil, "From empire to dependence: the evolution of Turkish underdevelopment,"(Unpublished PhD Dissertation, Binghamton University, 1975), p.8. Mkhelian, p.289 Beshara Doumani, *Family Life in the Ottoman Mediterranean,* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2017), p.25-30.

[82] Tosun Aricanli, "Property, Land and Labor in Nineteenth Century Anatolia, Landholding and Commercial Agriculture in the Middle East Publisher,": State University of New York Press Editors: Tabak, Çaglar Keyder and Faruk, p.1.

[83] ‘ □□□ -□□ □□□□□ □., Shahan Nat□ali, and Hakob Ter-Hakobean. 1960. *Պարտիզակը Խաւտուտիկ : Հաւելուածաբար Մանուշակ Եւ Իր Հէքեաթները*. P‘ariz: Ա. Դեր Ազոպիան.

In Bardizag, where Tanzimat reforms promised nominal equality, local authorities continued to rely on the existing communal structures, with the church exercising significant symbolic influence. These traditional social structures intensified the outsized tax burden felt by the peasantry. Although reformers attempted to shift the tax burden from rural land and production toward concentrations of urban wealth, local elites resisted, preserving their customary tax farming privileges.[84] Consequently, fiscal pressure on Bardizag's peasantry increased, particularly through the tithe, which remained the cornerstone of state revenue.[85]

**The Uneven Burden of Taxation**

For many years in the early 19th century, Bardizag was governed by Turkish notables; however, by the final years of the Mgerian era, around 1850, the authority of these aghas was abolished.[86] Administrative control was transferred to a council of locally elected elders (*ihtiyar meclisi*), officially recognized by the central government up until the genocide.[87] This council was led by a *muhtar* (village headman), selected by property-owning citizens who paid more than 50 piasters in land or property taxes (*emlak* or *arazi*). The *muhtar* exercised authority supported by a police corporal (*çavuş*) and a small contingent of officers. Through this multi-tiered system, the government intended for provincial directors (*muhassils*) and local councils to act as checks on the authority of provincial governors and magnates, thereby curbing fraudulent

[84] Erdogan Keles, *Anadolu`da Tanzimat ve Teftis,* (Ankara: Gece Akademi Yayinevi, 2019), p.180-2.

[85] Resat Kasaba, *A Moveable Empire: Ottoman Nomads, Migrants, and Refugees.* Seattle, WA: University of Washington Press, 2009. https://hdl-handle-net.proxy.binghamton.edu/2027/heb40470.0001.001. EPUB

[86] Grigor Mkhalean, and Ara Stepan Melkonian. 2014. *Bardizag and Its People*. London: Gomidas Institute., p.220.

[87] Mehmet Gunes, "Osmanlı Köy ve Mahalle İdarelerinde Yeni Bir Dönem: İhtiyar Meclislerinin Teşekkülü," *Journal of History Studies*, Vol.6., Issue: 3. April 2014.

tax practices and other abuses that had characterized the previous regime.[88] During the crisis, the survival of the empire depended on developing the internal capacity of the ruling class to collectively assert dominance over the peasantry while maintaining security in the face of mounting external threats. Rather than a simple center-periphery opposition, the Tanzimat era was characterized by a complex web of intra-elite negotiations and tensions, constrained by the dual pressures of potential rural unrest and geopolitical vulnerability.

Control over agricultural production in the Ottoman Empire was maintained through a complex set of property relations that diverged significantly from European models of landownership. Unlike the Western notion of full and secure property rights, Ottoman agrarian structures operated on more fluid terms, where rights to land were often provisional, segmented, and layered. [89] The 1858 Land Code marked a decisive shift toward the privatization of land, entrenching small holdings subject to heavy taxation while paving the way for uneven capitalist development in agriculture. Rather than protecting the ability of peasants to sustain themselves on their traditional holdings, it enabled ruling classes to extract surplus through rents, contracts, and taxes, and facilitated the outright seizure of peasant lands. The prohibition on collective registration eliminated communal property which had stood as a barrier to commodification, thus privileging the individual as the sole unit of ownership. As Alp Yücel Kaya and Yücel Terzibaşoğlu emphasize, this dismantling of communal protections transformed property into a more easily commodified form, while linking peasant survival ever more tightly to the fiscal

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88 Burak Hamza Eryigit and Cansu Kalafat, "Osmanlı Devleti'nde 1840 – 1858 Yılları Arasında Taşra Yönetimini Düzenleyen Nizamnameler Üzerine Bir Değerlendirme," *Strategic Public Management Journal*, Vol.5, Issue 10, 2019, p.55.

89 Tosun Aricanli, Property, Land and Labor in Nineteenth Century Anatolia, Landholding and Commercial Agriculture in the Middle East Publisher: State University of New York Press Editors: Tabak, Çaglar Keyder and Faruk, p.1

demands of the state.[90] By the 1860s, regulations permitting the forced sale of public land to cover state debts further opened the door for provincial elites to acquire peasant plots, a development Kaya describes as the "bourgeoization" of Ottoman land law.[91] Studies of farms confirm that these reforms aligned with dominant class interests, ensuring the transfer of surplus from producers to propertied elites.

In Bardizag, these broader reforms facilitated the rise of powerful Armenian families, the Saroukhians, Sahagians, Sinanians, Bedigians, and Mgerians. whose local influence was amplified by their ties to both the Armenian clergy and Muslim notables.[92] Their consolidation of land and wealth was inseparable from state policy: cadastral surveys, tax regimes, and debt enforcement created conditions in which elite households could expand property while poor peasants lost ground. The elder Sinan, connected to the Der-Sahagian family, illustrates this intertwining of private accumulation and state authority: he combined artisanal production of grain containers with political brokerage, his garden serving as a hub for negotiations with Ottoman officials. Similarly, Nshan Agha, son-in-law of the Bedigian family, expanded into mulberry groves, tobacco, cheese, and sheep, activities that thrived precisely because reforms opened space for petty commodity production feeding into the farm (*ciftlik*) economy. [93]

By the late nineteenth century, inequality had reached stark proportions: the Saroukhians and Mgerians controlled nearly half of Bardizag's resources, while the poorest half of

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Yücel Terzibaşoğlu ve Alp Yücel Kaya, "19. Yüzyılda Balkanlar'da Toprak Rejimi ve Emek İlişkileri" (Land Regime and Labour Relations in the 19th-century Balkans), *İktisat Tarihinin Dönüşü: Yeni Yaklaşımlar ve Tartışmalar*, İletişim, İstanbul, 2021, p. 49-105.

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Alp Yucel Kaya, "Bourgeois Revolution in Turkey (1908-1923)," *Revolutionary Marxism*, 2023, p.65-72.

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Grigor Mkhalean, and Ara Stepan Melkonian. 2014. *Bardizag and Its People*. London: Gomidas Institute., p.113-185.

93

*Ibid.*

households held less than 10 percent.[94] This concentration of land and wealth locked the poor into intergenerational landlessness, forcing successive generations into insecure wage labor. Bardizag thus exemplifies the concentration of land typical of peripheral capitalist development: a handful of landlords, some five or six families, controlled three-quarters of village resources. Economic success depended not only on land and labor but also on social capital and access to networks, while most peasant households remained structurally excluded and constrained in their survival strategies. These dynamics show that Ottoman land and labor relations produced distinct class formations, shaped not only by local elites but also by state-driven reorganization of agriculture. In Bardizag, the fragmentation and conditionality of property rights played a decisive role in the emergence of new labor forms and hierarchies. As peasants lost autonomous control over production and revenue, they increasingly became dependent on landlords, tax farmers, *iltizam* holders, and other fiscal intermediaries who acted as extensions of the state's extractive power.

**Three Essential Modes of Fiscal Extraction in Bardizag**

Beyond the general burden of property and income taxes, the Ottoman state relied on three additional extractive mechanisms; the charcoal tax, the road tax, and the military service exemption tax, that fundamentally reshaped the labor organization of Armenian peasant households. According to Avetis Nazarbek, editor of the *Hunchak* and a leading figure in the Social Democratic Hunchakian Party, one of the Ottoman government's most effective strategies

94 Mkhalean, *Ibid.*

for impoverishing and ultimately eliminating the Armenian population was the systematic imposition of excessive taxation, fines, and compulsory labor.[95]

In the Bardizag region, these three fiscal mechanisms disproportionately affected the Armenian peasantry. Each targeted a different segment of the rural population while simultaneously serving the dual purpose of generating state revenue and weakening peasant autonomy. As shown in Table 1, the *binnime* (charcoal tax), *tarik* (road tax), and *bedel-i askerî* (military exemption tax) imposed additional labor and financial obligations on rural households, shifting productive capacity away from subsistence agriculture and contributing to the erosion of agrarian self-sufficiency.

### *Charcoal Tax*

Among the most burdensome obligations imposed on Bardizag's Armenian villagers was the production of charcoal for the Ottoman state. As the imperial economy industrialized, charcoal became indispensable for minting coinage, manufacturing military supplies, and sustaining urban industries. Because of the high risk of fire and the depletion of forests in Istanbul, charcoal had to be sourced from provincial woodlands.[96] The Adapazarı-Geyve-Kandıra corridor, known as the Sea of Trees (*Ağaç Denizi*), emerged as a major supplier of timber and charcoal, integrating Bardizag into an expanding system of imperial extraction.[97] The Ottoman state secured this supply through a *muafiyet,* system of conditional tax exemptions that

[95] Avetis, Nazarbek "The Voice of the Armenian Revolutionists upon the Armenian Problem and how to Solve it" (editor of the "Hunchak", the central organ of the Armenian Revolutionary Party.) (London).

[96] BOA: C.DRB. 12/2/1190-2/4/1776, BOA: C.DRB. 09/B/1204-24/3/1790, BOA: C.ML. 29/L/1240-14/07/1825.

[97] Resul Narin, "Osmanlıdan Cumhuriyete Ağaç Denizi Kocaeli", *Uluslararası çoban Mustafa Paşave Kocaeli Tarihi Kültürü Sempozyumu – IV Bildirileri, Cilt II,* Kocaeli, 2018, p.971-5. Selçuk Dursun, "Forest and the State: History of Forestry and Forest in the Ottoman Empire," (Unpublished Dissertation, Sabancı University, 2007), p.126-128.

exchanged fiscal relief for compulsory service. [98] Rather than paying certain taxes, Armenian households supplied charcoal to the Imperial Mint (*Darphane-i Âmire*) by felling timber, burning charcoal, operating kilns, and transporting fuel. [99] As Halil Sahillioglu has shown, wartime expenditures repeatedly drove the Ottoman government to debase its currency in the early modern era.[100] Debasement required the mint to strike larger quantities of coin, increasing its demand for charcoal and, in turn, intensifying both forest extraction and peasant labor in villages such as Bardizag. Although *muafiyet* initially relieved villagers of certain fiscal burdens, it ultimately bound them to an extractive labor regime whose demands expanded with the empire's fiscal needs in the 18th and early 19th century. Their dependence was reinforced by Turkish notables, who controlled the means of production; oxcarts, ships, and capital, while simultaneously exercising administrative authority over village labor and procurement.

Against this backdrop, the Mint introduced a new levy in 1835 known among Armenian villagers as *binnime*. [101] Ostensibly imposed to finance the charcoal trade, the tax covered not only workers' wages but also the upkeep of transport animals and the living expenses of the regional notables who managed production. Rather than replacing existing obligations,

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BOA.C.DRB. 54/2662 (1831). Nurullah Demir, *219 Nolu Muhimme Defterinin Transkripsiyon ve Degerlendirilmesi.* (Ed.) Dr.Kazim Kartal, Serpil Sevim Kartal, (Ankara: Iksad Yayinevi, 2019), p.188.

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Ömerül Faruk Bölükbaşı, "Darbhane-i Amire`nin Yakacak Ihtiyacinin Temininde Kocaeli`nin Yeri ve Onemi," p.558-9. Ömerül Faruk Bölükbaşı, *18. Yüzyılın Ikinci Yarısında Darbhâne-i Âmire*. 1. baskı. İstanbul: İstanbul Bilgi Üniversitesi Yayınları. 2013. "Reading Ottoman Mining Through Ottoman Imperial Mint Registers: Silver Production of the Ottoman Empire in the Second Half of the The XVIII. Century / Osmanlı Madenciliğini Darphane Defterleri Üzerinden Okumak: XVIII. Yüzyılın İkinci Yarısında Osmanlı Devleti'nde Gümüş Üretimi," *Turkish Journal History,* 2002.

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Halil Sahillioglu, "The Role of International Monetary and Metal Movements in Ottoman Monetary History 1300-1750," Studies in Ottoman Economic and Social History, IRCICA, Istanbul, (1999), p.47.

101 Grigor Mkhalean, and Ara Stepan Melkonian. 2014. *Bardizag and Its People*. London: Gomidas Institute., p.107.

the *binnime* added a new fiscal burden to an already coercive labor system (which can be seen in Table 1) , shifting the costs of the empire's monetary infrastructure onto the very communities that supplied its fuel. Unsurprisingly, resentment spread throughout Bardizag. Many Armenian villagers abandoned charcoal production altogether, forcing neighboring villages such as Ovacık, under the leadership of Zakar Agha, to assume a greater share of the Imperial Mint's growing demand for charcoal.[102]

**Table 1. Modes of Fiscal Extraction in Bardizag, 19th–Early 20th Century**

| Tax Regime | Period | Primary Target | Form of Extraction | State Objective | Effects on Bardizag Peasantry | Relation to Semi-Proletarianization |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Charcoal Tax (*Binnime*)** | Introduced 1835 | Rural charcoal producers | Commodity extraction (raw materials + transport costs shifted to villagers) | Secure charcoal for minting, military production, urban industry | Rising costs, declining incentives, withdrawal from charcoal; Ovacık replaces Bardizag | Moves households toward cash dependency as subsistence + natural resource economy destabilizes |
| **Road Tax (*Tarik*)** | 1880s | Adult male villagers | Labor extraction (4 days annual road work or cash equivalent) | Build infrastructure to facilitate commodity circulation and central state reach | Diverts household labor into state projects; increases reliance on wage labor & female/child labor at home | Converts household labor into infrastructure; deepens market integration and time-disciplining of labor |
| **Military Exemption Tax (*Bedel-i Askeri*)** | Formalized 1856, intensified late 19th c., abolished 1909–1910 | Non-Muslim men (in practice nearly all ages but generally paid by the entire community) | Monetization of military obligation; purchase of exemption | Raise revenue, discipline non-Muslims, maintain imperial army | Poor families forced into debt; wealthy pay exemption; and class divisions widen | This shift pushes households toward cash dependency for subsistence and generates inequality between Muslim and non-Muslim citizens of the Empire, further intensifying market hierarchies in the valuation of labor. |

## *Road Tax*

[102] Mkhalean, *Ibid.*

In the Ottoman context, the road tax transformed household labor into public infrastructure, effectively turning local populations into contributors to state projects. In a key difference to the charcoal tax, the road tax was not levied on production, but was a fee levied against those who wished to be exempted from the labor of road construction. Thus, it served both as a method of revenue for the state, and a way to compel the labor of the poorer segments of the population. By constructing and maintaining roads, the state not only facilitated the movement of goods and people but also integrated rural households into emerging market networks.[103] These roads enabled workers to reach factories and urban centers, linking rural labor to industrial and commercial hubs. Such practices were part of a broader pattern in other modern states as well: infrastructure projects were used to regulate labor, and extend state authority into everyday life. The Ottoman Road tax illustrates how fiscal measures could simultaneously extract labor, shape temporal routines, and deepen economic integration.

Alongside charcoal obligations, new infrastructural demands further redirected peasant labor into state projects. Between 1880 and 1885, Bardizag was connected to its port town, Seymen, by a newly constructed road, part of the Ottoman state's broader modernization efforts.[104] To finance such projects, the government imposed a road tax (*tarik*)**,** obligating each able-bodied adult male to contribute four days of labor annually or pay a monetary equivalent of sixteen *piasters*.[105] Rather than a neutral fiscal measure, this tax exemplified the appropriation of surplus labor for state-led infrastructure, embedding rural households into broader circuits of

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[103] Fulya Ozkan, "Winding Road to Modernization: Trabzon-Erzurum-Bayezid Road in the Late Ottoman World," *Comparative Studies of South Asia, Africa and the Middle East* (2014) 34 (1): 191–205.

[104] Grigor Mkhalean, and Ara Stepan Melkonian. 2014. *Bardizag and Its People*. (London: Gomidas Institute., 2014), p.224-226.

[105] *Ibid*.

imperial and capitalist power. As Marx conceptualized in the *Grundrisse*, taxation functions not merely as a fiscal tool but as a coercive mechanism converting surplus value into state-controlled projects.[106]

In Bardizag, the road tax compounded existing pressures on semi-proletarian households. Male seasonal or permanent migrants supplied wage labor to urban centers, while women and children maintained domestic production, subsistence farming, and local industries such as sericulture. The tax therefore reorganized household labor, channeling it toward imperial and capitalist objectives, and reinforced dependency on wage labor, debt, and market engagement.

*Military Service Exemption Tax*

Fiscal extraction in Bardizag extended into conscription, where the military service exemption tax (*bedel-i askerî*) intensified both economic and social pressures on Armenian households. The history of the *bedel-i askerî* demonstrates how the late Ottoman state used fiscal instruments not simply to raise revenue, but to convert the life cycles of non-Muslim men into a taxable resource, binding peasants to the empire through debt, cash obligations, and monetized exemptions. Where charcoal and road taxes drew household labor into imperial projects, the military exemption tax appropriated the capacity to labor itself, transforming citizenship into a purchasable privilege and military obligation into a form of commodified labor power. In this sense, conscription taxation operated as a mechanism of dispossession*:* the poor surrendered its labor, the wealthy surrendered money, and both remained tethered to the state through continuous extraction.

A landmark decree in 1846 legalized Christian conscription, prompting widespread fear in Bardizag.[107] Villagers hid eligible sons, and local leaders sought to meet quotas by hiring

[106] Karl Marx, *The Grundrisse*. (London: Penguin Press,2002), p. 461. Zeynep Agdemir, "Marx, Engels ve Vergiler," *Fiscaoeconomia*, 2019, p.116-125.

[107]

substitutes, laying the groundwork for monetary exemption.[108] The *bedel-i askerî* , formalized under the Ottoman Reform Edict (*Islahat Fermanı)* in 1856, ostensibly extended equality by allowing payment in lieu of service, yet in practice it institutionalized surplus extraction from non-Muslims, particularly rural families. Although legally limited to men between the ages of fifteen to sixty, collection often extended beyond these limits, from infancy to old age, revealing the state's overriding priority of fiscal extraction and the class-based nature of imperial governance**.**

The economic burden of the exemption system grew steadily. The tax amounted to 28 piasters in 1856, equivalent to the jizya it replaced, rising to 37 piasters after 1878 and 50 piasters by 1904 as the state sought revenue to address war costs and fiscal crises.[109] According to Krikor Zohrab, by the early 1880s, more than 508,000 Armenian men were covered and between 1888 and 1909 the *bedel-i askerî* generated roughly 5% of total Ottoman revenue, second only to the *aşar* tithe. Military service became commodified, allowing the wealthy to substitute money for labor while subordinating non-Muslim communities as fiscal units whose reproductive and productive labor financed the imperial state.

In the late Ottoman Empire, taxation and military service were a source of tension for non-Muslim communities, reflecting broader struggles over equality and state authority. Among Armenians, this struggle was internationally dubbed the Armenian Question after the Congress

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Mehmet Hacısalihoğlu, "Inclusion and Exclusion: Conscription in the Ottoman Empire," Journal of Modern European History / Zeitschrift für moderne europäische Geschichte / Revue d'histoire européenne contemporaine Vol. 5, No. 2, Multi-Ethnic Empires and the Military: Conscription in Europe between Integration and Desintegration, 1860–1918 (2007), pp. 264-286.

108

Grigor Mkhalean, and Ara Stepan Melkonian. *Bardizag and Its People*. (London: Gomidas Institute, 2014), p.209.

109

Erik Jan Zürcher, "The Ottoman Conscription System in Theory and Practice, 1844–1918,"*Arming the State: Military Conscription in the Middle East and Central Asia 1775-1925, Erik Jan Zürcher* (ed.), London, I. B. Tauris, 1999, p. 88.

of Berlin in 1878.[110] Ultimately, the exemption system framed non-Muslims as fiscal subjects rather than political citizens, revealing how Ottoman reforms, even when articulated in the language of equality, often entrenched uneven incorporation into the imperial order. This dynamic helps explain why Armenian revolutionaries and representatives of the Armenian Revolutionary Federation in the Ottoman Parliament sought to abolish the tax after the constitution was reinstated in 1908 and the Ottoman legislature reopened. Members of the Armenian Revolutionary Federation Dashnaktsutyun and Social Democrat Hunchakian Party also strongly criticized the mobilization of Ottoman soldiers to war zones, such as the conflict in Tripoli.[111] Notable figures like Krikor Zohrab voiced the concern that this constituted an additional burden on their communities. They argued that the tax placed disproportionate economic pressure on non-Muslim subjects and worsened existing inequalities between Muslims and non-Muslims including Jews, Greeks, and Armenians. The impact was especially severe for Armenians, one of the largest minority populations in the Empire.[112]

As political groups with socialist ideas grounded in an agenda of national liberation, Armenian revolutionaries could not support imperialist wars that would expand Ottoman control over new lands and provide the state with more taxable subjects. However, they had little power to influence Ottoman foreign policy and so their agenda focused instead on providing economic relief to Armenian peasants, who bore the brunt of the tax burden. In cases where peasants could not pay the tax individually, measures were taken to pay collectively. For example, in Bardizag,

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[110] Ohannes Kılıçdağı, "Ottoman Armenians and the Politics of Conscription," Ottoman History Podcast, Episode 382.https://www.ottomanhistorypodcast.com/2018/10/armenian-conscription.html (October 3, 2018).

[111] Yasar Tolga Cora, "The Istanbul Students Union of the Social Democrat Hnchakian Party and its Periodical Kaytz (1911-14)," in The Armenian Social Democrat Hnchakian Party: Politics, Ideology, and Transnational History (Ed.) Bedross Der Matossian, University of Nebraska, Lincoln, USA), 2025. p.234.

[112] Nesim Ovadya Izrail, *1915: Bir Ölüm Yolculuğu Krikor Zohrab.* (Istanbul: Kor Kitap, 2024), p.157.

church meetings were organized to coordinate communal payments to the tax collector. These collective measures, however, often came at a cost: poor families were forced into debt, wealthier individuals were able to secure exemptions, and class divisions within the community widened. Until its abolition in 1909–1910, the tax remained a cornerstone of Ottoman fiscal strategy and a powerful instrument of governance, extracting surplus, structuring class relations, and binding both Armenian households and their incomes to the financial reproduction of the empire. While internal taxes such as the *bedel-i askerî* transformed the life cycles of Armenian men into taxable resources, the arrival of the Ottoman Public Debt Administration in Bardizag extended this logic of extraction to agricultural production itself. Through its oversight of commodities such as silk and agricultural crops, the OPDA ensured that the wealth generated by Armenian peasants was increasingly subordinated not only to the Ottoman treasury but also to the demands of international finance.

## Բաժանորդագրութեան գիներու և վաճառքի պայմաններու հատուածը վերծանելը:

This is a rough translation from photos of the 1 September 1913 issue of *Meghu* ("The Bee"), published in Bardizag (Bahçecik), with the Armenian original and its French and Ottoman Turkish mastheads. The text is lithographed cursive with creases and stains, so I've marked uncertain readings with [brackets] and gaps with […]. Pages 1 and 2 are mostly readable; page 3 is patchy, and page 4 is too faint to give more than the gist.

Page 1

**Masthead and header**

*Meghu*. Subscription: Constantinople and the provinces, 20 piastres; abroad, 5 francs; single

copies sold by hand at 10 para. Address: Editorial Office of "Meghu," Bardizag. Dated 1 September 1913, New Series, Year 2, no. 34–86 [issue numbering as read].

**Editorial: "Festivals and Reflections" [title as read]**

The tragic events that took place at Ovajik during the recent festival days left deep and sorrowful impressions on us. Before long, these events will surely become history and, for many, sink into deep oblivion. But in the minds of all thinking people one question will remain lodged: "Until when will these savage, most wretched phenomena continue?"

It is on such phenomena that we [now wish to dwell], so that, with calmer dispositions, we may [view them…] [the end of this paragraph is unclear].

Festivals, among all nations, and among the Armenians since their pagan era, have had an important role and meaning as occasions for national gathering and for the shared enjoyment of joyful days. In ancient times festivals were inspired by the gods, and in the Christian period […]. They brought together under the same fields and roofs the king with the [commoner/army], the prince with the laborer, the merchant with the craftsman, every social class.

Such was Navasard, which our forebears celebrated with contests, trials of valor, national songs and military exercises. Such was the feast of [illegible, perhaps a pagan harvest or Mihr festival], with its fertility associations. Such are New Year, the Cross, Vardavar and other feasts, which after the coming of Christianity were also given a new religious coloring.

In past times, under the weight of tyrannical hands pressing on our heads, our fathers suffered devastation in their intellectual [life]. The zeal for gathering and common inspiration died, and festivals shrank in proportion to the narrowing of people's horizons of inspiration. The result was that those festival days became only days of drunkenness and intoxication, and the young came to think that festivity and joy could be celebrated only in that way.

It is undoubtedly along this path that Ovajik, together with its like, arrived at the anguish of lamenting innocent corpses. The [unquenchable] fire of [vengeance/humiliation] will long remain petrified in hearts.

Until when will this [illegible] last? When shall we return to the pure inspiration of the old days?

Page 2

**Article (heading damaged; the second word reads "…Պաշտպանողական," "protective/defensive")**

*Right column.* More than once we were compelled to take up the [embezzlements/falsifications] of the former tax collector (*tahsildar*) Bey. Not only were the irregularities we pointed out fully confirmed, but in the investigation opened by the Accounting Office (*muhasebe*) they amounted to 3–4,000 piastres. The government not only dismissed him but […] summoned the said person to Ovajik. This is one of the ailments of our government, about which this is not the first time we have spoken. [Damaged lines follow.] It is in the nature of the [protective arrangement] that it reveals the causes of our country's misfortunes and of the state apparatus's [laxity].

How was that arrangement operated? The guarantor, after the terms of the guarantee bond are laid out, points out that the government was obliged to audit the said tax collector's accounts every month. The guarantor would by law be responsible only for the [monthly shortfall]. Since the government failed to audit for a long time, and as a result the tax collector's debt grew, responsibility for the embezzlement falls on the government itself, and hence also [an arrangement for the remedy…] [continues on page 3].

*Left column.* History shows that in [closed/confined] populations such phenomena have sometimes been common and general. But Bardizag has found the road to improvement in this respect, ever since its relations with Constantinople began and the new generation began [to

gather] under school roofs. [Damaged line.] It is fortunate that public outbursts by groups are rare, but Bardizag still lacks [true inspiration and] communal enthusiasm.

By contrast, Ovajik and half of [a neighboring place, name unclear] are still far from a respect-inspiring nobility. There are still young men there who [consider it an honor to…]. There are many people there for whom drinking in the streets is ordinary, and who stain their hands with the blood of their own kind, and perhaps [feel] the heavy judgment of conscience. A lack of pure feeling reigns there.

It is the government's duty to prohibit, in [such circumstances], the expression of bad feelings. It is the duty of the village's leaders, through school and education, to uproot and kill these tendencies in the new generation.

The only means of salvation is this: […].

**Notice (boxed):** Readers who hold issues 1, 3, 7 and 8 of *Meghu*'s second year are asked to send them to the editorial office, on the understanding that they will receive another issue in exchange.

Page 3

*Left column (badly damaged).* It appears to continue the tax-collector matter. It mentions the accounting office's duty, a sum of about 150 piastres a month accumulating over about five years into a gap and debt of 3–4,000 piastres, and Ovajik. The last paragraphs are mostly illegible but seem to concern communal and cultural societies (possibly choirs).

*Right column.*

**Donors to *Meghu* (List no. 39):**

- Hagop Chelebian, 10
- [initials] (K. Aramian [?]), 5

- [name unclear], 20
- Dr. S. [Sinanian/Menavian?], 10
- Yervant [Yeghian?], 20
- Sum: 65
- Previous total: 2,685.5
- Grand total: 2,750.5 (in piastres, as the ledger seems to indicate)

**Advertisement:** Dr. Nerses Khachadurian, surgeon and dentist, of the National Hospital. From 1 July [he receives patients…], with hours marked 8–12 and 1:30–5:30. [The rest is unclear, but it says the hospital is prepared to treat…].

**"To the Subscribers of *Meghu*":** Those of our subscribers who have not yet paid their subscription fees are asked to hasten to do so [otherwise the paper cannot continue to be sent to them]. We also ask the esteemed editorial offices [of other papers] to exchange their papers with ours. *(Signed: The Editorial Office)*

Page 4

**Heading: probably "News."** This is a column of short local items, each marked with "× ×". I can make out only fragments:

- The American High School and the National School (*Azgayin Varjaran*) are to reopen on 2 September.
- Several items mention local clergy, a professor and a teacher, and a note about hosting or visits.
- A boxed notice is signed by several individuals (a "Miss" and a "Mrs." among them).
- Footer: Licensee/Proprietor (*Artonater*) [name hard to read, something like "H. Dzoulchian"]. Below it, "Bardizag."

## Sericulture and Tobacco Production under the Ottoman Public Debt Administration in Bardizag

By the late 19th century, fiscal centralization intersected with global finance, as the Ottoman Public Debt Administration assumed control over tobacco and silk. The rise of Ottoman public debt in the mid-nineteenth century mirrored global trends in international borrowing, but its burden fell disproportionately on the peasantry, as revenues from tobacco and silk were increasingly centralized and controlled. The revival of the tobacco production and silk industry in Bursa—driven by investments from both the Ottoman Public Debt Administration (OPDA) and the Ottoman government—must be situated within broader global economic shifts. After a period of expansion, the world economy entered a prolonged downturn between 1873 and 1894, known as the Great Depression. [113]As a peripheral economy reliant on agricultural exports, the Ottoman Empire was acutely vulnerable to shrinking international markets. Şevket Pamuk has argued that the Ottoman Empire functioned as a relatively small actor in international trade, with the notable exception of its role in the export of "Turkish" tobacco. Even then, the share of tobacco in overall Ottoman exports never exceeded 10 percent prior to 1913. This observation underscores the importance of situating tobacco production within both the limits of Ottoman participation in global markets and the mechanisms of fiscal extraction that sustained imperial finances. In this regard, the authority of the Ottoman Public Debt Administration (OPDA) over the taxation of tobacco production and sericulture was central. While Bardizag's tobacco did not rival the higher-quality crops of the Black Sea region, the OPDA sought to impose control over the Bursa–Izmit network on the assumption that enforcement would be more manageable there.

[113] Sevket Pamuk, "The Ottoman Empire in the "Great Depression" of 1873-1896," The Journal of Economic History, Vol.44.No.1 (March 1984), p.108

In practice, however, the extension of OPDA oversight exposed the fragility of state and quasi-state authority: smuggling proliferated among both Muslim and Armenian peasants, and those excluded from smuggling networks bore the heaviest burdens of taxation and enforcement.

The influx of cheap American wheat further eroded the competitiveness of Ottoman agriculture, prompting authorities to promote higher-value sectors like sericulture, which offered entry into specialized international trade circuits. Investments in silk production, particularly in Bursa and İzmit, thus represented not merely local initiatives but strategic efforts to adapt to the pressures of global capitalism. Bardizag's rural economy was therefore not an isolated agrarian system but a node within the empire's mechanisms of debt extraction, where peripheral labor sustained imperial obligations. In this configuration, Armenian peasants produced surplus that flowed outward and upward, away from local communities and into distant centers of political and financial power, embedding Bardizag's labor within a broader imperial-capitalist order. The establishment of the Ottoman Public Debt Administration (*Düyûn-ı Umûmiye*) drew Bardizag's Armenian labor force further into the empire's fiscal web, accelerating semi-proletarianization. Initially hesitant to borrow abroad, the Ottoman state issued its first bonds in 1854–55 to finance the Crimean War. By the 1870s, mounting obligations and the global crisis forced the empire to suspend payments in 1875 and default in 1876, making it the world's largest sovereign debtor. The final decades of the nineteenth century were thus marked by acute financial crisis, as foreign debt deepened imperial dependence and reshaped local economies.

Between the default of 6 October 1875 and the creation of the Debt Administration in December 1881, the empire endured a severe financial crisis: war expenses drained the Treasury, salaries went unpaid, and even the Imperial Ottoman Bank, under orders from London and Paris, refused a £T2,000,000 advance. In desperation, the government issued 1.8 billion piastres in

paper money between 1876 and 1877, despite previous prohibitions; within two years, the currency had lost roughly 65% of its value, and by 1880 redemption rates had fallen to just 10–15% of face value, highlighting the depth of the fiscal collapse.[114]

The restructuring of Ottoman debt after the 1875 default culminated in the establishment of the Ottoman Public Debt Administration (OPDA) in 1881. Created by imperial decree under heavy creditor pressure, the OPDA took direct control of key revenue sources—including customs duties, alcohol and stamp taxes, fishing rights, and the state monopolies on silk, tobacco, and salt. [115] Staffed by representatives of Britain, France, Germany, the Netherlands, and Italy, it functioned independently of the Ottoman government, channeling imperial revenues to European bondholders. Over time, its remit expanded from debt service to include infrastructure projects, particularly railways, embedding foreign financial control deep within the empire's fiscal machinery. The establishment of the Ottoman Public Debt Administration (OPDA) marked a turning point for Bardizag's rural economy. By placing the empire's revenues—particularly from silk and tobacco—under foreign control, the OPDA transformed local production into a site of fiscal extraction. For smallholding peasants, this meant shrinking autonomy and mounting pressure to operate within a system subordinating their labor to state monopolies and international creditors. The Régie's tobacco monopoly crystallized these dynamics, restricting access to formal markets and enforcing a tightly regulated system of collection and distribution.

In Bardizag, the OPDA operated from a community-owned building near the ghonakh, known locally as the mizan. The office was led by a director (*müdür)*, typically Turkish, along with several Armenian locals who served as secretary, inspector of weights and measures

[114] Edhem Eldem, "Ottoman Financial Integration with Europe: foreign loans, the Ottoman Bank and the Ottoman Public Debt," European Review, Vol.13, No.3 (2005), p.440-441.

[115] Note sur l'institution de l'administration de la Dette Publique Ottomane, sur son organisation et sur son fonctionnement, 1894, Salt Research, Ottoman Public Debt Administratiotaccessed date: 09/09/2025 https://archives.saltresearch.org/handle/123456789/109076

(*kantarci*), and guard (*kolcu*).[116] The localized branches functioned as extensions of the central authority, streamlining tax collection by ensuring responsibilities were carried out effectively at the local level.[117]

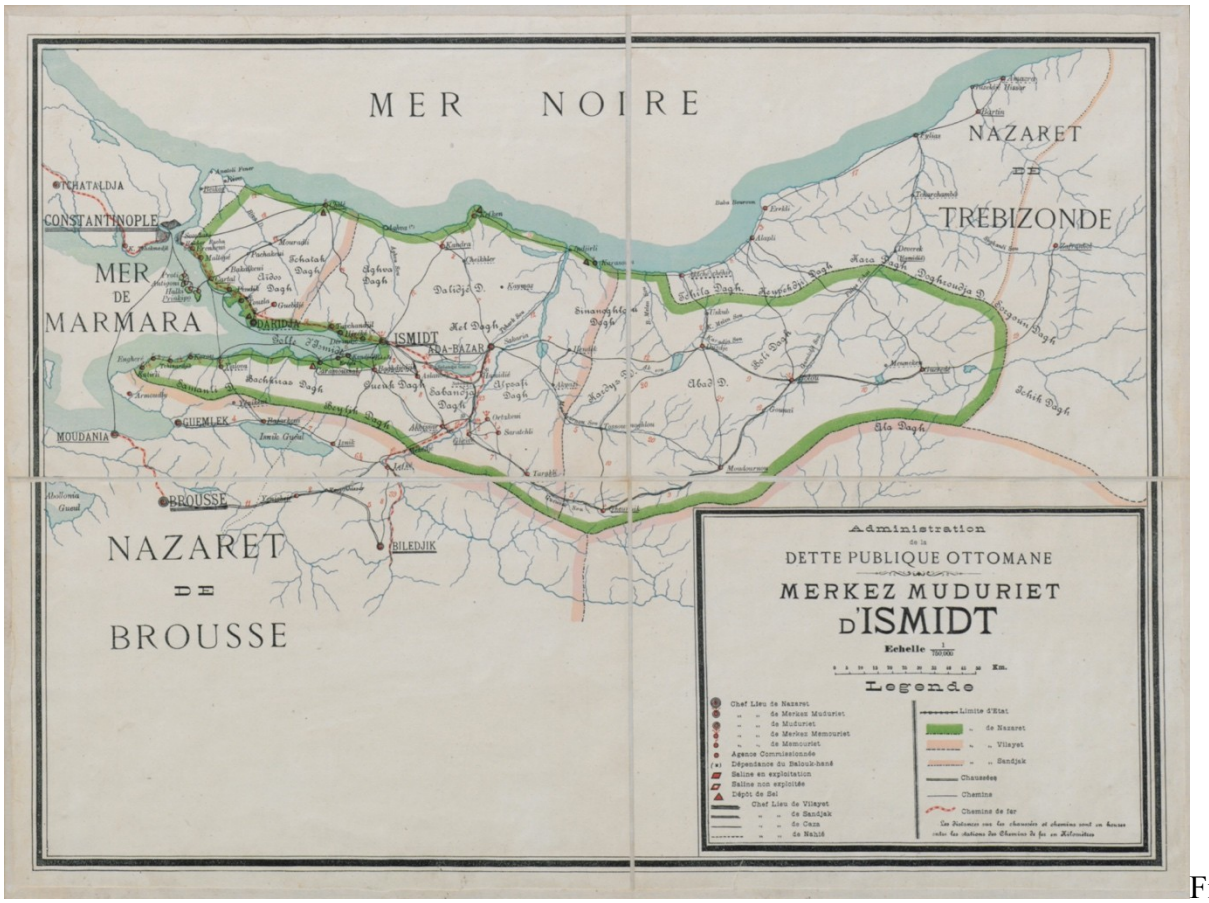


Figure X: *Düyun-u Umumiye İdaresi* Izmit. [118]

[116] Mkhalian,

[117] Yavuz Omer Akmil, From Duyun-u Umumiye Idaresi to Merkez Bankasi: Economy and Built Environment from the Late Ottoman to Early Republican Period, (Unpublished MA Thesis, Middle East Technical University, 2023), p.35

[118] Administration de la Dette Publique Ottomane, Merkez Mudiriet d'Ismıdt (Echelle: 1:1.750,000) - Düyûn-u Umûmiye İdaresi, İzmit Merkez Müdüriyeti (Ölçek: 1:1.750,000) - Ottoman public debt administration (Scale:1:1,750,000), Jacques Thobie Archive https://archives.saltresearch.org/handle/123456789/113030?mode=full (accessed date, 09/09/2025)

At first, Armenian peasants in Bardizag approached tobacco cultivation with considerable optimism, seeing it as a valuable opportunity to diversify their agricultural activities and improve their economic standing.[119] However, this initial enthusiasm was steadily eroded with the expansion of the Ottoman Tobacco Régie in the late nineteenth century. Through its monopoly on tobacco production, procurement, and taxation, the *Régie* inserted itself directly into rural life, effectively transforming peasant producers into contract-bound suppliers for a foreign-dominated syndicate.

The Régie, formally the *Société de la Régie Cointeressée des Tabacs de l'Empire Ottoman*, was established in 1884 as a state-sanctioned monopoly backed by European financial interests. Supported by a banking syndicate that included the Imperial Ottoman Bank, Austria's Credit-Anstalt, and Germany's Bleichröder, it operated under the authority of the Ottoman Public Debt Administration. By monopolizing not only tobacco production but also its sale and distribution, the Régie marked a decisive shift in Ottoman agrarian relations under the pressures of global capitalism. To secure a steady and predictable income, the Ottoman government established the Tobacco *Régie* in 1884, granting it a monopoly over the cultivation, purchase, export, and sale of tobacco. While this measure aimed to stabilize state finances by centralizing tobacco revenues, it simultaneously entrenched European control over one of the Empire's most lucrative sectors, further subordinating the Ottoman economy to external interests. Ottoman fiscal pressures intensified markedly in the late 19th and early 20th centuries. According to the Ottoman Public Debt Administration's records, revenues from six major taxes increased nearly 5.5 times between 1881 and 1911, reflecting the state's growing reliance on direct and indirect extraction from provincial populations. [120]

[119] Hagopian, *Պարտիզակը խաւտուտիկ*
[120] Quelques précisions sur l'administration de la Dette Publique Ottomane. Ses origines, Son Statut, Les résultats de son activité, p.19

In Bardizag, the Régie imposed a tightly regulated system that centralized tobacco collection, pricing, and auctioning, leaving local growers with little agency, as official and notarial records reveal. Although its charter nominally promised to safeguard producers' profits through public auctions, in practice the system overwhelmingly favored a narrow circle of authorized dealers. Bardizag's experience thus illustrates a broader dynamic of agrarian capitalism: the subordination of peasant production to commercial and financial imperatives, which in this case were directly tied to the Ottoman Empire's mechanisms of debt extraction and the servicing of imperial obligations.

The Régie established a monopoly not only over the sale and export of tobacco but also over key aspects of production, including pricing, quality control, and distribution. Intermediaries frequently manipulated prices to their own advantage, while producers were effectively excluded from broader market participation. As such, the Régie became a central mechanism through which the Ottoman countryside was drawn into global capitalist circuits, displacing local subsistence economies in favor of monocultural cash-crop production shaped by imperial financial interests. In the İzmit Sanjak, both individual and collective petitions reveal the intensity of grievances surrounding tobacco cultivation under the Régie monopoly. This monopolization had a profound impact on Bardizag's rural economy: peasants found themselves increasingly subordinated to the Régie's logistical and pricing mechanisms, which dictated not only how much tobacco they could sell but also at what price and to whom. Local autonomy over agricultural production was sharply curtailed, and dependency on a single, monopolized buyer exposed growers to greater financial vulnerability.

One collective petition, dated 13 February 1904, bears the signatures of the headmen, members, and imams of villages including Hamidiye, Ferhadiye, Nüzhetiye, Siretiye, Mamuriye,

Ümniye, Lütiye, Selimiye, Şevketiye, Hasaneyn, Nimetiye, İhsaniye, Hisareyn, Saraylı, İcadiye, Değirmendere, Bahçecik, and Örcün—most situated around Gölcük and closely tied to Bardizag's commercial networks.[121]

The petitioners protested that the Régie administration set purchase prices as low as 5 to 100 para for tobacco that cost 5 kuruş per kilo to produce, while also deducting additional fees under the categories of "taxable price," "supply," and "warehouse rent." Before the monopoly, they recalled, tobacco sold to merchants for 10–15 kuruş per kilo, a rate that at least covered production costs. By contrast, the Régie's artificially depressed prices left producers unable to recover even their basic expenditures. The headmen further emphasized the logistical hardships imposed by the monopoly system: warehouses were located across the sea, forcing villagers to transport tobacco for four to five hours by boat, often in stormy weather, without any shelter or compensation. Despite their repeated labor and risks, they were not paid in a timely manner. The petitioners demanded that Reji adopt a fairer pricing system, relocate warehouses to more accessible sites, and provide advance payments to alleviate the producers' suffering.

The petition thus highlights how price control became the decisive mechanism of subordination. By fixing low purchase prices and monopolizing access to legal markets, the Régie forced growers into dependency while simultaneously extracting surplus to service imperial debt. The headmen underscored additional burdens—warehouses located across the sea, four to five hours away by boat, often in stormy weather, without shelter, compensation, or timely payment. Yet at the heart of their complaint was the systematic devaluation of their labor through monopoly pricing, which rendered subsistence impossible and tethered Bardizag's peasantry ever more tightly to the fiscal demands of empire and international finance.

[121] Serdar Orsen, "20.yuzyil Baslarinda Izmit Sancaginda Tutun Uretiminde Karsilasilan Sikintilar ve Tutun Kacakciligi," p.1259.

This episode underscores how the fiscal and monopolistic structures of the late Ottoman state converged to extract surplus from rural communities. As the Public Debt Administration's own tables reveal, the amounts collected on six major taxes increased nearly 5.5 times between 1881 and 1911, disproportionately burdening non-Muslim peasants and petty producers. The Reji monopoly operated as part of this same apparatus: by enforcing low procurement prices, layering on deductions, and exploiting infrastructural bottlenecks, it transformed peasant households into fiscal units subordinated to both state centralization and foreign capital. In Bardizag and its surrounding villages, the cumulative effect was not only economic dispossession but also the erosion of communal resilience, binding rural Armenians ever more tightly to the coercive machinery of the Ottoman fiscal order.

The experience of tobacco smuggling in Bardizag offers a striking illustration of how semi-proletarianization unfolded in the late Ottoman countryside. Despite the Régie's reluctance to grant widespread cultivation rights, the village produced approximately 40,000 kilograms of tobacco annually, yielding local revenues of 4,000 to 5,000 Ottoman liras. Without legal access to the formal market, Bardizag's producers—many of them smallholding peasants—were effectively excluded from licit economic activity. In this context, smuggling emerged not merely as a form of resistance, but as a survival strategy for those unable to rely solely on subsistence farming or fully integrate into waged labor systems.

In Bardizag, peasants supplemented declining agricultural incomes through high-risk, high-reward contraband activity. Organized and often well-armed, local youth transported illicit tobacco by boat or horseback to cities such as Constantinople and Konya, embedding themselves in regional black-market circuits. These operations were frequently coordinated with Muslim Turkish partners, a strategic choice to navigate both ethnic tensions and state surveillance.

Yet while smuggling initially provided short-term relief from economic exclusion, it also exacerbated structural vulnerabilities. The focus on contraband tobacco led to the neglect of diversified, sustainable agricultural production, creating dependence on monoculture and the volatile dynamics of black-market pricing. As the state intensified enforcement and market fluctuations increased, the economic instability of Bardizag's rural households deepened.

Crucially, the benefits of this underground economy were unevenly distributed. Smuggling networks were typically controlled by wealthier individuals with access to transportation, weapons, and political protection, who captured most of the profits. Ordinary peasants bore the brunt of the physical risks and economic uncertainty. In this sense, the smuggling economy reinforced class divisions within the village and perpetuated patterns of semi-proletarianization: smallholders and land-poor families were pushed further into economic dependence, while wealthier actors consolidated control over labor, markets, and capital.

Seen through this lens, Bardizag's shift toward smuggling should not be romanticized as an act of peasant defiance. Rather, it should be analyzed as a symptom of broader processes of uneven capitalist incorporation. Ottoman modernization and fiscal centralization did not fully proletarianize the rural population; instead, they produced fragmented labor regimes in which wage work, petty production, and illicit economies coexisted. The result was a hybrid system in which peasants were partially commodified, perennially marginalized, and structurally dependent both on the land and on the shadow markets that emerged on its periphery.

As Murat Birdal highlights in his work on Ottoman public debt and financial administration, the Régie exemplified a broader trend in which monopolistic institutions, even when claiming to protect local producers, concentrated economic power and mediated rural production primarily for external profit. In Bardizag, tobacco cultivation thus shifted from a

potential engine of rural development into a site of structural economic control, narrowing opportunities for wealth generation and entrenching systemic inequalities.

To curb smuggling, the crop was assessed twice in the field, with the cultivator required to deliver the quantity agreed upon during the second assessment to the Régie's depots. Many growers, seeking to maximize profit, circumvented these rules. Some negotiated lower assessments with Régie officials, while others substituted inferior crops for delivery, reserving the best quality for illicit sale at higher prices. Although Bardizag lay within the officially designated tobacco zone, its limited arable land meant only small plots—typically held by one or two individuals—were available. This restriction curtailed participation in a potentially profitable crop and fostered economic disenfranchisement. In response, an illicit tobacco trade emerged, as villagers turned to smuggling to bypass the Régie's monopoly and regain access to closed markets. This illegal commerce served both as an economic necessity and as a form of resistance.

The Régie maintained its own kolcus (guards) to combat smuggling, operating by land and sea to track and confiscate illicit tobacco. The Ottoman government supported these enforcement efforts, ensuring that smugglers faced both state and corporate opposition. In Bardizag, limited farmland restricted cultivation to small plots. The Régie selectively issued permits to a few wealthy landowners, concentrating control over the trade and excluding poorer villagers. In response, many young men turned to smuggling to secure income, building a reputation for defiance and resourcefulness. Prominent figures included Biber Ardash, Biber Hovhannes, Bolig Hagop, Agosto Artin, Chatal Antranig, and Aksham Nigo. Later generations, such as Cavus Hovhannes, Atаments Krikor, Perkhadzin Vanes, Chinig Minas, and Bolig Barkev, continued this tradition, reinforcing Bardizag's central role in the informal tobacco

market and illustrating the local population's resilience in circumventing the Régie's monopolistic control within the Izmit-Adabazar region.[122]

In February 1896, Genç Ağazade Osman Efendi, who had undertaken the tax-farming (iltizam) of the *aşar* (tithe on agricultural produce) from the villages of Bağçecik, Cedid, and Sakarbağ in the district of İzmid, defaulted on his installment payments to the state treasury. Despite his contractual obligation, several payments remained outstanding. The case was subsequently transferred to the Ottoman Public Debt Administration (Düyun-ı Umumiye), which had jurisdiction over fiscal arrears related to state revenues. The Administration ordered that repayment be secured through the confiscation and liquidation of Osman Efendi's assets in İzmid, including a shop valued at nine liras. In accordance with procedure, notification was issued stipulating that, should payment not be rendered promptly, his property would be subject to forced sale to satisfy the debt, together with accrued interest and costs.[123]The matter was reviewed and confirmed by the İzmid Court of First Instance, which sanctioned the enforcement of the decision. The final certification and order of execution were registered on 26 February 1896**.**

In November 1896, a legal dispute emerged between Agop, son of Ohannes Gazarosyan, a resident of Bağçecik, and the Ottoman tobacco monopoly, the Reji Administration. Agop had delivered tobacco to the Reji warehouse in İzmit, but the officials claimed that his delivery was "contrary to the law" (*hilâf-ı kanun*). Specifically, they argued that the consignment was short by seventy okka (approximately ninety kilograms) and that a tax deduction of six hundred kuruş should therefore be imposed. On this basis, a case was brought against him.[124] Faced with the

[122] BOA Documents. Resul Narin, "Duyun-I Umumiye Idaresi vce Adapazari," *Karadeniz Arastirmalari*, Cilt:6, Sayi 21, Bahar 2009, p.53-56.
[123] Kocaeli Noter Defterleri 1, p.393.

[124] Kocaeli Noter Defterleri 1, Number 231. p.692

accusation, Agop appointed Ahmet Hamdi Efendi and Halil Rıfat Efendi as his legal representatives, granting them full authority to defend him in the courts, submit appeals, and handle all matters of litigation on his behalf. The formal authorization was recorded and validated with seals and witness testimony on 10 November 1896.

The charge against Agop reflects the strict regulatory framework of the Reji Administration, which had controlled tobacco cultivation, sale, and export in the Ottoman Empire since 1883. Under Reji law, peasants were required to deliver their tobacco in full, with accurate weight and proper registration. Any shortage, mismeasurement, or irregularity was deemed unlawful, effectively criminalizing practices that may have been routine within local agrarian exchange. The allegation that Agop's tobacco delivery was shortfall by seventy okka illustrates how the Reji monopoly scrutinized rural producers, enforcing its authority through both fiscal measures and legal action.

This episode underscores the entanglement of rural households in Bağçecik with the mechanisms of the Ottoman imperial economy. Far from being merely local agricultural producers, villagers such as Agop found themselves subject to legal disputes and financial penalties imposed by state-backed monopolies. In this way, the everyday transactions of tobacco cultivation and delivery became sites of contestation over legality, taxation, and the rights of peasants within the empire's fiscal and judicial order.

In Bardizag, the surplus generated through silkworm and tobacco farming rarely remained in the village. Rather than being reinvested in local infrastructure or improving workers' conditions, it was siphoned outward through trade and the mechanisms of the Ottoman Public Debt Administration (OPDA), which monopolized revenues from key commodities. By controlling tobacco auctions and silk sales, the OPDA compelled cash-poor peasants to sell their

harvests at low prices, while merchants and financiers captured the profits. Villagers supplied the indispensable labor for these industries, yet the gains flowed to imperial creditors and urban elites, leaving peasants with neither economic security nor wages sufficient to sustain life in the nahiye.

The emergence of the silk manufacturing industry in the Ottoman Empire in the 19th century led to the creation of two distinct socio-economic classes: an elite class of Armenian and Orthodox Christian merchants and factory owners, and a working class largely composed of women and girls employed in the silk spinning factories. This division is particularly evident in the central Anatolian regions like Bardizag, where the silk industry flourished, largely due to the investment of both local capital and the Pasteur method in sericulture. moment of revival spurred by technological and scientific innovations, such as Pasteur's disease-control methods.[125]

In 1888, the Ottoman government established the Silk Raising Institute (*Harir Darü't Talimi*) in Bursa under Kevork Torkomyan, an Ottoman Armenian and graduate of the Montpellier Agricultural School. Following Pasteur's methods, the institute trained over 2,000 students during Torkomyan's nearly three decades of leadership. Although the state had earlier expanded mulberry plantations around Bilecik in the mid-1880s, silk production remained dependent on imported silkworm eggs. The institute remedied this by producing healthy, locally bred stock, becoming central to the revival of the Bursa–İzmit silk industry.[126]

In Bardizag, sericulture depended on the seasonal intensification of silkworm labor. Peasants cultivated mulberry and supplied raw materials, including leaves and the other organic constituted for dyeing. Keri Topuzian yine: My father remembers his mother telling him that at

[125] In the 1870s, the French government commissioned Louis Pasteur to investigate and cure the silkworm sickness threatening their lucrative silk Pasteur developed a method known as Pasteur's System that relied on detailed examination of the silk moth eggs to separate healthy from diseased silkworms. Donald Quataert,

[126] Fatma Melek Arikan, *Ibid.*

night when they were in bed, they could hear the silkworms munching on mulberry leaves. Mulberry leaves were the staple food for silkworms. One of the challenges with the silk industry was to keep the worms healthy, and apparently, many Armenians would get training in Constantinople to become a "chemist" or a specialist in silkworm dynamics.

Silkworm breeding occurred during the spring months of April and May, a period that fell between the completion of plowing and sowing and the onset of threshing. For 40 to 50 days each year, entire families were mobilized, working long hours to meet production demands. The value generated flowed outward to silk merchants, imperial agents, and foreign buyers while what remained locally was an exhausted labor force and an increasingly fragile agrarian base.[127] Sericulture was therefore not simply a household pursuit but a microcosm of imperial-capitalist relations, where both ecological and human reproduction were subordinated to the imperatives of accumulation. [128] Before the adoption of the Pasteur method, however, the industry had experienced sharp decline, as silkworm diseases devastated stocks, leading to the closure of factories and breeding houses and forcing villagers to abandon what had once been their primary source of income.[129]

One of the earliest and most influential Armenian investors in sericulture Khachig Agha Avedian's Born into a modest Protestant family and orphaned at an early age, inherited a small sum from his widowed mother, who had labored as a servant in Constantinople. Using this modest capital, he initially established a bakery during a period of expanding commercial activity in Bardizag. Demonstrating keen entrepreneurial acumen, he soon expanded his business

[127] Donald Quataert, "The Silk Industry of Bursa, 1880-1914," p.X.

[128] John Bellamy Foster and Brett Clark, "Women, Nature, and Capital in the Industrial Revolution," Monthly Review, https://monthlyreview.org/2018/01/01/women-nature-and-capital-in-the-industrial-revolution/#fn5 (Accessed date, March, 21, 2025)

[129] Mkhalian, p.228

to include the sale of European flour, accumulating significant wealth and solidifying his position within the local mercantile elite.[130] Building on this commercial success, Avedian strategically entered the silk economy. This boom in the village economy was used by the Helvedjian house which, like the Mgerians, for a time, alongside the silk business, began to import great quantities of flour from Constantinople to satisfy public demand in Bardizag, Helvedjian was soon to be followed by a local merchant, Mr. Khachig Avedian who, thanks to his great success in the mercantile field, would become, in a very short time, a wealthy factory owner. After the establishment of the OPDA, Bardizag villagers, often cash-poor during the fresh cocoon season, sold their harvests at low prices through public auctions organized by the Ottoman Public Debt Administration. Avedian capitalized on this system, purchasing cocoons, stockpiling them with credit from financiers in Constantinople, and selling during off-season shortages to maximize profits. This commercial maneuvering positioned him as a leading figure in the local silk industry and a competitor to established operators like Hovhannes Efendi Helvedjian, who had previously managed the Saroukhanian enterprise

Bardizag followed the pattern of the Bursa region in the development of the silk industry toward the end of the 19th century. In 1894, the *Annuaire Oriental* highlighted the favorable conditions for silk-raising in the area, estimating that approximately 15,000 kilograms of cocoons were produced annually in the groves of Bardizag itself, while the entire nahiye produced about 35,000 kilograms.

By 1908, the *Annuaire Oriental* reported four filatures in Bardizag: Hadjik Avedian, Der Sahakian, Essayan, and Migurian. That year, Bardizag's production was estimated at around 10,000 kilograms of cocoons, while the entire nahiye produced approximately 200,000 kilograms. Some cocoons were sold to local merchants, including Hatchik Avedian, Der

[130] MKhalian, p.254

Garedian, Sahak der Sahakian, Essayan, Mugheian, Hadji Artin Kutnerian, and Hadji Kevork Kutnerian.The reference to "scientific methods" reflects the influence of the Silk Raising Institute in Bursa. Indeed, the *Annuaire Oriental* noted in 1907–1908 that, since the Institute's establishment, sericulture had significantly improved across the South Marmara region. Wage records from the silkworm houses in the Bardizag region offer valuable insight into the harsh economic realities faced by Armenian laborers in the late Ottoman Empire. Male workers employed seasonally, typically for nine to ten months, received modest monthly wages averaging between 3 and 4 Ottoman liras. By contrast, female workers, whose labor was indispensable yet systematically undervalued, earned about 3 kurush per day, totaling only around 8 liras for a full ten-month season. Placed against the backdrop of subsistence needs and increasing tax burdens, these figures underscore how Armenian households were trapped in enduring cycles of poverty. According to the 1908 annual report, 450 laborers were employed across the three filatures in the nahiye.[131] Kasabian provides detailed data on the workforce of the Avedian silk-spinning factory between 1910 and 1912. Operating with 98 spindles, the factory employed 117 workers in total, including 75 Armenian women and 42 Armenian Greek-Orthodox (*hai hrom*) laborers.[132] Supervision was carried out by seven Armenian and one Armenian Greek-Orthodox foreman. Female workers ranged in age from 13 to 60, with 35 of them between 13 and 16 years old. The workday lasted 10.5 hours, and wages reflected both age and experience: younger workers (13–16) earned 2–3 kurush per day, while older women received 3–6 kurush. Moreover, other filatures, owned by Mgerian & Basmadjian and K. Avedian, employed 315 workers, primarily women. These workers, too, worked for long hours (10 hours per day) and earned wages similar to those of their counterparts in Kurdbelen and Arslanbey. The harsh working conditions and

[131] Annuaire Orientale, 1908 p.1675-1676.

[132] Kasabian

meager pay were a defining feature of the silk industry's labor structure, which depended heavily on the exploitation of female labor.[133]

The reliance on such precarious and low-paying wage labor reflects a broader pattern of semi-proletarianization, in which rural Armenian communities increasingly depended on seasonal and gendered labor markets to survive. These communities were pushed into the margins—simultaneously exploited by imperial revenue demands and excluded from the benefits of economic modernization. The silkworm houses thus became sites not only of industrial activity, but also of intensified economic vulnerability and social stratification. By 1914, a year before the Armenian Genocide, Bardizag produced 15,000 kilograms of cocoons, while the entire region produced 35,000 kilograms.[134] This represents a significant decrease in production, suggesting a trend that warrants further research. The decline may reflect broader social and economic pressures in the region, including labor exploitation, environmental constraints, market fluctuations, and mounting political instability affecting rural Armenian communities. [135]

During the silk harvest, before the Public Debt, for example, when cocoons were gathered and processed using the traditional *mandjelekh* method, boiling the cocoons and hand-spooling silk onto spindles, the *reyis* (village headman) would be dispatched to inform households of the exact day their production would be assessed for the *öşür* tax. According to Mkhalian, the aghas appointed trusted village intermediaries to facilitate both the silk trade and tax calculation. These middlemen hosted silk buyers, announced market prices (e.g., the price per *tefe*, or 600 drams of silk), and coordinated the sale of silk between villagers and merchants. The *öşür* tax was then deducted directly from these transactions, embedding the state's extractive apparatus into the very fabric of peasant household economies. Through this system, taxation

[133] Mkhalian, p.256-257
[134] Annuaire Orientale, 1914, p.1371-1372.

[135] Annuaire Orientale, 1894, p.832.

functioned not only as a fiscal obligation but also as a mechanism of social control—binding producers to intermediaries and revenue farmers who operated under the Ottoman state control. The selective empowerment of local *aghas* to manage labor, arbitrate inheritance, and oversee commercial exchanges illustrates how imperial governance intersected with patriarchal and class hierarchies to sustain a semi-proletarianized labor force. It further reveals how even traditional and seemingly "domestic" modes of production—such as household silk spinning—were integrated into wider circuits of capital accumulation through coercive state mechanisms and elite mediation. [136]

These local experiences challenge historiographies that reduce Armenian society to a binary of elites versus peasants, instead showing the layered processes of semi-proletarianization

**Foreign Investments and the Loss of Autonomy**

During the global economic crisis between 1873 and 1894, the Ottoman state experienced increased difficulty servicing its international debts. [137] As a peripheral economy reliant on agricultural exports, the Ottoman Empire was acutely vulnerable to shrinking international markets. Şevket Pamuk has argued that the Ottoman Empire functioned as a relatively small actor in international trade, with the notable exception of its role in the export of "Turkish" tobacco. The OPDA, which was staffed by representatives of European nations, and which functioned independently of the Ottoman government, sought to invest in tobacco production in the Bardizag region, and to revive the silk industry in Bursa. This brought key Ottoman industries under the influence of foreign capital.

[136]Minassian, Kasabian P.97, Hagop der Hagopian, *Պարտիզակը խաւտուտիկ*

[137] Sevket Pamuk, "The Ottoman Empire in the "Great Depression" of 1873-1896," *The Journal of Economic History*, Vol.44.No.1 (March 1984), p.108.

At first, Armenian peasants in Bardizag approached tobacco cultivation with considerable optimism, seeing it as a valuable opportunity to diversify their agricultural activities and improve their economic standing.[138] However, this initial enthusiasm was steadily eroded with the expansion of the Ottoman Tobacco Régie in the late nineteenth century. Through its monopoly on tobacco production, procurement, and taxation, the Régie inserted itself directly into rural life, effectively transforming peasant producers into contract-bound suppliers for a foreign-dominated syndicate.

The Régie, formally *the Société de la Régie Cointeressée des Tabacs de l'Empire Ottoman*, was established in 1884 as a state-sanctioned monopoly backed by European financial interests. Supported by a banking syndicate that included the Imperial Ottoman Bank, Austria's Credit-Anstalt, and Germany's Bleichröder, it operated under the authority of the OPDA.[139] By monopolizing not only tobacco production but also its sale and distribution, the Régie marked a decisive shift in Ottoman agrarian relations under the pressures of global capitalism. To secure a steady and predictable income, the Ottoman government established the Tobacco Régie in 1884, granting it a monopoly over the cultivation, purchase, export, and sale of tobacco.[140] While this measure aimed to stabilize state finances by centralizing tobacco revenues, it simultaneously entrenched European control over one of the Empire's most lucrative sectors, further subordinating the Ottoman economy to external interests. Ottoman fiscal pressures intensified markedly in the late 19th and early 20th centuries. According to the OPDA's records, revenues

[138] Hagopian, *Պարտիզակը խաւտուտիկ,* p.356.

[139] Edhem Eldem, "Ottoman Financial Integration with Europe: foreign loans, the Ottoman Bank and the Ottoman Public Debt," *European Review*, Vol.13, No.3 (2005), p.440-441.

[140] Note sur l'institution de l'administration de la Dette Publique Ottomane, sur son organisation et sur son fonctionnement, 1894, Salt Research, Ottoman Public Debt Administratiotaccessed date: 09/09/2025 https://archives.saltresearch.org/handle/123456789/109076

from six major taxes increased nearly 5.5 times between 1881 and 1911, reflecting the state's growing reliance on direct and indirect extraction from provincial populations.[141]

The Régie established a monopoly not only over the sale and export of tobacco but also over key aspects of production, including pricing, quality control, and distribution. Local intermediaries frequently manipulated prices to their own advantage, while producers were effectively excluded from broader market participation. As such, the Régie became a central mechanism through which the Ottoman countryside was drawn into global capitalist circuits, displacing local subsistence economies in favor of monocultural cash-crop production shaped by imperial financial interests.[142] In the İzmit Sanjak, both individual and collective petitions reveal the intensity of grievances surrounding tobacco cultivation under the Régie monopoly. This monopolization had a profound impact on Bardizag's rural economy: peasants found themselves increasingly subordinated to the Régie's logistical and pricing mechanisms, which dictated not only how much tobacco they could sell but also at what price and to whom. Local autonomy over agricultural production was sharply curtailed, and dependency on a single, monopolized buyer exposed growers to greater financial vulnerability.

The history of sericulture in Bardizag mirrors that of tobacco, but additionally it provides perhaps the best insight into the local reconfiguration of gendered labor in response to shifting global financial pressure. By 1908, the *Annuaire Oriental* reported four filatures in Bardizag: Hadjik Avedian, Der Sahakian, Essayan, and Migerian. That year, Bardizag's production was estimated at around 10,000 kilograms of cocoons, while the entire nahiye

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[141] *Quelques précisions sur l'administration de la Dette Publique Ottomane. Ses origines, Son Statut, Les résultats de son activité,* p.19

[142] Yavuz Omer Akmil, *From Duyun-u Umumiye Idaresi to Merkez Bankasi: Economy and Built Environment from the Late Ottoman to Early Republican Period*, (Unpublished MA Thesis, Middle East Technical University, 2023), p.35

produced approximately 200,000 kilograms.[143] Some cocoons were sold to local merchants, including Hatchik Avedian, Der Garedian, Sahak der Sahakian, Essayan, Mugheian, Hadji Artin Kutnerian, and Hadji Kevork Kutnerian. The reference to "scientific methods" reflects the influence of the Silk Raising Institute in Bursa. Indeed, the *Annuaire Oriental* noted in 1907–1908 that, since the Institute's establishment, sericulture had significantly improved across the South Marmara region.

Wage records from the silkworm houses in the Bardizag region offer valuable insight into the harsh economic realities faced by Armenian laborers in the late Ottoman Empire. Male workers employed seasonally, typically for nine to ten months, received modest monthly wages averaging between 3 and 4 Ottoman liras.[144] By contrast, female workers, whose labor was indispensable yet systematically undervalued, earned about 3 piasters per day, totaling only around 8 liras for a full ten-month season. Placed against the backdrop of subsistence needs and increasing tax burdens, these figures underscore how Armenian households were trapped in enduring cycles of poverty. According to the 1908 annual report, 450 laborers were employed across the three filatures in the nahiye. Kasabian provides detailed data on the workforce of the Avedian silk-spinning factory between 1910 and 1912. Operating with 98 spindles, the factory employed 117 workers in total, including 75 Armenian women and 42 Armenian Greek-Orthodox (*hai-hrom*) laborers.[145] Supervision was carried out by seven Armenians and one

[143] (Ed.) R.César Cervati. *Annuaire Oriental du Commerce de l'Industrie de l'Administration et de la Magistrature* , 1908 p.1675-1676.

[144] Minas Kasabian, *The Armenians in the Province of Nicomedia.* (London: Gomidas Institute, 2019), p.201.

[145] The Hay Hroms are Armenian-speaking Christians belonging to the Greek Orthodox church. Historically, Hay Hrom communities lived in the region of Agn (modern day Kemaliye, Turkey) as well as in Nicomedia. Arda Ekşigil. *"The Hayhurum: A Forgotten Community of Armeno-Greeks in Ottoman Anatolia. In the Margins of Ottoman History: Revisiting the Ottoman Past. University of Oxford, 2015"* p.3. There were also a handful of villages established by Hemshin Armenian people in the north-eastern parts of the Adapazari kaza towards Bolu as well as communities in Hendek, Sapanca and Arifiye. Mahir Ozkan, "Izmit`in Hemsinli Koyleri," *Jineps Gazetesi*, 08/01/2023 https://jinepsgazetesi.com/2023/08/izmitin-hemsinli-koyleri/ (accessed date: 09/21/2026)

Armenian Greek-Orthodox foreman. Female workers ranged in age from 13 to 60, with 35 of them between 13 and 16 years old. The workday lasted 10.5 hours, and wages reflected both age and experience: younger workers (13–16) earned 2–3 piasters per day, while older women received 3–6 piasters. Moreover, other filatures, owned by Mgerian & Basmadjian and K. Avedian, employed 315 workers, primarily women. These workers, too, worked for long hours (10 hours per day) and earned wages similar to those of their counterparts in Kurdbelen and Arslanbey.[146] The harsh working conditions and meager pay were a defining feature of the silk industry's labor structure, which depended heavily on the exploitation of female labor.

These local conditions in Bardizag were symptomatic of wider regional trends; for instance, Nicole van Os and Yaşar Tolga Cora identify similar patterns of labor exploitation among Armenian women and children in the silk filatures of Adabazar while also highlighting the close relationship between women workers' organizing and the Armenian revolutionary movements. They describe a highly gendered and hierarchical labor system in which girls as young as eleven to fourteen prepared cocoons for the reelers, earning only 1–1.5 piasters per day. Adult women employed as reelers generally received between 2.5 and 5 piasters, although wages at the upper end of this range were exceptional. A third, much smaller group of women performed more skilled tasks, including winding hanks, packaging, weighing, and grading raw silk, for which they typically earned 5 piasters and could occasionally receive modest performance bonuses. Their account demonstrates how age, gender, and skill structured labor within the filatures while exposing the exceptionally low wages paid to the vast majority of female workers.

The reliance on such precarious and low-paying wage labor reflects a broader pattern of semi-proletarianization, in which rural Armenian communities increasingly depended on

[146] Kasabian, *Ibid.*

seasonal and gendered labor markets to survive. These communities were pushed into the margins simultaneously exploited by imperial revenue demands and excluded from the benefits of economic modernization. The silkworm houses thus became sites not only of industrial activity, but also of intensified economic vulnerability and social stratification. By 1914, a year before the Armenian Genocide, Bardizag produced 15,000 kilograms of cocoons, while the entire region produced 35,000 kilograms.[147] The decline in production suggests that the prosperity generated by silk cultivation was already under strain. Yet rather than marking the failure of the silk industry itself, this decline reveals the increasingly precarious conditions under which Armenian labor and production operated in the late Ottoman Empire. As economic pressures intensified, the productive capacities that Armenian communities had built over generations became increasingly susceptible to appropriation. Understanding this process requires situating "Armenianness" within broader structures of imperial and capitalist domination. As Nancy Fraser argues, capitalism depends not only the exploitation of formally free workers but also on the expropriation of populations denied such freedom. Drawing on the historical distinction between free white workers and enslaved Black subjects in the Antebellum South , Fraser shows that the subjection of the expropriated often serves as a hidden condition for the exploited. [148] This framework helps illuminate the structural violence directed against Armenians in the late Ottoman Empire.

The Armenian Genocide transformed this vulnerability into systematic dispossession. Through Fraser's distinction between exploitation and expropriation, the destruction of Bardizag can be understood not merely as the elimination of an Armenian community but as the forcible

[147] (Ed.) R.César Cervati. *Annuaire Oriental du Commerce de l'Industrie de l'Administration et de la Magistrature* 1914, p.1371-1372.

[148] Nancy Fraser, *Cannibal Capitalism*. (London, NY: Verso Books, 2022), p.34-35, p.114-115.

transfer of its labor, property, and productive capacities. The conscription of Armenian men into labor battalions, the confiscation of property, and the deportation of the population dismantled the social and economic networks that sustained silk production. The pre-1915 decline of the industry and the genocide itself were thus not separate developments but interconnected stages in the destruction of an Armenian economic world. Bardizag reveals how genocide functioned simultaneously as annihilation and economic reorganization, facilitating the incorporation of Armenian wealth, land, and productive resources into the emerging Turkish national economy.

**Conclusion**

The transformation of the Bardizag between 1850 and 1914 provides a definitive window into the structural logic of the late Ottoman economy. Rather than a linear transition from feudalism to a fully "free" proletariat, the Armenian peasantry in Bardizag experienced a gendered and class-based restructuring driven by the dual pressures of state extraction and global capital. This paper has demonstrated that the household, rather than the individual, served as the primary adaptive unit through which the peasantry negotiated the rising demands of the market and the state.

Each of the primary taxes I examined functioned not only to extract revenue or labor for the state but also to integrate Bardizag into broader capitalist circuits: 1) The charcoal tax forced villagers to commodify natural resources, destabilizing subsistence economies and pushing households toward cash dependency 2) The road tax mobilized male labor for state infrastructure while undermining their status as free proletarians, redirecting household work and intensifying reliance on women and children for both domestic and wage labor and 3) the military service exemption tax monetized military obligations, creating debt pressures and exacerbating class and sectarian inequalities.

The tobacco and sericulture industries demonstrate the direct influence of international finance on the local patterns of production in Bardizag. In the case of tobacco, local farmers were forced to produce and sell on terms dictated to them from afar. As male workers were pulled into more migratory labor patterns, women were increasingly pulled into industries such as sericulture, but on deeply unequal terms. To supplement meagre remittances, women were forced to work for a pittance in the silk factories, while still retaining responsibility for traditionally gendered labor. As seen in West's and Bodourian's anecdotes at the beginning of this article, industry arrived hand-in-hand with the perpetuation of informal and subsistence labor: women doing the washing in the streets and traditional crafts surviving through systems of barter.

These fiscal regimes, combined with industrial decline and migration patterns, made Armenian peasants simultaneously vulnerable to state and market pressures and innovative in their strategies of survival. Men's seasonal migration, women's expanded productive roles, and household adaptations to monetized obligations exemplify how Bardizag's peasants actively negotiated the demands of early capitalist encroachment. By linking labor, gender, and class to the mechanics of fiscal extraction, Bardizag demonstrates how rural communities confronted the forces of economic vulnerability with adaptive strategies.

## CHAPTER 4: The Material Foundations of Revolution: Labor, Social Reproduction and Political Capacity in Late Ottoman Bardizag

*We address our words to those socialist organizations that operate in the name of the working class. We remind them that they can justify their existence only through their work for the working class; the time has come for them to pay closer attention to this matter and to organize those who have a stake in their cause and are ready, at any moment, to lend a hand, namely, the working class itself.*[149]

Introduction: The revolutionary capacity of late Ottoman Bardizag did not emerge from an intellectual void, nor was it created from above by clandestine political parties operating outside everyday life. To understand how revolutionary politics took root, it is therefore essential to examine the material and institutional structures that preceded it. Long before explicit political crisis, schools, newspapers, credit banks, retail cooperatives, and occupational associations organized the everyday conditions of social reproduction. Over time, these institutions accumulated a reservoir of collective capacity: shared literacy, pooled financial resources, organizational experience, and networks of mutual trust that extended beyond the immediate workplace. Revolutionary politics did not invent these forms of organization from scratch. Rather, it embedded itself within this existing social infrastructure, translating everyday pressures—wage instability, food inflation, and indebtedness—into a shared critique of class and state exploitation. In this sense, revolutionary action was a mediating practice: it redirected established forms of communal survival toward explicitly political ends. As Hester Donaldson Jenkins observed, Bardizag was marked by "considerable intellectual activity," pointing to a

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[149] "Խմբագրական: ԿԱՋՄԱԿԵՐՊՈՒԹԵԱՆ ՊԷՏՔԸ," *ՄԵՂՈՒ*, October 7, 1912 (Year 2, Issue No. 49).

local culture in which education, discussion, and the exchange of ideas were already deeply embedded.[150] This intellectual life helped create the conditions in which social observation could become political engagement. Through schools, associations, newspapers, labor networks, and other institutions, Bardizag's inhabitants connected local concerns to wider Armenian political movements, turning knowledge of their community into concrete forms of collective action. Revolutionaries thus emerged from Bardizag not as outsiders arriving to transform the town, but as products of its own intellectual and social life who carried their experience outward and sought, in turn, to transform the community from which they came.

The political significance of this institutional world became particularly visible in the aftermath of the Adana massacres. On April 21, 1909, fifty men from Bardizag volunteered to march to Constantinople in defense of the Constitution. Only days earlier, Armenians in Adana had been subjected to mass violence, while missionaries had been killed in nearby Tarsus. Yet the crisis did not lead the Armenians of Bardizag to withdraw from political life. Instead, they organized against the massacres in Adana. Writing to Mr. W.W.Peet, the treasurer Missions American Board in Turkey Bible House Constantinople, Dr. Robert Chambers recorded the decision with striking brevity: "I hope you are all on the right side of Constantinople!". [151] The decision to mobilize, however, did not emerge from an isolated revolutionary organization It drew upon decades of institution-building through which people had learned to educate children, circulate information, obtain credit, organize work, and assist one another in moments of

[150] Hester Donaldson Jenkins, "Armenia and the Armenians," *The National Geographic Magazine*, Vol.XXVIII, No.4, October 1915, p.343.

[151] Transfer 128, Caa to Dy, Index No. 67. Ce to Ch. 1908-11-05/1909-09-13, Constantinople (Istanbul, Turkey), Tarsus (Turkey), Adana (Turkey), Bardezag (Bahçecik), Latakia (Syria), Mersine (Mersin, Turkey), *SALT Research* https://archives.saltresearch.org/handle/123456789/211126

insecurity. In moments of political crisis, these established practices could be redirected toward collective political action.

The Adana massacres themselves reveal the importance of these connections. Robert Tatoyan estimates that approximately 15.000-18.000 Armenians were killed in the massacres and argues that at least one-third of those killed were killed in the massacres. [152] Despite the Ottoman Constitution of 1908 and its formal guarantees of equality and protection for all imperial subjects, regardless of religious affiliation, the constitutional regime failed to prevent the eruption of violence.[153] As Ümit Kurt rightly underscores, Der Matossian's analysis offers a fresh perspective on the causes and processes that culminated in the 1909 Adana massacres. Rather than treating the violence as an isolated episode, Der Matossian situates it within the broader revolutionary movements of the period, emphasizing the erosion of social and political stability in Cilicia, the weakness of public-sphere institutions, and the intensification of existing economic tensions and class antagonisms, all of which contributed to the targeting of the vulnerable Armenian population.[154]

The presence of migrant workers in Adana also reveals the importance of mobility to Armenian collective life. [155] Workers moved between villages, towns, and regions in response to changing economic opportunities while maintaining social, familial, and communal connections across geographic boundaries. Economic mobility thus created more than circuits of labor. It

[152] Robert Tatoyan, "On the Armenian Death Toll and Demographic Impact of the 1909 Adana Massacres," *International Journal of Armenian Genocide Studies* 9, no. 2 (2024): 1-12.

[153] Հ. ՄԱՍԻԿԵԱՆ, "ՔԱՂԱՔԱԿԱՆ ԼՈՒՐԵՐ," *ԱՒԵՏԱԲԵՐ*, vol.62, 1909, p.628 https://archives.saltresearch.org/handle/123456789/226799 (Accessed date: 09/28/2026).

[154] Umit Kurt, "The Hunchakian Revolutionary Party in Cilicia: Aintab as a Case Study," *Armenian Review*, Vol.57, No.1-2, 2020, p.110.

[155] Tatoyan, *Ibid.*

generated networks through which Armenians exchanged information, found employment, established economic relationships, provided mutual assistance, and responded collectively to political crises.[156] These networks developed through the everyday experiences of work, migration, indebtedness, commerce, communal organization, and political uncertainty. Economic life could therefore become a foundation for political action, just as political crises could strengthen existing forms of economic and communal solidarity. The fifty men who prepared to march from Bardizag were consequently part of a much larger Armenian world whose connections extended far beyond individual villages and provinces.

The aftermath of Adana drew Bardizag into that world in another way. Simon Zavarian, a founder of the ARF, took up the question of Armenian reconstruction after the massacres.[157] (Avadis Book,) His report proposed that families deprived of income by the killing of Armenian workers receive financial support or compensation from the government for ten years. It also proposed orphanages and industrial schools in Haçin and Hasanbeyli, with the remaining orphans transferred to Bardizag and Adapazarı. [158] Bardizag was thus imagined not only as a place from which political activists emerged but also as a place capable of receiving, housing, educating, and training survivors of violence elsewhere. That capacity had been built before 1909. The Armenian Church anchored communal life through its parishes and schools, while the American missionary orphanage, founded in 1897 after the Hamidian massacres, had spent more than a decade housing and training displaced children.

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[156] *Ibid.*

[157] "Simon Zavarian," *Hairenik*, https://hairenik.com/vfp/zavarian/?srsltid=AU7gw4WqulZMT6aUDiQ52roAfYJ3K5UwdLAokDhqL4I73omOXRQAFIXd (Accessed date: 10/04/2026)

[158] Bedross Der Matossian, *The Horrors of Adana: Revolution and Violence in the Early Twentieth Century* (Stanford University Press, 2022), p. 211.

The juxtaposition of the fifty men preparing to march and the orphans who were to be brought to Bardizag points toward the central question of this chapter: what material and institutional conditions made such collective capacity possible? Revolutionary mobilization and the care of displaced children might appear to belong to separate histories. I argue, however, that they were connected through the institutions and practices of social reproduction that sustained Armenian communal life. Schools, churches, newspapers, credit institutions, cooperatives, occupational associations, households, and charitable institutions reproduced not only people and labor but also the relationships, knowledge, resources, and organizational skills through which collective action could occur. Revolutionary organizations entered this already organized social world and redirected some of its existing capacities toward political action.

**Social Reproduction and Production of Collective Capacity**

This chapter treats transformations in labor, production, credit, mobility, household life, and political organization as mutually constitutive dimensions of communal struggle. Marx located production behind the visible surface of commodity exchange, in what he called the "hidden abode of production." Nancy Fraser has extended this insight by asking what lies behind that hidden abode: the forms of social reproduction that sustain workers, households, institutions, and social relations. [159] I use social reproduction to describe the material and institutional processes through which people sustained households, labor, education, care, consumption, credit, and communal relationships. These processes did more than reproduce individuals and households: they generated relationships, skills, knowledge, resources, and forms of coordination that could be mobilized beyond the immediate requirements of everyday life.

[159] Nancy Fraser, "Behind Marx's Hidden Abode: For an Expanded Conception of Capitalism," *New Left Review* 86 (March–April 2014): 60, https://doi.org/10.64590/kdf.

I use collective capacity to describe the ability produced through these processes to circulate information, pool resources, coordinate labor, establish trust, and act collectively. This capacity was not located in any single institution. Schools, newspapers, churches, credit institutions, cooperatives, occupational associations, households, and charitable organizations provided different organizational forms through which resources and relationships could accumulate and persist. Institutions therefore served as the infrastructure through which collective capacities were produced, maintained, and sometimes redirected**.** Revolutionary organizations could then mobilize some of these capacities for explicitly political purposes.

This approach also makes it possible to situate Bardizag's changing labor relations within a broader transformation of social life. The expansion of wage labor, commercial production, indebtedness, and monetary exchange did not simply dissolve existing communal relationships. It altered the conditions under which households and communities reproduced themselves, creating new forms of vulnerability alongside new forms of cooperation and organization. Semi-proletarianization therefore needs to be understood not only as a transformation in the organization of labor, but also as a process that reshaped the material conditions from which collective capacities could emerge.

Beverly Silver's work is useful here because it draws attention to the relationship between capitalist development and workers' capacity to organize. Processes that deepen dependence on markets and wage labor can simultaneously create new forms of concentration, interdependence, and collective power. Bardizag presents a related but distinct configuration. Commercialization and wage dependence developed alongside household production, credit networks, communal institutions, and forms of mutual organization. The resulting social formation was therefore shaped by competing pressures of dependence, cooperation, and institutional organization. The

political capacities that emerged in the late Ottoman period were rooted in these material relations rather than existing separately from them.

**Differentiating Infrastructures of Collective Life**

The institutions through which Armenians in Bardizag organized collective life were not a single, undifferentiated infrastructure; they performed different functions and operated through distinct relationships to authority, labor, and political action. The Armenian Church and its associated schools and charities provided a foundation for communal reproduction, sustaining religious belonging, education, charity, ritual, and moral authority. At the same time, the Armenian Patriarchate served as a principal intermediary between Armenian communities and the Ottoman state, representing communal interests and regulating matters of taxation, property, education, and administration. Through its local institutions, the Church thus organized both Armenian communal life and its relationship to Ottoman sovereignty. It consequently occupied an ambivalent position: sustaining forms of communal autonomy while simultaneously mediating Armenians' incorporation into the imperial order.

Yet the Church also intervened materially in economic life. The forty-para token issued by Surp Hagop Church in 1855 can be placed within a broader Ottoman Balkan practice in which churches and other communal institutions issued local coins or tokens, sometimes to supplement scarce small denominations. The church board of Gabrovo of Bulgaria, for instance, lent its own coins to residents at one percent monthly interest, extending its role from circulation into credit.[160] The Bardizag token shows a parish institution participating directly in the organization

[160] Nikolay Nenovsky and Penchev, Denchev Pencho. "Money without a State: Currencies of the Orthodox Christians in the Balkan Provinces of the Ottoman Empire (17th-19th Centuries)," *The Review of Austrian Economics*, 29 (1), July 2016. DOI:10.1007/s11138-014-0281-9 Kenneth MacKenzie and Samuel Lachman, *Countermarks of the Ottoman Empire 1880–1922* (London: Spink & Son, 1974) Kenneth MacKenzie, *"*Armenian Church Tokens used in the Ottoman Empire*", International Bank Note Society Journal*, 17/2, pages 85-94.

of monetary exchange, but the evidence is limited. It establishes the denomination, date, and association with the church, and it does not establish how widely the token circulated, which transactions employed it, who accepted it, or whether it could be converted into Ottoman currency.



[161]

It cannot support the claim that Bardizag possessed a developed local currency system. It does demonstrate that communal institutions could mediate economic relations as well as religious and social ones. The Church therefore belonged to the material infrastructure of communal life without being reducible to an economic or revolutionary institution. Its authority operated through established forms of religious and communal hierarchy, and its relationship to political organization remained contingent rather than inherent.

Histories of late Ottoman Armenian revolutionary politics have often been written through political organizations, ideological movements, and episodes of violence, and political mobilization has frequently been treated as detached from the material conditions of daily economic life.[162] Traditional Ottoman scholarship has marginalized capitalism as an analytical category and left labor struggles and communal organizing outside its core concerns. When socialism is addressed, it is often presented as an intellectual import, introduced by non-Muslim

[161] "Istanbul, Bardizag, Bahçecik / ԲԱՐՏԻԶԱԳ - Surp Hagop Church / St. James Church -Saint Jacques," *Armenian Numismatic Research Organization* https://armnumres.org/bardizag-bahecik-surp-hagop-church-st.-james-church/istanbul-bardizag-bahecik-surp-hagop-church-st.-james-church-40-para (accessed date: July 13, 2025)

[162] Articles.

minorities whose connections to Europe exposed them to European ideas. This idealist interpretation obscures the material relations through which socialist consciousness developed. In the provinces, class consciousness was also produced through labor exploitation, indebtedness, fiscal extraction, declining economic autonomy, and state coercion.

A growing body of scholarship situates Ottoman radicalism within the social and material conditions of particular regions. Dzovinar Derderian examines provincial Armenian communities in Eastern Anatolia, Zozan Pehlivan focuses on Ottoman Kurdistan, and Toygun Altıntaş traces Armenian revolutionary politics across Central Anatolia and Sasun. Yaşar Tolga Cora's work on Armenian labor, including his study with Nicole van Os of women silk workers in Adapazarı, foregrounds workplace relations, gender, community, and socialist organization, and Stefo Benlisoy reconstructs the multiethnic labor and socialist politics of late Ottoman Istanbul. A growing body of scholarship situates Ottoman radicalism within the social and material conditions of particular regions. Dzovinar Derderian examines provincial Armenian communities in Eastern Anatolia, Zozan Pehlivan focuses on Ottoman Kurdistan, and Toygun Altıntaş traces Armenian revolutionary politics across Central Anatolia and Sasun. Yaşar Tolga Cora's work on Armenian labor, including his study with Nicole van Os of women silk workers in Adapazarı, foregrounds workplace relations, gender, community, and socialist organization, and Stefo Benlisoy reconstructs the multiethnic labor and socialist politics of late Ottoman Istanbul.

Önder Eren Akgül extends this materialist approach to the agrarian sphere, drawing on W. E. B. Du Bois to situate the 1908 Revolution within the political economy of dispossession, land, labor, and class conflict. His account of peasant land occupations as a form of "constitutionalism of the dispossessed" highlights how struggles over property and labor shaped the possibilities and limits of revolutionary transformation. Together, this scholarship moves the

history of Ottoman radicalism away from a model of ideological diffusion toward political mobilization rooted in local social relations, class conflict, and material conditions. Yet we still know less about how everyday economic institutions and household relations in provincial Armenian communities shaped the reception and practice of socialist and revolutionary politics. This chapter aims to address this gap.

Two microhistories of the region sharpen the point. Ümit Kurt shows that in Adapazarı in 1911 the invocation of the Adana massacres turned a local dispute into a question of anticipated violence, which Muslim and Christian residents contested through petitions and alliances.[163] Violence had a political life beyond the place and moment of its enactment: it could be remembered, anticipated, invoked, and resisted. Cora shows that homeland associations were among the most durable forms of migrant solidarity in the late empire, and that Armenian porters and migrant workers organized through such networks played important roles in the 1895 Kumkapı demonstrations and the 1896 occupation of the Ottoman Bank. [164] Bardizag's cooperatives, schools, and financial institutions did something similar, with one difference. Cora's associations linked migrants to places of origin, whereas Bardizag's institutions were embedded directly in the economic and social reproduction of the community itself.

The chapter draws on the structural interventions of Beverly Silver, Giovanni Arrighi, and Şahan Savaş Karataşlı. Beverly Silver and Eric Slater's account of hegemonic transition describes periods of intensified inter-elite conflict and subordinate unrest that produce decades of social turbulence and end when a new order contains the conflict through cooptation and repression. The era from the Tanzimat to 1915 fits this pattern, and Bardizag's mobilization

[163] Ümit Kurt, "1911'de Toplumsal Hassasiyetleri Kaşımak: Osmanlı Adapazarı'nda Bir Provokasyon Arayışı," #Tarih, Ağustos 2021, pp. 56-59.

[164] Yaşar Tolga Cora, "Institutionalized Migrant Solidarity in the Late Ottoman Empire: Armenian Homeland Associations (1800s–1920s)," *New Perspectives on Turkey* 63 (2020): 55–79. https://doi.org/10.1017/npt.2020.16.

belongs to this long turbulence, as does the violence that ended it. Silver and Karataşlı also show that in such periods class relations are reconfigured: segments of the working-class form and dissolve, and are differentiated along lines of gender, ethnicity, and citizenship. Bardizag's semi-proletarianized households, women silk and factory workers, migrant laborers, and the devaluation of non-Muslim labor appear within this framework.

These institutions did not constitute a unified political movement. Their significance lay in the different capacities they generated and the relationships they made available for collective action. Revolutionary organizations could draw upon networks of literacy, communication, credit, labor, sociability, and trust that had developed through everyday communal life. Political organization thus represented a particular mobilization of capacities produced across a much wider institutional field. The following sections trace how these capacities were activated through Armenian revolutionary movements in Bardizag, and how political repression increasingly brought the ordinary institutions of communal life under state surveillance.

***Region and violence***

The Southern Marmara provides a useful setting in which to reconsider these relationships. Unlike the eastern provinces that have dominated scholarship on Armenian agrarian conflict, the region was closely connected to Constantinople through labor migration, commerce, transportation, print, and political networks. It served as an intellectual and material backyard for the capital's revolutionary underground: secret branches in İzmit, Bardizag, and Bursa sustained the Constantinople committees, smuggled weapons, and funded publications such as the ARF's *Azadamard*.

The comparison with Eastern Anatolia is useful primarily for clarifying what Bardizag is, and is not, a case of. In parts of the east, Hamidian violence contributed to the displacement of

Armenian peasants and the transfer of their land to Kurdish tribal chiefs and other Muslim actors, as Janet Klein's work on land, local power, and protection has shown.[165] The Southern Marmara evidence does not permit the same claim on the same scale. Ryan Gingeras demonstrates that the region was neither peripheral to the transformations of the late empire nor reducible to intercommunal conflict.[166] The relative absence of sustained large-scale communal violence in Bardizag should not be mistaken for an absence of coercion. Conflict took the form of disputes over land and forest access, labor and production, petitions, surveillance, migration, and negotiations with local officials. Relative stability was one possible outcome of continuing negotiation among communities, state officials, migrants, and regional elites.

Violence elsewhere remained materially and politically present in Bardizag. Survivors and orphans arrived through missionary networks, information about massacres circulated through newspapers and political organizations, Ottoman intelligence monitored Armenian mobility and association, and activists interpreted local conditions in light of violence elsewhere. The geography of violence was uneven, but its effects were not geographically contained. Similar care is needed with Muslim migration. The settlement of Circassian and Georgian migrants after the Russo-Ottoman War of 1877–78 could generate competition over land, forests, and local authority, but it should not be retrospectively collapsed into genocidal expropriation. Settlement could involve conflict and dispossession, and it could also produce economic integration and negotiated coexistence.[167] Bardizag's history therefore supports neither a model in

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[165] Janet Klein, "Conflict and Collaboration: Rethinking Kurdish-Armenian Relations in the Hamidian Period, 1876-1909," *Int. J. Turkish Studies* Vol. 13, Nos. 1&2, 2007.

[166] Ryan Gingeras, *Sorrowful Shores: Violence, Ethnicity, and the End of the Ottoman Empire, 1912-1923* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2009).

[167] Hamed-Troyansky, Vladimir. 2024. *Empire of Refugees : North Caucasian Muslims and the Late Ottoman State.* Redwood City: Stanford University Press. https://public.ebookcentral.proquest.com/choice/PublicFullRecord.aspx?p=31018077.

which revolutionary politics followed an escalating sequence of communal violence or an image of the town as an exceptional zone of peace.

## Revolutionary Politics as Institutional Practice

### *The emergence of the movement*

As Houri Berberian underlines, the emergence of the Armenian revolutionary movement in Bardizag should be situated within the broader transformations of the late Ottoman Empire: changes in governance, taxation, economic pressure, and insecurity, alongside new opportunities created by education, print culture, and associational life.[168] Bardizag became increasingly connected to this network in the 1880s and 1890s. The Armenakan organization reportedly had a presence by 1882, followed by the Social Democrat Hunchakian Party and, later, the ARF.[169] The important question is not simply when these organizations arrived, but what allowed political organization to take root locally.

It depended on institutions that already organized everyday communication. Coffeehouses, schools, churches, newspapers, and personal networks provided spaces in which political developments could be discussed. Amasyalı, who had previously run a coffeehouse in İzmit, arrived in Bardizag around 1890 after reportedly being imprisoned in Istanbul for his political activities.[170] He cultivated relationships with students and introduced younger Armenians to discussions of the Armenian Question. Students were not passive recipients. They became part of the networks through which political consciousness was reproduced and extended. The same years brought the town's first appearance in the international press as a site

[168] Houri Berberian, *Roving Revolutionaries: Armenians and the Connected Revolutions in the Russian, Iranian, and Ottoman Worlds* (Oakland, California: University of California Press, 2019). https://www.degruyter.com/viewbooktoc/product/540921.

[169] Mkhalian

[170] *Ibid.*

of political violence. A dispatch from Constantinople dated 9 September 1890, printed in the *New York Herald* the next day, reported that five Turkish gendarmes had been assassinated by Armenians in the village of "Baghtchedjik," near Ismidt, a village "inhabited chiefly by Armenians," and that the matter was discussed at the Palace in a council attended by the Grand Vizier and the Ministers of Justice and Foreign Affairs.[171] The place name appears to be a rendering of Bahçecik. I have found no corresponding Ottoman archival record, so the *Herald* dispatch is currently the only documentary trace. It shows how quickly news from a provincial Armenian village reached the highest levels of the Ottoman government and the foreign press.

Mobility was a channel for ideas as well as people. Constitutionalism, federalism, and socialism traveled through the movement of workers and revolutionaries, as well as through newspapers, railways, steamships, and telegraphs. [172] Publications such as *Armenia*, associated with Mıgırdiç Portakalyan and published in Marseille, circulated across imperial borders despite censorship. The networks that connected rural Armenians to employment beyond their villages could also connect them to new ideas and forms of collective action.

***The crisis of the 1890s***

On 30 September 1895, Hunchakian activists organized a demonstration in Constantinople demanding reforms on Armenian question. Ottoman authorities suppressed it, and Bardizag sheltered an injured participant until he could safely return to the capital.[173] Mobilization in the capital thus depended in part on networks of protection extending into smaller Armenian communities. The Hamidian massacres of 1894–1896, which claimed an estimated 100,000 to 200,000 lives reinforced the perception among many activists that petitions

[171] Constantinople, Sept. 9," *New York Herald*, 10 September 1890

[172] Houri Berberian,

[173] Mkhaliean,

and appeals to the authorities, and European intervention, could not guarantee security.[174] Yet the movement's response was not limited to confrontation. It also involved building institutions capable of sustaining communal life.

The Ottoman state read this institutional life through the lens of conspiracy. Two documents from these years show the logic. The first is an 1894 interrogation in which an official asks which Armenians in Bardizag were responsible for sending "cherry growers" to Istanbul. He apparently treated the expression as a designation for men recruited to the revolutionary movement. The conversation had begun with two Istanbul Armenians discussing the quality of Bardizag's cherries and who would bring them to the city, and the *jurnalci* who overheard them interpreted it through a vocabulary of arms, *fedais*, and insurrection.[175] The second is an intelligence report of December 1895–January 1896 following Mr.Shipley, an interpreter at the British Embassy, from Istanbul to İzmit, Bardizag, and Adapazarı.[176] Officials ordered his contacts monitored and claimed he had visited Armenian communities to "console and incite (*Ermenileri teselli edip kışkırtmaktan)*" them, and attributed to him statements concerning intervention in the aftermath of the Zeytun conflict.[177] These allegations belong to an

[174] Recent estimates generally range from 100,000 to 200,000, while the figure of 300,000 persists mainly in popular historical accounts. Because casualty figures underpin narratives of unprecedented mass violence, and questioning them can be seen as reinforcing Turkish denialism, Verheij and Miller argue that scholars have often treated the issue with surprising lack of scrutiny. Many estimates are cited without evidence or even a source. Jelle Verheij and Owen Miller, "New Approaches to the Hamidian Massacres, 1894–7," in *The I.B. Tauris Handbook of the Late Ottoman Empire: History and Legacy.* (ed.) Hans Lukas Kieser and Khatchig Mouradian, 2025, p.202.

[175] Hüseyin Nazım Paşa (Police Minister 1890–1896; *Hatıralarım*; *Ermeni Olayları Tarihi*;.

[176] BOA.Y.PRK.ASK, 109/53 (09/01/1896) mentioned in *Osmanli Belgelerinde Ermeni-Ingiliz Iliskileri (1896-1922),* (T.C. Basbakanlik Devlet Arsivleri Genel Mudurlugu Osmanli Arsivi Daire Basbakanligi Yayin. No:76, 2005), p.15-18.

[177] Following the First Zeitun Resistance of 1862, renewed Ottoman pressure culminated in the 1895–96 resistance, when Armenians organized under Hunchakian leadership and successfully resisted a numerically superior Ottoman force. European intervention brought the conflict to an end, with concessions including the exile of Hunchakian activists, some reduction of the tax burden, and the appointment of a Christian sub-governor. The episode illustrates the capacity of an established Armenian community to mobilize collectively when longstanding forms of local autonomy came under intensified state pressure. Aram Arkun, "Zeytun and the Commencement of the Armenian Genocide'," in Ronald Grigor Suny, Fatma Muge Gogek, and Norman M. Naimark (eds), *A Question of Genocide:*

Ottoman intelligence discourse and should not be taken at face value. The report also maps the heterogeneous population of the region, identifying Circassians, Abkhaz, Georgians, Lazes, Bosnians, and Kurds, and recording who rented which forest and which communities intermarried. These documents reveal more than the extent of surveillance. They show that the state understood everyday economic circulation as politically consequential. A cherry grower could become a suspected revolutionary, the movement of fruit could be read as the movement of weapons, and the commercial routes linking Bardizag to Istanbul could be imagined as channels of clandestine organization. Surveillance did not merely discover a political infrastructure already in place. It helped produce political meaning by rendering ordinary mobility, association, and exchange legible as political. İlkay Yılmaz's analysis of travel regulations clarifies the link between mobility and control: new rules on travel papers were selectively applied to Armenians and Bulgarians, and after the Kumkapı demonstration of 1890 and the Ottoman Bank seizure of 1896 officials associated Armenians with categories such as vagrant, anarchist, and villain (*fesad*), legitimizing wider policing.[178]

The Hamidian massacres entered Bardizag through survivors and orphans, through missionary and charitable networks, through intelligence reports and official fears, and through the changing political language with which Armenian mobility and organization were interpreted. Children who had survived massacres elsewhere brought the consequences of distant violence into the orphanage, and their incorporation into systems of care, education, and productive labor tied mass violence to household reproduction and social survival. Violence at a

*Armenians and Turks at the End of the Ottoman Empire* (New York, 2011; online edn, Oxford Academic, 16 Mar. 2015), https://doi.org/10.1093/acprof:osobl/9780195393743.003.0011, accessed 5 Oct. 2026. Girayalp Karakus, "Relations of Turkish Armenians with Great Powers According to Ottoman, Russian and French Archival Documents (1891-1918), *Akademik Sosyal Arastirmalar Dergisi*, Yil: 12, Sayi: 151, Nisan 2024, p.151.

[178] İlkay Yılmaz, "Governing the Armenian Question through Passports in the Late Ottoman Empire (1876-1908)," Journal of Historical Sociology, 2019, pp. 392-395.

distance could become materially present without taking the form of the violence that produced the displacement.

***The constitutional moment of 1908***

The Constitutional Revolution of 1908 briefly rekindled hopes for a more inclusive Ottoman polity.[179] Bedross Der describes an ecumenical mass at the Armenian Holy Trinity Church in Constantinople, attended by Armenians, Greeks, Muslims, and Jews, followed by a procession to Taksim Garden where thousands celebrated "Turkish-Armenian brotherhood".[180] A French diplomatic report of 8 July 1908, written by Mr.Boppe, described the same mood in the provinces: crowds honoring the dead of 1895–96, an officer in Adrianople confessing shame to the Armenian bishop, and a crowd in Trebizond demanding the dismissal of a governor who refused to release imprisoned Armenians.[181]

The restoration of the Constitution brought Bardizag a remarkable expansion of political activity. The ARF and the Hunchaks opened clubhouses, and prominent figures visited, including Khachag Shahrigian and Simon Zavarian of the ARF and the Hunchak representative Sabah Gulian.[182] Zavarian's presence is particularly significant because his political work intersected with his activities as an educator and agronomist. The struggle for political freedom went together with efforts to educate the population, organize economic life, and circulate information. The political opening did not create collective capacity from nothing. It exposed and redirected capacities that had been developing through decades of institutional life, and the

[179] *Ibid.* Kansu, Aykut. 1997. *The Revolution of 1908 in Turkey*. Leiden: E.J. Brill. Tarik Zafer Tunaya, Mete Tuncay, Erik Jan Zurcher

[180] Der Matossian, Bedross. 2014. *Shattered Dreams of Revolution : From Liberty to Violence in the Late Ottoman Empire*. Stanford, California: Stanford University Press. http://site.ebrary.com/id/10939785, p.23.

[181] "*Salonique Consulat,*" 604PO/B-19, Centre des Archives diplomatiques de Nantes (CADN), Nantes, France

[182] Grigor Mkhalean, and Ara Stepan Melkonian, *Bardizag and Its People*. London: Gomidas Institute, 2014, p.

history of revolutionary politics in Bardizag is neither a simple expression of economic deprivation nor a purely ideological or nationalist phenomenon. The movement's own publications, such as *Meghou*, show that activists understood this institutional labor as central to the construction of collective power.

The growing political activity of Bardizag also brought its everyday institutional life under closer state scrutiny. A report written by Bardizag branch of ARF, dated July 31, records a series of arrests and searches following an alleged clash on the customs road. The gendarmerie commander arrived in Bardizag and detained fifteen people, including the local figure Shavarsh and several of his associates, placing them under investigation and detention.[183] The report describes the response of their relatives and the wider population, who sought their release on bail while anticipating further searches and arrests. Gendarmes and police surrounded coffeehouses, reading rooms, market areas, and government offices, while the report records a growing atmosphere of fear among the population.

What makes the incident significant is the breadth of the spaces and relationships brought under surveillance. Coffeehouses and reading rooms were sites of sociability and political discussion; markets connected people through everyday economic exchange; families mobilized to secure the release of detainees; and local networks carried information about arrests and possible searches. The authorities therefore encountered Bardizag not simply as a collection of individuals suspected of revolutionary activity but as a densely connected social world. The same networks through which Armenians circulated information, organized economic life, and sustained communal relationships could also become the infrastructure through which political

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[183] Հ.Յ.Դ. ԱՐԽԻՎ, ՍԱՍ Գ, ՏԱՐԻ 1910, ԾՐԱՐ 877, ՇՐՋԱՆ Կ. Պոլիս, Էսկի Զաղրա կամ Վիրան Շեհիր կկ. Armenian Revolutionary Archives Institute, Watertown, MA.

ideas and opposition circulated**.** State repression increasingly reflected an awareness of this connection. The political significance of these networks becomes clearer in the case of Yervant Topuzian.

***Hunchaks and Yervant Topuzian***

The case of the Hunchakian movement makes the relationship clearest. On June 15, 1915, twenty Hunchak activists were executed in Constantinople, among them Yervant Topuzian of Bardizag. Their significance extends beyond their prosecution. Their cases show how far Hunchak politics had become embedded in communal institutions, schools, newspapers, clubs, and electoral campaigns. The party emerged at the intersection of Armenian national liberation and socialism, influenced by Russian revolutionary thought including *Narodnaya Volya* and the conversations with exiled revolutionary leaders; including Vladimir Lenin.[184] Their official program advocated "broad democracy, political freedom, and national independence" for Turkish Armenia—the six Armenian provinces of eastern Anatolia, commonly referred to as Western Armenia—through revolutionary struggle. [185]At the same time, it condemned "the exploitation of man by man" and identified socialism as the ultimate goal of the Armenian people. Its 1888 program described the existing order in terms of "economic slavery," identified the appropriation of the majority's labor by a privileged minority as a foundation of inequality,

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[184] Lenin closely followed the Hunchak movement in Geneva, and his engagement with Hunchak and Dashnak activists informed his early thinking on the national question, including the right of nations to self-determination. Garren Jansezian "Lenin in the Periphery: Self Determination and Its Discontents," EVN Report, 02/28/2024, https://evnreport.com/opinion/lenin-in-the-periphery-self-determination-and-its-discontents/ (Accessed date: 10/05/2026). Suny, Ronald Grigor. 1979. "Populism, Nationalism, and Marxism: The Origins of Revolutionary Parties Among the Armenians of the Caucasus." *The Armenian Review* 32, no. 2 (June): 134–51. Louise Nalbandian, *The Armenian Revolutionary Movement: The Development of Armenian Political Parties through the Nineteenth Century* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1963), p. 108-115.

[185] Umit Kurt, "The Hunchakian Revolutionary Party in Cilicia: Aintab as a Case Study," *Armenian Review*, Vol.57, No.1-2, 2020, p.93-115.

and named private property as a mechanism of domination.[186] Its minimum program described Armenians as subject to expanding taxation, attacks on their lands, and the appropriation of the products of their labor. This language placed labor and material exploitation within the vocabulary through which activists interpreted their circumstances. In Bardizag it encountered existing experiences of indebtedness, labor exploitation, state extraction, and insecurity. Socialism was not simply imported from Europe; it became intelligible through local institutions and material relations.

Topuzian appeared before the Ottoman authorities as a twenty-two-year-old teacher at the Armenian school in Bardizag. He identified himself as a Hunchakian, testified that he had joined because its program matched his own ideas, and denied having relations with the party's headquarters abroad. He was also known by the pen name *Panvor* and contributed as an editor to the weekly *Yergir* (Homeland). [187]



*Yervant Topuzian*[188]

[186] Anahide Ter Minassian, *Nationalism and Socialism in the Armenian Revolutionary Movement (1887-1912)* (Cambridge, Mass.: Zoryan Institute, 1984), pp. 197-199.

[187] Mihran A. Minassian, "Adapazar-Printing Press," *Houshamadyan*, 05/05/2025, trans. Simon Beugekian, https://www.houshamadyan.org/mapottomanempire/vilayet-of-izmit/adapazar/literature/printing/press.html (accessed 09/27/2026).

S. Arabyan remembered him as an organizer and propagandist whose activities extended across the İzmit region and who was associated with *Baykar*, the paper of the Bardizag Hunchak branch.[189] He also led the party's 1908 campaign in the İzmit region in support of a CUP-backed Ottoman Greek candidate **[name to be added]**. Topuzian was simultaneously a teacher, journalist, organizer, and party member. His activity moved across education, journalism, electoral politics, and party organization, which counters a Turkish nationalist historiography that confines Hunchak mobilization to secret cells or armed activity. The Bardizag Club corresponded with Hunchak headquarters in Istanbul, and testimonies point to communication routes through intermediary communities such as Hacıhabibli and Antep, linking village life to provincial and transregional networks.

The distinction between local organization and centralized decision-making matters for the events that followed. At the Seventh General Convention of the Social Democrat Hunchakian Party in Constanţa, Romania, in 1913, the leadership planned the assassination of leading CUP figures whom activists held responsible for the Adana massacres and believed to be preparing the annihilation of the Armenian population.[190] Anna Tadevosyan notes that the party's circulars had emphasized since 1908 the need to prepare Armenians for possible violence, reflecting suspicion of the Young Turk project.[191] An Armenian informant alerted the government, delegates were

[188] "Yervant Topuzian," Wikimedia Commons, https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Yervant_Topuzian.png (Accessed date: 10/04/2026).

[189] Eduard Ç'oburean, ed., *Paramazlar: Beyazıt'ta 20 Darağacı = K'san K'akhaghanner* (Beyoğlu, İstanbul: Evrensel Basım Yayın, 2015), p. 81.

[190] Bedross Der Matossian, ed., *The Armenian Social Democrat Hnchakian Party: Politics, Ideology and Transnational History* (London: I.B. Tauris, 2024), https://doi.org/10.5040/9780755651337. Tigran Yevagian, "The Rise and Fall of the Hunchak Party," EVN Report, 01/09/2024, https://evnreport.com/raw-unfiltered/the-rise-and-fall-of-the-hunchak-party/ (Accessed date: 09/27/2026). Bülent Cırık, "Birinci Dünya Savaşı'ndan Önce Hınçak Partisi'nin İki Kongresi ve Savaş Kararı," Belleten 86, no. 307 (2022): 1007-1033. https://doi.org/10.37879/belleten.2022.1007. Louise Nalbandian, *The Armenian Revolutionary Movement* (Berkeley, CA: University of California Press, 2018).

[191] Anna Tadevosyan, "The Social-Democratic Hnchak Party in America 1908-1914," *Journal for Armenian Studies* 1 (60), March 2023, p. 141-151.

arrested on entering Ottoman territory, and about 140 people were ultimately detained. [192] Topuzian was among the twenty sentenced to death and hanged in Sultan Beyazıt Square on June 15, 1915, only weeks after the beginning of the genocide.[193] The executions grew out of the state's attempt to criminalize a transnational Armenian revolutionary organization, and not out of party membership alone. Later Hunchak accounts remembered the twenty as martyrs, while the Ottoman prosecution represented them through the framework of conspiracy and state security.

***Institutions of Collective Capacity***

The institutional life of Bardizag reveals several distinct dimensions of collective capacity. Schools and the press organized knowledge and communication; credit institutions and cooperatives pooled economic resources; occupational associations coordinated labor; and charitable institutions organized care, education, and subsistence. These institutions did not perform equivalent functions, nor did they generate capacity in the same way. Their significance lies in the different resources and relationships they made available for collective action—and in the unequal and sometimes disciplinary relations through which those capacities were produced. The examples that follow therefore trace not a unified institutional system, but a heterogeneous field in which economic, social, and political capacities could be accumulated, redirected, and contested.

Religious life centered on two Armenian Apostolic churches, St. James (Surp Hagop) and Holy King (Surp Takavor), and on the pilgrimage site of St. Minas, while Armenian Catholics and Protestants maintained their own churches and the nunnery.[194] In 1909–1910 the Nerses-

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[192] Ronald Grigor Suny, *"They Can Live in the Desert but Nowhere Else": A History of the Armenian Genocide* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2015), p. 197.

[193] Kadir Akın, *Armenian Revolutionary Paramaz: Armenian Socialists from Abdülhamid to the Committee of Union and Progress*, trans. Pınar Erol, 1st ed. (Glendale, CA: Massis Publishing, 2024).

[194]

Shoushanian co-educational community school enrolled 330 boys and 290 girls, alongside a community kindergarten of 305 pupils, a Protestant kindergarten of 170, a Mekhitarian school of 170, the American High School with 421 students, and the Favre Boys' Home with 120. [195] These institutions did not all serve the same purpose, and the sections below take up the press, women's labor, the Teachers' Union, credit, consumption, and leisure in turn.

**Print and the Organization of Collective Knowledge**

Bardizag produced at least twenty-one newspapers and periodicals between the 1840s and 1915, ranging from handwritten school papers to locally produced and Istanbul-printed publications. [196] Their subjects extended beyond politics to education, agriculture, prices, and other problems of everyday life. The significance of this press lies less in the number of publications than in the institutional work that made collective interpretation possible.

Around 1847, Hovhannes Suren Mıgıryan, later Başpapaz Hovhannes Mıgıryan, edited the handwritten *Panper Bardizagyan*, probably produced in a single copy and placed in the village school for collective reading. A November 1847 letter proposed buying shoes for poor children so that they could attend school in cold and muddy weather and urged the inclusion of national history in the girls' curriculum. The material conditions of schooling thus appeared alongside questions of education and communal identity. The newspaper did not simply

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Boghos Vartabed Natanian, *First Report on the Diocese of Nicomedia 1870*. (London: Gomidas Institute, 2019), p.23.

[195] An Armenian weekly published in Constantinople (Istanbul) by the American Board of Commissioners for Foreign Missions provides enrollment figures for Armenian boys and girls in Bardizag (ՊԱՐՏԻԶԱԿ / Bahçecik). For the 1910 academic year, the school year began in September 4/17; boarding tuition was 16 Ottoman gold lira, or 8 liras for students in the day division. The notice lists Grigor H. Shahbazian and Rev. J. P. McNaughton as contacts. See ԱՒԵՏԱՐԵՐ 1910, *Salt Research*, (Accessed date: September 27, 2026).

[196] Mihran Minassian, "The Armenian Periodical Press at Bardizag," trans. Tamar Marie Boyadjian, *Houshamadyan*, 10/07/2024, https://www.houshamadyan.org/mapottomanempire/vilayet-of-izmit/bardizag/literature.html (Accessed date: September 27, 2026).

disseminate ideas produced elsewhere. It helped readers identify shared problems, assign institutional responsibility, and imagine collective solutions.

This function became more explicitly political as school, religious, and revolutionary publications multiplied. Papers such as *Meghou*, *Paros*, and Hunchak publications provided spaces in which economic grievances, education, gender, and political repression could be discussed as interconnected problems. The ARF's *Meghou* (Bee), subtitled "the Voice of the Province," appeared weekly from late 1911 until 13 July 1914, for 124 issues, and its 1913 numbers treated the municipality's ceiling on meat prices, the new agricultural law on insect pests, an infestation of locusts, and the village's need for a secondary school, an agricultural enterprise, and an arts society. [197] Its notices column printed an announcement of a general assembly of the party beside a lost pocket watch and a teaching vacancy, which suggests how thoroughly political organization had become part of the ordinary communicative life of the town. Print therefore did more than circulate information. It transformed dispersed experiences into collectively intelligible ones and provided a medium through which people could imagine themselves as participants in a common social world.

Women's labor was part of the material foundation from which this collective political world emerged. A song published in *Meghou*, introduced as the work of suffering women workers, gives unusually direct expression to this experience. The young women ask why they have grown yellow and worn down, locating the cause in the factory of their "agha," situated beside the road. They describe the wound produced by this labor as one carried in their hearts, while the factory doorstep is worn smooth by their repeated passage:

[197] *Meghou*, 4 August 1913 (year 2, no. 30–82), p. 1, editorial "A Useful Decision," praising the municipality's ceiling on meat prices and promising to urge similar regulation of bread, coal, wood, other goods, cleanliness, and building; p. 2, "To the Farmers," a summary of the new law on combating insects and parasites that harm agriculture, requiring owners to report infestations, admit government experts, and carry out the prescribed measures.

"Girls, girls, why have you turned yellow? We'll be crowned over by a cockerel, mother; we got yellow from there. A bird has passed over the factory; Over the girls' hearts, mother, a black thing has passed. Our agha's factory is at the side of the road, The girls' wounds, mother, are in their hearts, The factory's doorstep is smoothed, The girls' hearts, mother, are worn out, worn out." [198]

The significance of the song lies not simply in its depiction of exploitation but in its movement from experience to collective expression. The women's bodies register the effects of factory labor; the newspaper turns that embodied experience into a public account of exploitation. What might otherwise remain an individual or household burden becomes recognizable as a shared social condition. The song therefore reveals another dimension of the infrastructure of political life: women workers did not merely occupy the labor relations that revolutionary organizations sought to politicize. Their experiences entered the communicative institutions through which exploitation could be named, interpreted, and made collectively intelligible. The same paper's November 1912 campaign to collect the village's folk songs, which produced "The Tender Lyrics ofBardizag," likewise brought women's lullabies and wedding songs into its pages. This matters for the history of revolutionary politics because it shifts attention away from organizations composed primarily of male activists and toward the labor that made political knowledge possible. The collective capacity of Bardizag was produced not only in party meetings or workplaces but also through the circulation of experiences that exposed how class, gender, and labor were lived in everyday life.

[198] Gasapean, Minas G. *The Armenians in the Province of Nicomedia : A Study Complete with a Map and Statistics*. Edited by Ara Stepan Melkonian. London: Gomidas Institute, 2019.

### *Teachers and the Reproduction of Collective Capacity*

The Bardizag Teachers' Union shows the same process in another sphere. A 1913 article in *Meghou* criticized the longstanding separation between teachers at the American High School and at the Armenian National Primary School, even though they served the same children, and proposed a union to overcome the division through regular consultation, reciprocal classroom visits, and curricular coordination.[199] The author acknowledged that the American school was not strictly a Bardizag institution but stressed its influence on the town's moral and educational life. The union's purpose was not merely professional representation. It sought to coordinate educational institutions and establish common practices, treating the school as a site through which the community reproduced knowledge, habits, bodies, and collective identity.

Its concern extended to the physical formation of youth. A longer essay in *Meghou* in 1914 identified *marzank* (physical exercise) as the most neglected dimension of national schooling. [200] The author argued that earlier generations had acquired strength through village life while town children lacked it, and he criticized mothers who discouraged children from running or getting dirty. Education concerned not only what children knew but the bodies and habits through which they would take part in communal life. Organizing teachers meant organizing part of the infrastructure through which the next generation of workers and community members was produced.

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[199] "Պարտիզակի Ուսուցչական Միութիւնը," *Մեղու* 1913, March 24, issue no.1.

[200] *Մեղու*, dated 29 June 1914, year 3, issue no.17, p.1-3.



[201]

The relationship between education and political organization was visible to the state. A 1914 photograph of the Bardizag Armenian Teachers' Association shows a copy of *Azadamard*, the ARF-affiliated Constantinople daily, among the group, and an Ottoman document accuses the people of Bardizag of supporting and providing information to the paper.[202] The evidence does not establish that the Teachers' Union functioned as a political organization. It shows why educational institutions could become politically significant: they were nodes through which people, publications, knowledge, and relationships circulated.

The Teachers' Union illustrates another dimension of collective capacity. By bringing teachers from different educational institutions into regular communication, it created a

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[201] Outing of the Armenian Teachers' Association, Bardizag, Ottoman Empire, 1914. Photographer unknown. Project Save Archives, Watertown MA. The photograph likely depicts the teachers' union mentioned in *Meghou*. The newspaper visible at the bottom of the photograph is *Azadamard* (Battle for Liberty), an Armenian newspaper published in Constantinople until the Armenian Genocide. Its manager, Haig Tiriakian, was among the first group of Armenian intellectuals arrested on April 24, 1915. See: Project SAVE Archives, Arpy Kashmanian Folder, File Copy 5-97, https://www.facebook.com/ProjectSavePhotographArchive/photos/outing-of-turkish-armenian-teachers-association-bardizag-ottoman-empire-1914-pho/2090232421256510/ (Accessed date: 09/27/2025).

[202] Toygun Altintas, "Armenian Revolutionary Federation," *International Encyclopedia of the First World War*, https://encyclopedia.1914-1918-online.net/article/armenian-revolutionary-federation-arf/ (Accessed date: 09/27/2025).

mechanism for coordinating knowledge, professional practice, and educational work. Its significance therefore extended beyond the administration of schools: it strengthened the networks through which educational labor could become a coordinated communal activity.

**Credit and the Collective Management of Money**

The first empirical chapter of this dissertation traced how Armenian peasants turned forest resources into charcoal for the Imperial Mint, so that their labor entered the monetary system before currency entered local economic life. Here the direction is reversed: the question is how money became embedded in local social reproduction. Monetization raised the importance of money in taxation, trade, debt, and household reproduction, and made access to monetary resources an increasingly consequential problem. The Surp Hagop token, discussed above, was one early and ambiguous communal intervention. The People's Bank provides stronger evidence.

According to its founder's account, poorer villagers were losing their earnings to creditors, and accumulated debts could force them to sell possessions on unfavorable terms. The response was to pool local resources and provide small-scale credit within the community. Shares were set at twenty *tahegans*, with a projected capital of 1,000 liras, and nearly 5,000 shares were reportedly sold, many to villagers who bought five or ten. Within three months the was extending loans of one to three liras against shares or the guarantee of a trusted individual. The bank did not establish an alternative to monetary exchange. Its loans were denominated in liras and governed by the discipline of debt. What it changed was the social organization of access to credit, which became partially collectivized. It reduced dependence on individual moneylenders while deepening participation in monetary relations. Communal institutions did not protect Armenians by removing them from capitalism. They helped them manage the

conditions of their incorporation into it.The People's Bank provides stronger evidence of communal intervention in monetary relations. According to its founder's account, poorer villagers were losing their earnings to creditors, while accumulated debts could force them to sell their possessions under unfavorable conditions. The proposed response was to pool local resources and provide small-scale credit within the community. Shares were set at twenty *tahegans*, with a projected capital of 1,000 liras.[203] Nearly 5,000 shares were reportedly sold, many to villagers who purchased five or ten shares. Within three months, the bank had begun extending loans of one to three liras against shares or the guarantee of a trusted individual.

The bank's structure reveals the collective dimension of this response. Its purpose was not primarily to maximize shareholder returns. Profits were intended to cover administrative expenses, with modest dividends distributed to administrators and shareholders. By pooling small contributions and redistributing them through loans, the bank sought to make capital available within the local economy and reduce dependence on individual creditors.[204] The evidence does not establish how many households relied on the bank or how significantly it altered local indebtedness. It does show that access to credit was treated as a collective economic problem that could be addressed through a communal institution.

The church token and People's Bank therefore represent different forms of communal intervention rather than parts of a single coordinated program. The token concerned the local circulation of monetary value; the bank concerned access to credit and the relations of

[203] A *tahegan* is a historical medieval coin used in Armenian kingdoms here Mkhalian referes

[204] For a comparative perspective on the collective organization of credit and debt, see Éric Toussaint, "The Paris Commune of 1871, Banks and Debt," *Committee for the Abolition of Illegitimate Debt*, https://www.cadtm.org/the-paris-commune-of-1871-banks-and-debt?debut_tous_articles_auteur=80 (Accessed date: 10/04/2026) The comparison is analytical rather than historical: there is no evidence of a connection between the Paris Commune and Bardizag's People's Bank, and the two emerged from very different political and economic circumstances. Its value lies in identifying a broader possibility in the history of finance: debt can become a collective economic problem rather than remain solely a private relation between borrower and creditor. The comparison concerns the collective organization of financial relations, not institutional similarity or shared political purpose.

indebtedness surrounding it. Their historical importance lies in demonstrating that communal institutions could mediate monetary relations from within the expanding monetary economy itself. This argument connects directly to the charcoal economy examined in the first empirical chapter. Charcoal production shows how Bardizag's forests and Armenian peasant labor became part of the material infrastructure of Ottoman currency production. The church token and People's Bank show what happened further along that process, when money entered local economic relations and generated questions about exchange, credit, and access. The monetary history of Bardizag thus moves from the material production of currency to the communal organization of some of the relations through which that currency acquired economic significance.

The point is not that communal institutions stood outside or resisted monetization as such. Rather, they provided locally organized means of negotiating its consequences. The token and the People's Bank reveal different attempts to shape how monetary value circulated and how credit was accessed within the community. Their destruction during the deportations therefore formed part of the wider dismantling of Bardizag's economic infrastructure, including the institutions through which communal resources and financial relations had been organized.

***Labor, Production, and Collective Enterprise***

The same logic extended beyond credit into the organization of production itself. A series of letters exchanged in Bardizag in March 1913 reveals the local ARF committee considering how to organize the work of "worker-artisans" whose individual efforts within existing factories had produced limited results.[205] The correspondence identified wage labor itself as a problem: "it

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[205] Հ.Յ.Դ. ԱՐԽԻՎ, ՍԱՍ Գ , ԾՐԱՐ 880, ՏԱՐԻ 1913, ԾՐՋԱՆ Կ. Պոլսոյ, Լիւսիկամ կամ Վիշապ կկ. Armenian Revolutionary Archives Institute, Watertown, MA.

is difficult to operate on wages alone," one letter observed, and proposed instead to organize work on an individual contract basis. The proposed solution was not simply to secure employment within existing enterprises but to organize productive activity through collective support and guarantees. One proposal asked whether the party, working with and under the guarantee of the local committee, could undertake such an enterprise and allocate up to 100 gold liras for tools, materials, and other expenses.

The correspondence also reveals an explicit concern with the relations between worker-artisans and factory owners. The writers noted that the efforts of individuals working within existing factories had produced limited results and discussed the difficulty of creating sufficient competition to influence factory owners. They proposed directing particular attention toward the expenses of worker-artisans and questioned whether work could be organized through contracts rather than wages alone. These were not simply questions of political ideology. They were practical questions about how labor could be organized, financed, and made more productive under conditions in which individual workers had limited leverage.

This evidence complicates a simple distinction between economic and political organization. The ARF was not merely drawing political support from an already organized working population; it was itself becoming involved in the material organization of production. The proposed enterprise linked political authority to financial guarantees, tools, contracts, factory relations, and the allocation of capital. Collective political capacity could therefore emerge through attempts to reorganize the economic relations on which everyday survival depended.

The March 1913 correspondence reveals a further extension of this capacity into the organization of production itself. The ARF committee's concern with workers' ability to survive "on wages alone," and its willingness to provide tools, materials, and financial guarantees, shows

an effort to organize the material conditions of labor alongside political activity. Here, collective capacity took the form of economic coordination within production**.**

***Consumption and the Dashnaktsagan Retail Cooperative***

The same principle appears in the Dashnaktsagan retail cooperative. The Bardizag ARF committee was concerned about the cost of meat, flour, and other basic foodstuffs and asserted that every person was entitled to a healthy diet, treating access to food as a collective question and not only a matter of individual purchasing power. The cooperative was founded in May 1911. Membership cost 20 paras, with a subscription of one para a week for five years, and one hundred people joined as founding members. Because the committee lacked commercial experience, it entrusted administration to Karnig Bodourian, manager of the Builders' Association, who had also founded a Carpenters Association. His appointment linked the ARF's organization to the associational infrastructure already developing in Bardizag. The cooperative sought to provide goods of the best quality at reasonable prices, to return a share of the benefits in proportion to purchases, and eventually to run a bakery. Village grocers strongly resisted it, which suggests that it challenged existing commercial relationships.[206]

The cooperative made socialist politics tangible in an unusually ordinary sphere: the reproduction of the household. For workers and small producers, the question was not only how much they earned, but what their earnings could buy. By organizing consumption collectively, the cooperative attempted to intervene in the cost of living as well as the organization of labor. It should not be presented as an anti-capitalist institution, since it remained within the market and addressed particular material needs. Its importance lies in the overlap between economic and political organization. Collective consumption strengthened relationships among members and

[206] Mkhalian, Karnig G. Bodourian, *Տարագրի յուշեր 1915-1917* [Memoirs of a Deportee 1915-1917], Memoirs of Survivors of the Armenian Genocide, vol. 8, ed. Mihran A. Minassian (Yerevan: AGMI Publishing, 2022).

created organizational capacities that could also support political solidarity. Economic solidarity and political solidarity were not identical, but they could reinforce one another. The retail cooperative brought these questions into the sphere of everyday consumption. The price and quality of basic goods were household concerns, but the cooperative treated them as problems that could be addressed collectively. In doing so, it transformed an ordinary practice of household reproduction—obtaining food and other necessities—into a form of collective economic organization**.**

The Public Garden Association, established in 1913, created another space for communal sociability, bringing together residents for leisure and informal interaction. An article in *Meghou* of 4 August 1913 promoted Bardizag for *odapokhutyun* (a change of air), praising its clean water, elevated air, vineyards, and mulberry groves. [207] The association chose a site at one of the Lower Threshing Floors with views over the fields and the Gulf of İzmit, planted trees and flowerbeds, laid gravel paths, installed benches, opened a buffet, and brought in running water. Grigor Mkhaleian remembers it as a gathering place where, during the constitutional years, "old and young, men and women" spent time.[208] The garden offers less evidence of organized economic or political action than the institutions discussed above, but it nevertheless reveals the density of associational life in Bardizag. Economic cooperation, political discussion, education, and sociability developed within an overlapping institutional environment rather than in separate spheres. This broader associational world also included institutions whose functions were more explicitly reproductive. The orphanage provides the most revealing example because it shows that the organization of collective life could generate capacities through relations of care and discipline at the same time.

[207] "Պարտիզակ օդափոխական վայր," ՄԵՂՈՒ, 4 August 1913. For "beautiful summers" in Bardizag, see ՄԵՂՈՒ, 2 March 1914, year 3, issue no. 5–109.

[208] Grigor Mkhaleian, pp. 319-321

### The Missionary Orphanage: Care, Labor, and Institutional Dependency

The contrast between the cooperative and the orphanage reveals the contradictory character of collective capacity in Bardizag. The cooperative emerged from a shared economic problem: the rising cost of everyday consumption. By pooling resources, organizing purchasing, and attempting to secure affordable goods, it offered households a collective means of navigating the pressures of an increasingly monetized economy. Collective organization here could reduce individual vulnerability.

The orphanage presents a different possibility. It likewise pooled resources, organized labor, provided education, and reproduced children who had been displaced by violence. Yet these functions depended upon the institutional regulation of children's time, labor, movement, and future prospects. If the cooperative shows how collective organization could redistribute the pressures of monetization, the orphanage shows how institutional organization could also internalize those pressures. Its productive activities simultaneously trained children sustained the institution, and reduced its dependence on external resources. Protection and appropriation therefore operated through the same institutional arrangements.

The significance of the orphanage lies precisely in this contradiction. Collective capacity was not inherently emancipatory. It could be generated through solidarity and mutual provision, but also through discipline, hierarchy, and dependency. What mattered was not simply the existence of institutions, but the relations through which they organized resources, labor, and social reproduction.

***From cocoonery to orphanage***

The mission site had originally served an agricultural function. Around 1858, according to Sophia Newnham, a long, low structure was erected there as a cocoonery, later repurposed as a girls' school before reverting to domestic use. [209] The institution became an orphanage through emergency and not through planning. During the massacres of 1896, Dr. Chambers, working with the American Board of Commissioners for Foreign Missions, received a cohort of Armenian orphans evacuated from Constantinople and housed them in the old cocoonery after its occupants vacated on short notice. The arrangement was soon formalized with the construction of the "Swiss Building," funded by Swiss donors, which provided a schoolroom and dormitory for older boys. The original structure was adapted into a warren of kitchen, stores, workshops for tailoring and shoemaking, and dormitories for young children.

The Bithynia High School, whose earliest recorded class dates to 1876–77, was a cornerstone of Protestant Armenian education. In February 1897 the school became home to a newly established orphanage for boys made homeless by the violence in Constantinople, under the patronage of Sir Philip Currie, then British Ambassador. It received support from the Swiss Committee for Armenian Relief, the Friends of Armenia in London, and the India Relief Committee.[210] Despite this philanthropic backing, the orphanage increasingly relied on the labor of the children it housed.

[209] Report, Bardezag Orphanage for Boys, by Sophia Newnham, American Board, United Church of Christ (UCC), American Research Institute in Turkey (ARIT), *SALT Research*, 1905.

[210] *The Orient*, June 26, 1912, Vol. III, No. 26, p. 1-3.



HOMELESS AND FRIENDLESS BROUGHT TO OUR DOOR.

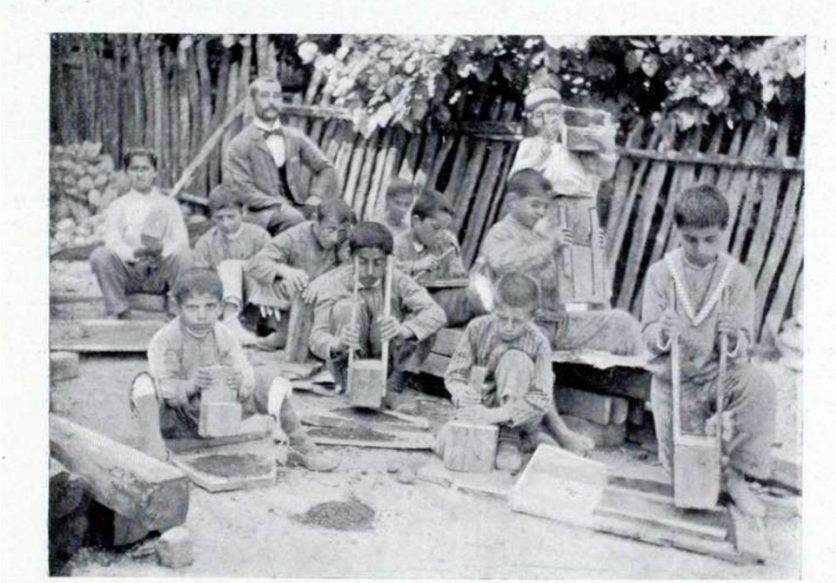
The High School expanded under Chambers and was expected to move toward financial independence through student fees, while the orphanage remained dependent on external support. Construction debts and continuing operating costs made the search for local self-sufficiency an institutional concern. The tension became visible in 1899, when the expiration of leases on the cocoonery and adjoining cottages forced the school onto land that the Chambers family had kept as its garden. The construction generated a debt that remained unresolved in 1903, and the fundraising campaign spanned London and Worcester, Massachusetts, and included a pledge of £100 in matching funds if £700 could be raised by the end of June.[211] The failure to raise the sum showed the limits of the mission's drive for independence and the continuing importance of transatlantic Protestant philanthropy. The orphanage's organization of children's labor must be understood within this economic structure.

***Children's labor***

The rebuilding of the orphanage in 1903 provides the clearest example. After securing local permission in May 1903 to demolish and rebuild, the mission placed younger boys with poor local families for the summer, which lowered boarding costs, while older boys and recent

[211] Report, *Ibid.*

graduates took part directly in the reconstruction. They carried bricks and mixed mortar alongside hired adult workers, and the frame was erected and roofed within thirteen days. Several members of the graduating class reportedly worked from about 5 a.m. to 7 p.m. and received wages from the architect at rates higher than those paid to the adult workers whose positions they had taken. The institution itself therefore represented their work as economically comparable to adult wage labor.



POUNDING BRICKS FOR MORTAR.

The meaning of those wages was transformed within the institution. The graduating students reportedly returned their Saturday wages voluntarily as an "offering." Harontune, who had spent six years in the orphanage, was presented as intending to explain that he had begun to "pay" his debt to the institution. Wage labor became moral obligation. The boys entered an economic relationship in which their labor had a monetary value while learning to understand the earnings as a contribution to the community that had raised them.

The vocational programs followed the same logic. Tailoring, gardening, bookbinding, basket-making, and cocoon production were presented as practical education and "self-help," but

they generated measurable returns. The financial statement for June 1902–June 1903 recorded 71 piasters as “Orphans' First Earnings,” 230 piasters from the sale of cocoons, and 133 piasters from bookbinding, basket-making, and similar work, counted as income alongside contributions from Armenian, Swiss, American, and British supporters, within total income of 85,484 piasters. In the tailoring class the boys produced more than 238 undergarments, 15 shirts, 48 blouses, 17 coats, and 43 pairs of trousers in a year and repaired clothing and darned socks. The pamphlet emphasizes that “not one para has been paid for making them,” presenting the absence of expense as evidence of thrift and successful training. In labor-historical terms, the institution was producing goods it needed without corresponding wage expenditure. Training gave the boys skills for their future livelihoods and also reduced the present costs of maintaining the orphanage.

The important point is not simply that the children worked. Care, education, labor, and institutional reproduction were inseparable. The mission's repeated concern with becoming "less dependent on outside help" must be read alongside its continued reliance on foreign philanthropy. "Self-help" was both a pedagogical ideal and an institutional strategy: children were to acquire the skills for future independence, and their productive activities could at once reduce the costs of care. Religious and communal formation reinforced this program. The boys' self-organized "Daniel's Band" society, together with regular religious instruction, shows how far the institution sought to cultivate disciplined communal subjects. The productive child was also the disciplined Christian student and the future self-supporting member of the community.

***Dependency and the limits of solidarity***

The orphanage presents a different and more contradictory form of collective capacity. It brought together resources, labor, education, care, and vocational training in an institution

designed to reproduce displaced children as future members of the community. Yet the same institutional arrangements that provided protection and training also organized children's time and labor according to the needs of the institution. The orphanage therefore reveals that collective capacity could be produced through relations of discipline as well as solidarity**.** Dependence created the conditions under which productive activity could be organized and morally reinterpreted as gratitude. The Church, communal associations, and revolutionary organizations could support households and workers through religious, mutual, or political solidarity without taking direct control of their daily labor. The orphanage's solidarity was inseparable from institutional dependency.

This matters for the chapter's larger argument. Social reproduction does not simply sustain resistance to exploitation. It can itself become a site through which labor is disciplined and appropriated. An institution created to repair the social consequences of violence could simultaneously organize the labor of those it protected. In the post-1896 Ottoman Armenian context, humanitarian institutions could organize labor not through the language of employment but through the intertwined categories of care, education, religious formation, gratitude, and "self-help." Humanitarian care did not stand outside economic relations; it became one of the forms through which those relations were organized.

**Conclusion:** The fifty men who volunteered to march to Constantinople in April 1909 acted at a moment of fragile hope. The atmosphere of intercommunal solidarity that followed the Constitution of 1908 proved short-lived, and the counterrevolution of 1909 brought renewed anti-Armenian violence, most devastatingly in Adana. That Bardizag's men still prepared to defend the constitutional order shows that the community did not respond to crisis by withdrawing. They mobilized through a social infrastructure built over decades.

That infrastructure was differentiated. The People's Bank organized access to credit, the retail cooperative addressed the costs of consumption, occupational associations coordinated economic interests, schools and the Teachers' Union reproduced knowledge and skills, newspapers circulated information and created spaces for discussion, and the Church sustained religious and communal life. Revolutionary organizations redirected some of the relationships, resources, and skills produced through these institutions toward political action. The missionary orphanage reveals the contradictions within this infrastructure: it provided shelter and education to displaced children while organizing their labor, showing how care and discipline could coexist within the same structures of social reproduction. These institutions did not constitute a unified alternative economy. They occupied different positions within the reproduction of social life and mediated different forms of economic and social power.

This perspective changes how semi-proletarianization should be understood. The incorporation of Armenian households into wage labor, markets, credit, and commodity exchange did not simply dissolve communal solidarity. Wage instability, indebtedness, rising consumption costs, and state coercion placed new pressures on social reproduction, while the institutions through which Armenians organized collective life provided mechanisms for managing those pressures. Schools, newspapers, banks, cooperatives, occupational associations, charitable institutions, and households organized knowledge, resources, care, and labor in differentiated ways. In doing so, they helped sustain the conditions of everyday life while also generating capacities that could be redirected toward political action. Revolutionary politics therefore emerged from within the institutional relations through which Armenian workers and households reproduced themselves under increasingly commodified conditions.

Bardizag's history was a history of political and economic experimentation in which a community developed collective mechanisms of survival and resistance within an increasingly capitalist Ottoman economy. Yet collective capacity was never inherently emancipatory. The same institutions that sustained communal life could discipline labor, reproduce hierarchy, and generate dependency. The orphanage makes this contradiction particularly visible: care and exploitation, education and labor discipline, protection and institutional appropriation could coexist within the same structures of social reproduction. This contradiction also clarifies the significance of Bardizag's destruction in 1915. Genocidal violence did not target only individuals and property. Deportation, killing, dispossession, and institutional dissolution dismantled the networks through which knowledge, resources, labor, care, and authority had been organized. The destruction of schools, churches, businesses, associations, and households therefore meant the destruction of the institutional infrastructure through which the community reproduced itself and generated collective capacity. Genocidal expropriation was consequently also an expropriation of collective capacity: it destroyed not only what Armenians possessed, but the social and institutional means through which they could reproduce themselves as a social formation and act collectively. The history of revolution in Bardizag therefore cannot be separated from the material conditions that made collective action possible—or from the violence that ultimately sought to destroy those conditions.

**CHAPTER 5: The Colonial Boomerang in the Heartland: Bardizag, Genocide and the Gendered Logic of Expropriation**

**https://www.armenian-genocide.org/br-stats_2.html**

**Introduction:** By 1914, the Ottoman Empire had entered the First World War on the side of Germany. In the first months of the war, Ottoman Armenians did not stand outside the imperial war effort. They participated in it. Across the empire, Armenians enlisted, contributed money, prayed for an Ottoman victory, and publicly affirmed their loyalty to the state. In Bardizag, the village's Armenian Revolutionary Federation (ARF) trumpet band accompanied approximately five hundred Armenian recruits as they marched toward the town center.[212] The scene was one of participation and belonging: Armenian men departing for the Ottoman army, accompanied by the music of their own community, to serve the empire of which they considered themselves subjects. Within months, many of these same communities would be marked for destruction.

The Ottoman defeat at Sarıkamış in January 1915 transformed the political meaning of Armenian loyalty. Of the approximately 90,000 Ottoman soldiers who participated in the campaign against Russia, an estimated 78,000 died, many from exposure to the severe winter conditions. Armenian volunteers fighting alongside the Russian army further intensified CUP suspicions of Armenians within the empire.[213] Yet the existence of Armenian volunteers on the Russian side did not erase the loyalty demonstrated by the much larger Armenian population serving and supporting the Ottoman war effort. Instead, military defeat and wartime insecurity allowed the CUP leadership to recast Armenians as a potential internal enemy. This transformation was accompanied by the expansion of the *Teşkilat-ı Mahsusa* (Special

[212] Yigit Akin, When the War, p.166.

[213] Tigran Martirosyan, "Battle of Sarikamis," *1914-1918 Online International Encylopedia of the First World War,* https://encyclopedia.1914-1918-online.net/article/sarkams-battle-of-1-1/ (accessed date: 09/24/2026).

Organization), whose units, working alongside Kurdish, Chechen, and other irregular forces, became central to the deportation and killing of Ottoman Armenians.[214] But the destruction of Armenian communities depended on more than paramilitary violence. It required the cooperation of provincial officials, local political elites, police and gendarmerie forces, and mechanisms for the seizure and redistribution of Armenian property. The story of Bardizag thus begins with a contradiction. In the early months of the war, Armenians marched to the Ottoman army beneath the music of their own community. Soon afterward, the state that called upon them to defend the empire would mobilize its institutions and irregular forces to destroy that community. It is this transformation—from subjects and participants in the imperial war effort to an internal enemy—that this chapter seeks to explain.

According to a table published by *Azamard*, an Armenian daily in Constantinople on 9 April 1919, titled "Condition of Armenian Population and Houses in the Bardizag District," the impact of the genocide on the local community was devastating.[215] The prewar population of Bardizag was approximately 10,500, which fell to 1,147 after the war. Of the 2,500 houses in the district before the deportations, only 300 remained, while 1,700 were either destroyed or rendered uninhabitable.[216] The region's silk production similarly collapsed: before the deportations, Bardizag produced around 3,000 kilograms of silk, but afterward production plummeted to just 30 kilograms. These figures document not simply demographic loss but the

[214] Çetinoğlu, S. (2015). 3. The Special Organization (teşkilat-i Mahsusa) Dans Par le Conseil scientifique international pour l'étude du génocide des Arméniens Le génocide des Arméniens : Un siècle de recherche 1915-2015 (p. 33-39). Armand Colin. https://doi.org/10.3917/arco.ecker.2015.02.0033.

[215] Clark University Clark Digital Commons, Genocide (Various Languages) Private Materials (Archive 2), 4-29-2018, Krikor Guerguerian

[216] *Ibid.* Near East Mission in Turkey Annual Station Reports, 1914-1921 to 1925-1926, "Nicomedia Report 1915-1921," https://archives.saltresearch.org/handle/123456789/42756 (accessed date: 09/21/2026)

destruction of the material infrastructure through which Armenian households reproduced themselves.

The destruction of the Armenian community of Bardizag in 1915 presents a fundamental historical and theoretical puzzle: why did an ecclesiastically organized community situated only fifty-six miles from Constantinople become the target of the "frontier style" demographic engineering, selective dispossession, and irregular warfare usually reserved for remote peripheries? Bardizag's Armenian community was systematically dismantled by the Ottoman state, its Christian citizens deported, and their property divided among state institutions, party elites, and resettled Muslim refugees. Bardizag's fate therefore resembles that of towns and villages on the outskirts of the empire, challenging conventional geopolitical distinctions between the imperial core and its frontiers.

Moreover, this chapter argues that the violence directed against Bardizag cannot be understood solely as a project of physical destruction. The genocide was also a process of violent economic reorganization and capital transfer, through which the destruction of Armenian social and economic life created the conditions for the appropriation of land, property, wealth, and labor. To explain this process, I brings together two interlocking theoretical frameworks: the colonial boomerang and gendered expropriation**.** The colonial boomerang helps explain how techniques of demographic engineering, irregular warfare, and selective dispossession developed in imperial frontier zones could be redirected toward an Armenian community located in the Ottoman heartland. Yet the concept requires a critical revision in the Ottoman context. Rather than violence simply traveling from a distant frontier back to the metropolitan center, Bardizag reveals a more intimate domestic trajectory: a population deeply integrated into the empire could itself be rendered peripheral through the inward application of frontier techniques.

The chapter traces this process through three moments of the colonial boomerang. First, techniques of demographic engineering and counterinsurgency were forged and refined on imperial frontiers. Second, these techniques were carried by specialized perpetrators and state agents into the interior. Third, they were applied against an Armenian community in the Marmara region, where administrative coercion, staged disarmament, deportation, and irregular violence dismantled the social, political, and economic infrastructures that had enabled Armenian life. The destruction of those infrastructures was not simply preparatory to genocide; it created the conditions under which Armenian property and labor could be expropriated.

This framework also makes visible an economic dimension of the genocide that is obscured when dispossession is treated as a secondary consequence of mass violence. Drawing on the concept of primitive accumulation, I argue that the confiscation of Armenian lands, vineyards, homes, businesses, and other assets constituted a state-mediated process of economic reorganization rather than an incidental byproduct of wartime disorder. The destruction of Armenian property opened economic space for state institutions, political elites, and neighboring populations while contributing to the consolidation of a new national political economy. In Bardizag, this process unfolded through what I call a "coerced marketplace," in which Armenian assets were transferred and liquidated under conditions created by state violence and administrative coercion.

Yet expropriation did not stop at property. It extended to bodies, labor, and the capacity to reproduce social life**.** The chapter therefore develops a gendered analysis of expropriation that follows Armenian men, women, and children through different regimes of coerced incorporation. For the male "productive remnant," survival could depend upon conscripted labor in auxiliary battalions and, later, upon captive artisanal production in Cemal Pasha's factories in Aleppo and

Damascus. For women and children, expropriation operated through a different set of mechanisms, including incorporation into Muslim households, forced domestic labor, and the suppression or transformation of Armenian identity. The chapter uses the concept of "recursive expropriation" to capture how this process could continue beyond the initial act of dispossession, as individuals such as Arshalous Patoogian were repeatedly transferred between households and treated as appropriable sources of labor. The related concept of "hollow freedom" describes how ostensibly voluntary or juridical forms, including marriage, could become mechanisms through which Armenian women's labor and social reproduction were absorbed into other households.

***The colonial boomerang***

The concept of the colonial boomerang, associated most prominently with Aimé Césaire and Hannah Arendt, emerged from different reflections on the relationship between imperial domination and political violence.[217] Césaire, a Martinican intellectual and anticolonial theorist writing in the context of French colonial rule, argued in *Discourse on Colonialism* (1950) that colonialism did not confine violence to the populations subjected to it. Colonial domination brutalized the colonized while simultaneously transforming the political culture of the colonizing society, making practices of dehumanization transforming the political culture of the colonizing society, making practices of dehumanization and and violence available for use beyond the colonial setting. Arendt similarly traced, in *The Origins of Totalitarianism*, connections between European imperialism, racial ideologies, and modern techniques of domination. Her discussion of the imperial "boomerang effect" emphasized how racial classification, bureaucratic control, and coercion developed in colonial settings could return to Europe as instruments of

[217] Aimé Césaire, *Discourse on Colonialism.* (New York, NYU Press, 2000). Hannah Arendt, *The Origins of Totalitarianism.*

metropolitan repression. Despite their differences, both therefore drew attention to the circulation of imperial practices across geographical and political boundaries.

The Herero and Nama genocide in German Southwest Africa (1904–1908) demonstrated earlier forms of racialized population destruction, forced displacement, and colonial confinement. The Holocaust cannot be reduced to a direct continuation of this violence; it arose from the specific ideological and institutional conditions of Nazi Germany. Yet the African colonial experience forms part of the longer history through which European states developed practices of racial classification, demographic management, forced removal, and mass killing. The colonial boomerang is therefore best understood not as a simple return of violence but as the circulation and recombination of repertoires of domination across empires.

Following Connor Woodman, the colonial boomerang should be understood not simply as the return of colonial violence to the imperial center, but as the circulation of counterinsurgency expertise, specialized personnel, and techniques of social control from imperial frontiers into metropolitan spaces. In Woodman's account of French Algeria, personnel such as Maurice Papon acquired techniques of repression in the colonies and subsequently redeployed them against Algerian migrants in Paris. [218]

The late Ottoman case both confirms and complicates this framework. Here, the boomerang did not simply return from a distant colonial possession to the imperial center. Instead, violent practices, personnel, and administrative knowledge developed through frontier warfare were redirected toward an Armenian population living within the empire's economic and administrative core. The result was the production of an internal periphery. The violence of in the heartland was not merely an abstract emergence of violence inspired by wartime animosity

[218] Connor Woodman, "The Imperial Boomerang: How France used colonial methods to massacre Algerians in Paris," *Verso Books*, 06/18/2020 https://www.versobooks.com/blogs/news/4418-the-imperial-boomerang-how-france-used-colonial-methods-to-massacre-algerians-in-paris?srsltid=AfmBOoqrBIAblhzwoMlcApoDxRV-ktO5gfOAPRnBpbBq4vG-YFyZhi5l (accessed date: 09/24/2026).

against "Armenianness" and other minorities, but was a specific set of repressive practices instituted by a specific set of specialists with experience on the imperial frontier. They turned their frontier-tested counterinsurgency and demographic techniques inward, transforming a highly proximate, economically integrated population into an internal periphery in the shadow of the capital.

Bardizag makes this process visible through the careers of İbrahim Bey and Ali Bey, who embodied different but complementary forms of coercive state power. İbrahim represented the mobility of frontier-trained coercive expertise. His experience in the Balkans and during the 1909 Adana massacre formed part of a repertoire of violence that he subsequently carried into the İzmit region.[219] He threatened the Armenians of Bardizag with burning the town and vowed to deal with its inhabitants as he had done in Adana in 1909.[220] His threats against Bardizag Armenians and his reputation among prisoners as an official sent to "cleanse" Armenians in Adapazarı demonstrate how the knowledge and personnel of earlier campaigns could be redirected toward the Armenian communities of the Marmara region.

Vartuhi Kalantar, who was imprisoned in the *Hapishane-i Umumi* in 1915, recalled hearing from a fellow prisoner; Kurdish Sinem, that the prison's director, Ibrahim, had gone to Adapazari to "cleanse the Armenians". [221] By 1916, İbrahim Bey appears in the *Polis*

[219] Nahiye Bardizag (BAHCECIK), *Virtual Genocide Memorial*, https://www.virtual-genocide-memorial.de/region/the-black-sea-marmara-and-aegean-littorals-eastern-thrace-and-central-anatolia/bursa-prousa-vilayet-province/mutesarifat-izmit/kaza-izmit-nicomedia/nahiye-bardizag-bahcecik/ (accessed date: 09/04/2026). Richard G. Hovannisian and Manuk-Khaloyan, Armen, *The Armenian Communities of Asia Minor: A Pictorial Essay; in: The Armenian Communities of Asia Minor*, ed. R.G. Hovannisian (Costa Mesa, CA: Mazda Publishers, 2014), p.16.

[220] *Ibid.*

[221] Vartuhi Kalantar, *Hapishane-i Umumi Kadinlar Kogusu (1920-1921)*. Translated by, Artur Gebenlioglu, p.55-57. Vartuhi Kalantar was arrested in spring 1915, reportedly the only woman detained in this wave of arrests, and sent with her father, Tavit Kalantaryan, to the *Hapishane-i Umumi*, where Armenian intellectuals arrested on 24 April were also held. She was accused of membership in the "Armenian nationalist and separatist movement" after sending her family a summary of a speech delivered by an Armenian revolutionary at the Armenian Students' Association in Lausanne. The authorities treated the letter as evidence of her participation in alleged anti-Turkish

*Mecmuası* as the director of the Istanbul prison, a position within an institution designed to discipline, reform, and render subjects governable through confinement, labor, and education. [222] The later trajectory of İbrahim's career also illuminates the institutional connections between extralegal violence and formal state discipline. By 1916, he appears as director of the *Hapishane-i Umumi*, an institution organized around confinement, surveillance, discipline, labor, and the production of governable subjects. Rather than treating his prison directorship as the source of his violent capacity, however, the prison should be understood as revealing the broader institutional repertoire through which Ottoman coercion operated. His career moved across the boundary between counterinsurgency and formal administration, demonstrating that the state's disciplinary institutions and its extralegal violence were not necessarily separate worlds. The prison was therefore not simply a place where political opponents were confined; it was part of a wider field of coercive power that could extend beyond its walls.

This **porousness w**as particularly consequential for Armenian revolutionary politics. The prison was itself a site of political struggle. Armenian revolutionaries sought not only to resist arrest but to secure the release of political prisoners, as demonstrated by the Armenian Revolutionary Federation's demand for the liberation of Armenian prisoners during the 1896 Ottoman Bank occupation. [223] Imprisonment thus occupied a double position: it was a technology through which the Ottoman state sought to immobilize political opposition, but it was also a site around which revolutionary politics organized. The history of imprisonment therefore belongs within, rather than outside, the history of Armenian resistance and Ottoman state formation.

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activities, although the correspondence remained personal and did not itself constitute political action. The speech was by Rupen Sevag, who had attended school in Bardizag. See Lerna Ekmekçioğlu, "Kadınlar Koğuşu'nun Siyasi Matmazeli Vartuhi Kalantar Nalbantyan (Zarevant)," 10, 12–13, 18.

[222] Ufuk Adak, "Yirminci Yuzyilin Ilk Yillarinda Yayimlanan Osmanli Mecmualarinda Ceza Infaz Kurumlari," *Erken Cumhuriyet Donemi Kolluk Bibliyografyasi, Guvenlik, Ceza ve Infaz*, s.563.
[223] Armen Garo, *Osmanli Bankasi Baskini: Armen Garo'nun Anilari.* (Istanbul: Belge Yayinlari, 2000).

If İbrahim Bey represents the coercive and extralegal dimension of this process, Ali Şuuri Bey represents its bureaucratic and administrative counterpart**.** A 1912 graduate of the prestigious *Mülkiye* (School of Civil Administration), Ali Şuuri entered Bardizag not as an irregular fighter but as a trained state administrator. After serving on the staff of the governor of Thessaloniki and later the governor of İzmit, he became director of Bardizag in May 1914. His subsequent appointments—to district governor of Ayancık and police chief of Kastamonu—demonstrate that participation in the administration of wartime coercion did not necessarily interrupt an official's bureaucratic career.[224] In Turkish nationalist historiography, he is described as having carried out "the duties" assigned to him with "sincerity and dedication" during this period.[225] After Bardizag, he continued his administrative career: district governor of Ayancık in August 1916, and police chief of Kastamonu in July 1917.

The contrast between İbrahim and Ali Şuuri is analytically important precisely because they were not interchangeable. **İbrahim carried the repertoire of frontier counterinsurgency; Ali Şuuri supplied the administrative capacity through which coercion could be territorialized and normalized.** The destruction of Bardizag therefore depended neither exclusively on irregular violence nor exclusively on bureaucratic command. It emerged through their convergence: frontier-trained coercion weakened the community's capacity to defend itself, while administrative authority converted that vulnerability into a governable process of disarmament, deportation, dispossession, and redistribution.

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224 Vekillerimiz Şuuri Hoşafcı, *TBMM*, https://vekillerimiz.com/vekil/ali-suuri-bey-suuri-hosafci-624/ (accessed date: 09/04/2026).

225 Kazım Öztürk, *Turkish Parliamentary History, TBMM – 2nd Term 1923–1927*, Vol. 3, Ankara, 1995, pp. 455–456; Fahri Çoker, *Turkish Parliamentary History, TBMM – 4th Term 1931–1935*, Vol. 2, Ankara, 1996, p. 85; Mücellidoğlu Ali Çankaya, "With Important Events of the Last Century of Turkish History," *Yeni Mülkiye Tarihi ve Mülkiyeliler (Mülkiye Honor Book)*, Vol. 4, Ankara, 1968–1969, p. 1545.

The colonial boomerang in Bardizag was thus not simply a story of violent techniques moving from one geographical location to another. It was a process through which **personnel, expertise, and institutional practices converged to transform an integrated Armenian community into an internal periphery**. Once that transformation occurred, the destruction of Armenian political and communal capacity created the conditions for the economic processes examined in the remainder of this chapter: the confiscation of property, the appropriation of labor, and the incorporation of Armenian bodies into new relations of ownership and social reproduction.

Paramilitary units operating in civilian dress were particularly important to this process. As Uğur Ümit Üngör argues, such organizations, often mobilized by political elites to target particular populations, played a crucial role in the perpetration of mass violence, even though the genocide's broader trajectory was shaped by wartime escalation, ethnic nationalism, and long-term political planning. Young Turk paramilitary organizations were therefore not simply autonomous bands of perpetrators. They operated within a political environment in which violence could be organized, directed, and retrospectively justified as service to the state and nation.

Indeed, members of the Special Organization themselves frequently represented their actions as patriotic duty. One member defended the organization against accusations of plunder and robbery by insisting that its members sacrificed everything for the homeland and acted decisively when destruction was deemed necessary. Such statements illuminate an important dimension of the colonial boomerang: violence was not merely transferred from one geographical setting to another. It was also transformed into a political language through which coercion could be understood as legitimate state service.

Yet the relationship between the Ottoman state and its irregular agents remained unstable. While many perpetrators benefited from booty and impunity, others became politically expendable once their actions threatened state interests. General Ali Fuat Erden's memoirs describe the bloody spoils accumulated by militiamen, while the case of Çerkez Ahmed demonstrates the limits of tolerated paramilitary autonomy. After his involvement in the killing of Armenians, Çerkez Ahmed was arrested, court-martialed, and hanged in Damascus on 30 September 1915 following orders from the CUP leadership. The episode illustrates the paradox of paramilitary governance: the state relied upon irregular violence while simultaneously claiming the authority to discipline those who exceeded the boundaries of politically useful violence.[226][227]

Ryan Gingeras places this relationship within a longer history of the South Marmara region, arguing that the emergence of organized paramilitary and criminal networks in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries was deeply intertwined with a political environment in which the boundaries between state authority and irregular violence were deliberately obscured.[228] In this context, the careers of İbrahim Bey and Ali Şuuri suggest that the expropriation of Armenian wealth was not simply an incidental consequence of wartime violence. Violence and dispossession could instead be converted into administrative experience, material resources, and political capital. The paramilitary and the bureaucratic were therefore not opposing forms of power; they were mutually reinforcing components of the same governing apparatus.

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[226] Ugur Umit Gungor, "The Armenian Genocide in the Context of 20th century Paramilitarism," p.11-15.

[227] *Ibid*, p.15.

[228] Ryan Gingeras, "Beyond Istanbul's 'Laz Underworld': Ottoman Paramilitarism and the Rise of Turkish Organized Crime, 1908-1950," Contemporary European History, Vol.19, No.3. *Aftershocks: Violence in Dissolving Empires after the First World War* (August 2010), pp. 215-230.

The collapse of the Committee of Union and Progress regime did not erase the institutional, personal, or material consequences of the genocide. Ali Şuuri Bey's postwar career demonstrates the limits of any sharp rupture between the wartime CUP state and its successors. During the Armistice period, he was tried by the Martial Court, chaired by Esat Pasha, for his role in the deportation of Armenians.[229] The testimony presented at the trial provides further evidence of the coercive system in which both Ali Şuuri and İbrahim Bey had participated.[230]

Tanaş Efendi testified that İbrahim Bey had ordered detainees to be beaten. Karabet of İzmit stated that İbrahim Bey had imprisoned approximately fifteen Armenians and ordered gendarmes to beat them, while Artin Kürekçiyan testified that İbrahim Bey had arrested him and that he and other detainees were beaten. Merchant Mihran Semerciyan, meanwhile, testified to Ali Şuuri Bey's personal involvement in the extortion during the deportations during the trials in 1920.[231]

A document dated 24 November 1918 states that Şuuri Bey had acted *müfritane*—that is, excessively or harshly—during the *sevk* deportation of the Armenians from the district. [232]

Buraya Thessaloniki bulduklarim

[229] Enver Konukcu, "Ermenilere Adapazari'ndan Bakis," p.17.

[230] Dadrian, Vahakn N., and Taner Akçam. 2011. *Judgment at Istanbul : The Armenian Genocide Trials*. English-language ed. New York: Berghahn Books. http://site.ebrary.com/id/10521923 p. 216-218. Huseyin Alpaslan, "Izmit Tehciri Yargilamalari II," *Turk Dunyasi Stratejik Arastirmalar Merkezi,* 09/09/2022, https://www.tarihistan.org/yazarlar/huseyin-alpaslan/izmit-tehciri-yargilamalari-ii/37353 (accessed date: 09/21/2026). Vahakn Dadrian Papers, "Arrest, detention, deportation, (Mudros, Malta), 1918-1921, *USC Digital Library*, https://digitallibrary.usc.edu/asset-management/2A3BF1MH9D8B7?FR_=1&W=1631&H=868 ) (accessed date: 09/21/2026).

[231] Nejdet Bilgi, "Izmit Tehciri Davasi," https://www.tarihistan.org/yazarlar/huseyin-alpaslan/izmit-tehciri-yargilamalari-vi/37536 Huseyin Alpaslan, "Izmit Tehciri Yargilamalari VI," *Turk Dunyasi Stratejik Arastirmalar Merkezi,*12/23/2022, https://www.tarihistan.org/yazarlar/huseyin-alpaslan/izmit-tehciri-yargilamalari-vi/37536 (accessed date: 09/21/2026)/ Guerguerian, Krikor, "06 La Renaissance - Takvim - i Vekayi" (2018). Genocide (Various Languages). 6. https://commons.clarku.edu/genocide_various/6

[232] BOA.DH.SFR. 603/85. 11/24/1334-11/24/1918

These testimonies place both men within a local apparatus in which imprisonment, physical coercion, extortion, and deportation operated together. Their subsequent trajectories are significant precisely because prosecution did not necessarily produce permanent exclusion from public life. The wartime apparatus had generated forms of expertise, networks, and political legitimacy that could survive the regime that created them. The colonial boomerang therefore did not simply carry violence from the frontier into the imperial center. It helped produce internal peripheries while creating a repertoire of coercive governance whose personnel and practices could outlive the CUP itself. The end of the empire did not automatically mark the end of these structures; rather, the careers of figures such as Ali Şuuri reveal how elements of the wartime apparatus could be absorbed, rehabilitated, and carried into the political order that followed.

Following his release, he returned to Balıkesir and, in April 1920, was elected a member of the Central Committee of National Defense. A few months later, he was appointed district governor of Balya by the National Government. He was captured by Greek forces on the İvrindi front; after the Armistice of Mudanya, he was exchanged and returned to Turkey in June 1923. He was elected as a deputy for Balıkesir in the 1923, 1927, and 1931 elections and served in the Turkish Grand National Assembly until his death of a sudden stroke on July 20, 1934. The point of this trajectory is not that the Republic was simply the CUP continued; that claim is too broad to defend on the evidence of one career. Rather, the point is that within the shifting context of the Ottoman Empire's decline and the establishment of the Turkish Republic, individuals like Ali Şuuri were able to leverage their involvement in the genocide into personal and professional benefits as they constituted the emerging Turkish national bourgeoisie.

***Expropriation, not simply destruction***

This chapter highlights the economic dimension of the imperial boomerang, as the Ottoman state employed the dual mechanisms of expropriation and exploitation in its attempt to transform the Armenian population of Bardizag into a source of wealth for the state and its favored citizens. Drawing on the distinction that Nancy Fraser makes between exploitation and expropriation in her historical analysis on the political economy of capitalism, this chapter highlights the shifting economic categorization of Armenian subjects of the empire. While exploitation operates through the formalized market mechanisms of the wage contract, expropriation represents accumulation by other means; the coercive, extra-economic seizure of property, labor, and personhood.[233] This process of primitive accumulation, which Karl Marx described as inscribed "in blood and fire," advanced in the Ottoman context through the tandem (synonym) operations of physical extermination and wealth transfer.[234] Critically, as the pioneering work of Anahit Astoyan demonstrates, this expropriation cannot be reduced to the mere confiscation of material wealth, such as land, houses, and vineyards.[235] Rather, genocidal violence targeted human capacity itself; systematically seizing, redirecting, and capitalizing bodies, unfree labor, and physical existence of the Armenian population.

The Armenian case in Bardizag demonstrates both exploitation and expropriation, and holding them together yields a claim that is stronger, and more defensible, than a purely material one. The point is not that the genocide happened because people wanted Armenian property; that

[233] Nancy Fraser, "Expropriation and Exploitation in Racialized Capitalism: A Reply to Michael Dawson," *Critical Historical Studies,* Volume 3, Number 1, 2016. *Cannibal Capitalism: How our System is Devouring Democracy, Care, and the Planet – and What We Can Do About It.* (London: Verso Books, 2022).

[234] Karl Marx, *Capital: A Critique of Political Economy, Vol.1*, (Vintage: 1977), p.875.

235 Anahit Astoyan, *The Pillage of The Century. Expropriation of Armenians in The Ottoman Empire 1914-1923 (Դարի Կողոպուտը Հայերի ՈՒնեզրկումը Օսմանյան Կայսրությունում 1914-1923 թթ).* (Yerevan : Nairi, Armenia, 2015).

formulation is too reductive, and it collapses extermination into a simple motive. The stronger argument is that genocidal policy created the conditions under which Armenian property, labor, and human capacity could be systematically appropriated and redistributed. The genocide did not simply eliminate Armenian economic actors: it appropriated the material and human capacities that their elimination made available. That distinction between motive and mechanism organizes the rest of this chapter, which traces that mechanism across five sites: the administrative dismantling of Bardizag itself (Section II); the different forms this dismantling took for men, women, and children (Section III); the recursive, repeating structure of expropriation as it operated on one survivor, Arshalous Patoogian (Section IV); the relocation rather than termination of extraction once deportees reached Syria (Section V); and the afterlives of this process in postwar disappearance, humanitarian documentation, and the institutional continuities of the Turkish Republic (Section VI).

### II. Producing Expropriability

The deportation and destruction of Bardizag's Armenian community in August 1915 was not an uncoordinated outburst of wartime violence but a meticulously sequenced administrative operation. This section analyzes the operational machinery of the colonial boomerang as it was deployed in the Marmara region, tracing how techniques of counterinsurgency, dispossession, and physical terror migrated from the imperial frontiers back to the political center. Before a population's property, labor, and persons could be appropriated, the state first had to render that population expropriable: incapable of organizing resistance, incapable of self-defense, and incapable of protecting what it owned. That operation followed a clear sequence: bring in specialized perpetrators carrying frontier-tested repertoires of violence, isolate the population, disarm it, and only then extract its wealth. This section reconstructs that sequence through a

narration of three separate but historically entangled moments — the removal of intellectual and communal leadership, a highly ritualized campaign of staged disarmament that functioned as a fiscal instrument of plunder, and the final transition to a coerced marketplace designed to strip the community of its remaining resources under radical duress.

***Removing leadership***

The first stage was the targeted removal of Armenian intellectual and communal leadership. The arrests of April 24, 1915, in Constantinople, which targeted Armenian intellectuals, clergy, and political leaders, established a pattern reproduced in the provinces: arrest, removal from the community, deportation under guard to the interior, and execution beyond public scrutiny. Bardizag's leaders were subjected to this same process. Among those arrested were Dr. Der Stepanian, the teacher Karnig Bodourian, Boghos Kourouyian, and Mihran Der-Garabedian. They were removed from the community under military guard and deported to remote locations in the Anatolian interior, including the high-security prison at Ayas.[236]

Their removal did more than eliminate individual leaders. It severed Bardizag from the networks of authority and knowledge through which the community organized itself. The absence of bodies, graves, and official acknowledgment then transformed their deaths into permanent disappearances. As Özgür Sevgi Göral's work on state-sponsored disappearance demonstrates, this uncertainty can itself function as a mechanism of domination: by withholding knowledge of a victim's fate, the state extends violence beyond the act of killing, suspending families and communities between mourning and hope.[237] In Bardizag, the disappearance of communal leaders

[236] Grigor Mkhalean, and Ara Stepan Melkonian. 2014. *Bardizag and Its People*. London: Gomidas Institute.

[237] This episode may be understood through Özgür Sevgi Göral's analysis of enforced disappearance in Kurdistan during 1990s, which highlights the deliberate production of uncertainty regarding victims' fates as a mechanism of political violence. Viewed through this lens, Armenian Genocide was not only a history of mass killing and deportation but also a regime of disappearance in which families were denied knowledge about their loved ones. Özgür Sevgi Göral, "Waiting for the disappeared: waiting as a form of resilience and the limits of legal space in Turkey," *Soc Anthropol*, 29, 2021, 800-815. https://doi.org/10.1111/1469-8676.13096

therefore operated both materially and psychologically, weakening the community's capacity to organize while generating fear and uncertainty among those who remained. The distance between arrest and execution was consequently not merely logistical: by transporting leaders to remote sites, the state deprived their communities of witnesses, obscured the circumstances of their deaths, and disrupted conventional practices of mourning. Disappearance thus became part of the process of communal destruction rather than simply a means of concealing violence after the fact. This disappearance had a long postwar afterlife of its own; for families who spent years trying to learn what had happened to the missing, which is taken up in Section VI, alongside the other institutional afterlives of the genocide.[238]

***Staged disarmament***

According to Turkish nationalist historiography, claims that the deportations of Armenians during World War I were defensive and necessary measures taken to preserve the security of the Ottoman Empire. From this perspective, the Ottomans authorities faced a dual threat: an advancing Russian army on the eastern front and internal unrest allegedly instigated by Armenian revolutionary groups such as the Dashnaks (*Dashnaktsutyun*) committees. Advocates of this view argue that Armenians in regions like İzmit, Adapazarı, and the eastern provinces engaged in espionage, rebellion, and armed collaboration with Russia, thereby endangering the stability of the state. [239] Consequently, the government is portrayed as having implemented the

[238] It is perhaps not surprising that survivors of the Armenian Genocide and their descendants later found common cause with analogous movements in Argentina and Turkey. In both countries, in the aftermath of fascist coups, state and paramilitary forces disappeared political opponents, leaving families without knowledge of their fate. The Saturday Mothers of Turkey and the Mothers of the Plaza de Mayo in Argentina emerged from precisely this grief: the refusal to accept silence in the face of state-sponsored disappearance that Armenian/diaspora community in both countries gravitated toward these struggles speaks not only shared political solidarity but a transgenerational familiarity with the particular cruelty of disappearance as a tool of political terror. (Source)

[239] Selma Cetinkaya and Taner Bilgin, "Tehcir Kanunu ve Izmit Ermenileri," *Uluslararası Kara Mürsel Alp ve Kocaeli Tarihi Sempozyumu -II = International Symposium on Kara Mürsel Alp & History of Kocaeli -II.* (Kocaeli: Kocaeli Büyükşehir Belediyesi, Kültür ve Sosyal İşler Dairesi Başkanlığı Yayınları, 2016), p.1313. Ari Şekeryan, 2023. *The Armenians and the Fall of the Ottoman Empire : After Genocide, 1918-1923*. Cambridge, United Kingdom: Cambridge University Press, 2023, p.44.

relocations (*tehcir*) as a precautionary response to treason and civil disorder rather than as a campaign of persecution.

The mutesarrif of İzmit, Deli Mazhar Bey (June 1913–September 1916), dutifully executed Istanbul's orders, and by early 1915 only a few Armenian notables had been arrested, acts still seen locally as isolated forms of repression. The situation changed with the arrival of two CUP delegates from the frontier regions of the empire: Ibrahim Bey (Tchete Bashi, Deli {Crazy} Ibrahim), former director of Istanbul's prisons, and Hoca Rifat Effendi.[240] Their mission was to implement mass deportation.[241] Yet the measures that would culminate in deportation were already visible months earlier. On 26 January 1915, a police report recorded that searches of the Armenian villages of Bahçecik, Yuvacık, Arslanbey, and Döngel in the İzmit district had uncovered weapons and ammunition.[242] At this stage, state intervention took the form of searches, weapons seizures, and the arrest of Armenian notables. Over the following months, these measures escalated into the systematic removal of Armenian communities: on 5/18 July 1915, the Interior Ministry authorized the deportation of Armenians from forty-two localities in the İzmit district.[243]

As officers of the *Teşkilat-ı Mahsusa*, Ibrahim Bey and Hoca Rifat directed bands under Şevket Bey, Faik Bey (İzmit's gendarmerie commander), *Çeteci* Mehmed, *Çeteci* Edhem, *Çeteci* Pehlivan, and Hasan Çavuş, who carried out the violence on the ground. The administrative machinery was overseen by Major Mustafa Emir, Eşref Adil Bey, Beha Bey, militia head

[240] BOA.DH.SFR. 479/51 04/26/1331- British High Commissioner provide the list of criminals of the massacres during the WWI which lists Ibrahim Bey and Ali Suuri. FO 371/5089 No.82/W.2886 06/15/1920 available in USC Library Vahakn Dadrian Papers, Vahakn Dadrian Archives, "Arrest, detention, deportation (Mudros, Malta), 1918-1921," https://digitallibrary.usc.edu/asset-management/2A3BF1MH9D8B7?FR_=1&W=1630&H=858

[241] Richard Diran Kloian, *The Armenian Genocide News Account from the American Press: 1915-1922*, p.28.

[242] BOA.DH.EUM. 2.Sb. 2/67-A in Osmanli Belgelerinde Ermenilerin Sevk., p.108

[243] Kasabian, Nesim Ovadya Izrail, Izmit Techir Belgeleri

Hüseyin Çavuş, and police chief Reşid Bey, while İzmit's Unionist elites—including naval officer İsmail Ali Bey, lawyer Şerif Bey, and pharmacist Cavid Bey—organized propaganda and facilitated the expropriation of Armenian assets through the *emval-i metruke* (abandoned property) commission.[244]

Together, these actors formed a coordinated apparatus of state and paramilitary collaboration: the Special Organization supplied the means of violence, the bureaucracy provided administrative authority, and local Unionists facilitated the transfer of Armenian property. The first deportations targeted Adapazarı rather than İzmit.[245] In early May, approximately fifty prominent Armenians were arrested and deported to Sultaniye in Konya province and Koçhisar. Soon afterward, two Ottoman divisions entered the Armenian neighborhoods, clearing the ground for their destruction.

İstepan İstepanyan's testimony illustrates how this machinery operated across the region. He recalled that on April 11, 1915, he and twelve others were arrested and deported from Adapazarı. En route, they were joined by two groups from Nicomedia and Bardizag, revealing how Armenians from neighboring communities were funneled into shared deportation routes.[246] Their convoy was diverted from Ankara to Sultaniye near Konya, a major collection point for deportees from Asia Minor. A veiled letter from home later reported that Çete İbrahim, dispatched from Istanbul, had imprisoned Adapazarı's leading Armenians in the Surp Hreşdagabet Church, where they were tortured, disarmed, and ordered to prepare for deportation to Der Zor. İstepanyan's account thus connects local imprisonment and violence to the broader

[244] Grigor Mkhalean,

[245] Towards Golgotha, p.61-63.

[246] Arsag Alboyaciyan**,** 'Huşamadyan Gudinahayeru' (Kütahya Ermenileri Anı Kitabı), Beyrut, Donikyan Basımevi, 1961. Sayfa 218-228)

machinery of organized deportation and demonstrates how the destruction of Armenian communities was coordinated across neighboring towns.

In late May 1915, the CUP delegate İbrahim Bey, a former *çete* leader from Macedonia who would later oversee atrocities in Bardizag, arrived in Adabazar and immediately ordered the arrest of prominent Armenians, including merchant Bedros Afeyan, banker Bedros Muradian, and municipal president Stepan Demirjian.[247] Accompanied by police chief Reşid Bey, he visited the detainees confined in the Church of the Holy Archangel, boasting of his experience in raids and demanding the surrender of 250 Mauser rifles. This fabricated weapons search provided the pretext for mass arrests: within days, 600–700 men were imprisoned in the Church of St. Garabed. Under İbrahim's orders, Father Mikayel Yeramian and Antranig Charkejian were tortured for confessions about hidden arms, and ten leading figures were sent to Istanbul for trial.

On 11 August, the deportation order for Adabazar and surrounding villages was announced. [248] Armenian neighborhoods were sealed off, escape barred, and possessions confiscated. Over the following two weeks, more than 20,000 Armenians; beginning with residents of Nemçer and Malacılar—were deported toward Konya.[249] Only twenty-five families employed by the army and a single family that converted to Islam were allowed to remain. In the kaza of Ismit, the violence centered on Bardizag and Arslanbeg, targeted for evacuation before other Armenian communities. In Arslanbeg, arrests began in May; detainees were held in Ismit and then transferred to Geyve's Turkish village of Taraklı, where elites from other towns were concentrated. On 18 July, İbrahim Bey ordered 200 soldiers and gendarmes to surround Arslanbeg, after which deportations began and Çerkez çetes of the Special Organization, aided

[247] Raymond Kevorkian*, Armenian Genocide*, p.552-555.

[248] BOA. DH.SFR. 54-A/340 08/09/1915 in Osmanli Belgelerinde Ermenilerin, p.207.

[249] Raymond Kevorkian, Nesim Ovadya Izrail

by local Turkish villagers, looted and destroyed the town. Over 2,000 people were deported via Eskişehir, Konya, and Bozanti to destinations including Rakka, Meskene, Der Zor, Mosul, and Baghdad; few returned.

With leadership removed, the operational machinery turned to disarmament. On June 27, 1915, Ibrahim Bey and Ali Şuuri Bey orchestrated a staged, highly public disarmament campaign in Bardizag. This campaign involved ritualized threats of massacre and the systematic conversion of civic and religious institutions; village schools and churches into militarized spaces of coercion. The primary physical technology of this coercion was the *falaka,* ritualized beating on the soles of the feet, administered by Ibrahim Bey and his gang of irregulars. The *falaka* was not merely an instrument of physical punishment; it functioned as a fiscal instrument designed to break communal resistance, enforce submission, and facilitate mass plunder. By subjecting community leaders and ordinary residents to systematic violence, state officials forced the population to reveal hidden weapon caches, gold, and personal valuables.

Vahakn Dadrian/Taner Akcam The postwar Ottoman government initiated a series of prosecutions against Unionist leaders and functionaries before the Special Military Tribunal (*Divan-ı Harb-i Örfî*) between 1919 and 1922. At least sixty-three trials directly concerned crimes committed against Armenians. Talat Pasha was tried in absentia alongside other leading Unionists and wartime cabinet ministers and sentenced to death on 5 July 1919 for his role in the massacres.[250] Drawing on witness testimony, memoranda, coded telegrams, letters, and other documents, the indictments maintained that the massacres of deported Armenians were carried out "under the orders and with the knowledge of Talat, Enver and Cemal Beys." The postwar İzmit deportation trials are particularly valuable for reconstructing the localized mechanisms of this violence. Their testimonies document charges

[250] Basak Ertur, p.106.

including *nehb* (plunder), *garet* (robbery),deportation, and *irtishah* (bribery), providing empirical evidence of how deportation was accompanied by the systematic dispossession of Armenians. Kirkor Efendi, a janitor at the Armenian patriarchate, testified that when they were sent to Izmit, they were imprisoned inside a church, where he was beaten with a falaka in the direct presence of Ibrahim Bey, who then confiscated his money. Mıgırdıç testified that during his transfer from Istanbul to Çankırı, he was detained for five days in Izmit, taken to a house where Ibrahim Bey was staying, and severely beaten. Artin Kürekçiyan and Karabet from İzmit both testified that İbrahim Bey imprisoned groups of Armenians and ordered his gendarmes to beat them. Serope Efendi confirmed that during her transfer to Konya via İzmit, she witnessed and heard that İbrahim Bey's entourage systematically beat deportees and took their money. Hacı Mıgırdıç Karabet testified that İbrahim Bey arrived to collect weapons fifteen days prior to the deportation, mistreating the inhabitants in every possible way, while Ali Şuuri Bey accompanied him and directly seized personal belongings from his house. Priest Aganya Efendi of Bardizag and Minas Efendi likewise confirmed that İbrahim Bey assaulted the villagers under the pretext of weapon collection.

This violence culminated in the partial demolition of the village church during extensive searches. After repeated rounds of torture with wet canes, surviving community leaders were forced to sign documents pledging to surrender any remaining arms under penalty of immediate death. Gendarmes then conducted exhaustive house-to-house sweeps of every household, khan, and local silk-spinning factory, confiscating not only firearms but also any metal tool that could potentially be used for defense, including pocketknives, saws, and agricultural sickles. This performative act of selective dispossession was highly asymmetrical: while weapons were permanently stripped from Armenians, those surrendered by Muslim villagers within Bardizag and the neighboring communitie were promptly returned to them. That asymmetry is not incidental,

and it is not merely an anecdote. It demonstrates that "disarmament" was not neutral security policy: it dismantled Armenian collective capacity while preserving the coercive capacity of the population that would benefit from Armenian dispossession. The causal sequence is worth stating explicitly, because it is easy for a reader to miss if it is left implicit: remove leadership, isolate the population, disarm the population, thereby make resistance difficult, and thereby facilitate expropriation. By leaving Armenians entirely defenseless while arming surrounding populations, the state produced the specific vulnerability required to execute the final stage of primitive accumulation; the liquidation of the community's remaining wealth.

***The coerced marketplace***

Once the community had been stripped of its leadership and defensive capacity, the operational machinery shifted from physical terror to administrative and financial extraction. The aim was to liquidate the remaining portable wealth of the Armenian population and transfer it into the hands of state officials, CUP networks, and neighboring Muslim populations. Even before the formal deportation order was issued, local authorities used administrative pressure, extortion and fraudulent promises to drain the community's financial resources while exploiting survivors' desperate attempts to secure their safety. Hagop der Hagopian records that the villagers of Bardizag collectively raised four hundred gold liras as a donation to the Ottoman Red Crescent and military hospital, presenting the money to local governor, Ali Şuuri Bey, in an effort to demonstrate their loyalty and secure protection.[251] Although the authorities accepted and praised the donation, it offered no protection against the dispossession that followed. Families were also reportedly compelled to sums of up to four hundred Turkish pounds on the promise that such payments would exempt them from the deportation lists.

[251] Grigor Mkhalean, and Ara Stepan Melkonian. 2014. *Bardizag and Its People*. London: Gomidas Institute. p.x.

The postwar trials furthesr reveal how such transfers could be contested and subsequently reframed by local officials. The merchant Mihran Semerciyan testified that Ali Şuuri had engaged in widespread corruption during the deportations and extorted 650 liras' worth of his personal belongings under direct threat. Ali Şuuri denied the accusation. He described the money collected from Armenians as a fundraising campaign that followed a speech he delivered on the July 10th holiday, claiming that 800 liras not the 1,800 liras alleged by others had been collected and deposited in the state treasury for the construction of a hospital.[252] He similarly maintained that Armenians had sold their property voluntarily, taking some possessions with them and leaving the remainder behind for the Abandoned Property Officer to confiscate. He denied personally taking valuables, sheep, or sewing machines and presented himself as an official who had attempted to prevent abuses.

The discrepancy between these accounts is revealing. Property transfers that survivors experienced as extortion or coercion could be recast by officials as charitable donations, voluntary sales, or routine transfers to the Abandoned Property administration. Administrative language thus helped transform coercive dispossession into an apparently lawful process of property liquidation.

The resulting scene in the streets of Bardizag is best conceptualized as a coerced marketplace, rather than a merely "distressed" economic space. Under ordinary market logic, prices fluctuate according to supply and demand. Here, exchange was dictated by radical asymmetry, duress, and extra-economic coercion. Crowds of neighboring Muslim populations; Laz, Georgian, Tatar, and Turkish neighbors, arrived in the village specifically to profit from the forced liquidations.[253] The prices paid for Armenian assets were catastrophically low: fully

[252]

[253] *Ibid.*

furnished houses were emptied within days, with furniture, jewelry, and prized household goods worth five to ten liras sold for a mere five to ten kuruş, a fraction of a lira. Most families recovered only trivial, insulting amounts; usually no more than three, five, or ten liras, which were often immediately stolen or confiscated by gendarmerie forces on the road. Some families, recognizing this process as state-sanctioned and legalized plunder, refused to participate in the marketplace, choosing instead to face deportation with their belongings intact and preferring the risk of death to submission to systemic robbery. A striking example is the "Temporary Law of Expropriation and Confiscation," passed by the Ottoman Parliament on September 13, 1915, which authorized the seizure of Armenian-owned land, livestock, and homes under the cover of legal sanction. Alongside this juridical seizure, deportees were systematically robbed by local villagers, paramilitary bands, and government-contracted agents, while money, jewelry, clothing, and other provisions were taken along the deportation routes. The *Emvâl-i Metruke* (Abandoned Properties) system subsequently absorbed whatever remained in emptied Armenian homes: the Abandoned Property authorities confiscated unsold goods and redistributed them to CUP-affiliated elites and state institutions or used them in the resettlement of Muslim refugees. Violence and legislation thus operated not as separate processes but as mutually reinforcing mechanisms through which dispossession was converted into an institutionalized transfer of capital.

This process can be illuminated through Onur Ulaş İnce's engagement with Walter Benjamin's "Critique of Violence." İnce distinguishes between capital-positing violence, which establishes the legal and institutional conditions for accumulation, and capital-preserving violence, which enforces and reproduces those conditions. The Armenian case demonstrates both modalities: the expropriation law constituted the lawmaking moment that translated violent

seizure into juridical right, while *the Emvâl-i Metruke* regime bureaucratically enforced Armenians' permanent exclusion from their property and means of livelihood. As Taner Akçam and Ümit Kurt have shown, this legal architecture did not merely provide a "legal veil" for violence; it transformed dispossession into an enduring mechanism of governance, ensuring that Armenian property could be systematically transferred, redistributed, and incorporated into a new social and economic order.

This account is consistent with, and builds on, the historiography establishing that the confiscation of Armenian property was not a chaotic byproduct of wartime dislocation or localized opportunistic greed, as mainstream historiography analyzed it for decades. Pioneering research by Hilmar Kaiser, Ümit Kurt, and Bedross Der Matossian has demonstrated instead that the confiscation of Armenian properties was orchestrated through the full administrative and legislative machinery of the Ottoman state, bridging central ministries with provincial and local authorities. In his critical analysis of genocidal violence, Yektan Türkyılmaz draws on Claudia Card's concept of "social death" to argue that the Armenian Genocide did not merely target biological life but aimed at the absolute destruction of Western Armenian social, political, cultural, and economic networks; the systematic transfer of capital served as the primary instrument of this social death.[254] As Harry Harootunian has argued, the genocide was a large-scale project of primitive accumulation through which pre-capitalist wealth, generated through centuries of Armenian labor, agriculture, and commerce, was forcefully converted into the foundational capital essential for the emerging Turkish national economy.[255] In Bardizag, this took a highly physical and localized form: as missionary Arthur Ryan reported present in Bardizag between October and November 1915, reported that only about sixty Armenians

[254] Yektan Turkyilmaz, p.337.

[255] Harry Harootunian

remained, most of them disabled and under American care. Turkish officials collected movable property and shipped it to Istanbul, while sixty Muslim families were resettled in Armenian homes. In nearby villages, Armenian women and children were denied food unless they converted. Ryan further confirmed that İzmit's Armenian district had been reduced to rubble and its bazaar stripped of goods.

Through this process of legal and extra-legal redistribution, the newly founded Turkish Republic positioned itself as the direct heir to the confiscated wealth. By redistributing these assets to members of the Committee of Union and Progress, local Muslim elites, and loyal businessmen, the state actively restructured class relations, consolidating a compliant and dependent Turkish national bourgeoisie whose class survival was structurally tethered to the erasure of the Armenian presence. The techniques of dispossession and extraction deployed in the streets of Bardizag; forced liquidation, administrative fraud, extortion, and the mobilization of neighboring ethnic communities as instruments of dispossession, were not novel. They represented a highly coordinated form of the fiscal instrument that had already been practiced on the empire's populations for decades. In 1915, the colonial boomerang returned to the heartland, converting the wealth generated through centuries of Armenian labor into foundational capital for the emerging national economy.

III. The Gendered Forms of Expropriation

Expropriation in Bardizag was gendered from the beginning, not merely in its consequences but in its mechanisms. The genocidal economy assigned Armenian bodies different forms of extractive value according to gender and age: men's labor was conscripted into the state's logistical apparatus arrest, conscription, labor battalions, later military factories, productive labor, while women and children were absorbed into households, captivity, domestic labor, forced

incorporation, marriage, reproductive and care work, household production. This was not a secondary effect of a gender-neutral process of destruction; it was one of the primary mechanisms through which destruction was converted into accumulation. The point is not simply that women were also victims. It is that the genocidal economy assigned Armenian bodies different forms of extractive value according to gender and age.

***Men: conscription and labor battalions***

With the onset of mobilization, the Ottoman state conscripted nearly all of Bardizag's young men, approximately one thousand individuals, into auxiliary, unarmed labor battalions (*amele taburları*) in May 1915.[256] Tasos Iakovidis's testimony, though concerning a Greek railway worker from Nicomedia, illuminates the broader system of wartime labor mobilization. Born in 1889, Iakovidis joined the railway company at nineteen and initially avoided the labor battalions because of his technical expertise, which railway officials deemed useful for training Turkish workers.[257] After escaping from Edirne, however, he was captured and sent to a labor battalion in Nicomedia, demonstrating that even skilled Christian workers remained subject to coercive labor mobilization once their labor was no longer needed elsewhere. In August, nineteen-year-old conscripts of Bardizag were also drafted and transferred to Constantinople. Reflecting the state's deep structural mistrust of its Christian subjects, these men were kept entirely unarmed and assigned to grueling logistical tasks: road construction, railway repair, agricultural labor, and the transportation of military provisions over long distances on foot - in other words, they were forced to establish the infrastructure of the emerging bourgeois state from

[256] Tigran Martirosyan, "Labour Battalions: Ottoman Empire/Middle East," 1914-1918 International Encyclopedia of the First World War," https://encyclopedia.1914-1918-online.net/article/labour-battalions-ottoman-empiremiddle-east/ (accessed date: 09/04/2026).

[257] "Tasos Iakovidis", Nicomedia Region, 1930-1969, *Center for Asia Minor Studies*, July 7 1960. I would like to thank Stavros Anestidis and the interns at the Center for Asia Minor Studies for helping their assistance in translating this interview.

which they would be excluded. Lacking basic shelter, clothing, and adequate food, these conscripts endured extreme suffering in what survivors called "camps of shadows," where their bodies were ravaged by disease, starvation, and exposure. By draining Bardizag of its young, able-bodied male population, the Ottoman state effectively eliminated the possibility of armed resistance and initiated the economic devaluation of Armenian labor;  productive labor extracted from men under conditions designed to exhaust rather than sustain them.

***Women and children: a conceptual framework***

For women and children, expropriation operated differently: not through conscription into state labor but through household captivity. Three concepts, developed more fully in Section IV through the case of Arshalous Patoogian, describe how this worked. Recursive expropriation treats expropriation not as a single originary act but as a repeating, serial structure. For Armenian women and children, the act of being sold did not end her status as a commodity, but marked a singular moment in a vicious cycle. This cycle prevented captives from being able to establish any sense of stability or to gather any resources with which she could hope to gain freedom.

A captive sold and resold across successive households had the relation of domination reset with each transfer, stripping away whatever relational capital, local knowledge, and fragile social ties she had begun to accumulate, and foreclosing the possibility of escape. Coerced incorporation describes captives' absorption into intimate household categories — wife, maid, rescued orphan, protected person. These legibleme classifications naturalized their dependency and co-opted social structures to obscure what was, in substance, an unfree and unwaged labor relation. Domination, in other words, does not always operate by keeping someone visibly outside society; sometimes it works by absorbing them into social categories that conceal coercion, making it harder to see.

Hollow freedom names the colonization of respected legal and social forms, most notably the legal registration of marriage (*pasakadrutyun*). It describes a condition in which a formal or socially recognized status associated with consent; particularly marriage exists without the material conditions necessary for meaningful choice. As exemplified by Taguhi Seferian-Antonyan, known as Hikmet Hanım after her marriage to Ali Şuuri Bey, ordinary institutions were co-opted as instruments of possession, rendering captivity invisible while demanding total identity renunciation as the price of physical survival.[258]

Ali Şuuri Bey's testimony during Izmit deportation trial illustrates how readily such violence could be rendered invisible through the language of legitimate domesticity. During the deportations, he claimed to have provided three houses for disabled and sick Armenians to use as a makeshift hospital. He denied an accusation that he had raped an Armenian girl, insisting instead that she was his lawful wife, and claimed that half of the Armenians respected him while the other half did not. Marriage and protection thus provided a vocabulary through which coercion could be recast as benevolence and possession as legitimate domestic authority.

**Highlight:** The violence of this process survives not only in official records but also in the memories of those who endured it. Anais Martin recalls her grandmother, Arşaluys, who came from Bardizag in Adapazarı. "There were no incidents there; we experienced the genocide in our homes," she remembered her grandmother saying. Too young to understand the meaning of the words, Martin nevertheless remembered her grandmother's tears as she rocked her grandchildren and sang laments, especially those embroidered on her headdress. [259] The phrase "We experienced the genocide in our homes" captures precisely the form of expropriation

[258] Katharine Derderian, "Common Fate, Different Experience: Gender-specific Aspects of the Armenian Genocide, 1915-1917," *Holocaust Genocide Studies.* Vol.19, N.1, p.12.
[259] Anais Martin, "Tehcir Artigi Kadinlarin Cileleri ve Oykuleri Benzesir Mi?," *Evrensel,* April 05, 2015. https://www.evrensel.net/haber/109656/tehcir-artigi-kadinlarin-cileleri-ve-oykuleri-benzesir-mi (accessed date: 09/12/25)

that conventional accounts of deportation can obscure. Violence did not end when Armenians were removed from public space. For women and children who survived, it continued within houses, orphanages, marriages, and other intimate institutions. For Arşaluys, however, survival did not end captivity. According to the family account, she was taken while still very young. A Turkish neighbor, a pumpkin trader, transported her to Istanbul hidden beneath pumpkins and placed her in an Armenian orphanage. Yet displacement continued there. Children from Hemşin, Kayseri, Adana, and elsewhere were gathered together only to be dispersed again: some adopted by Armenian families, others placed with Muslim households. Arşaluys, among the youngest, was sent to live with Armenian families as a day maid. Her trajectory from Bardizag to concealment and flight, from orphanage to domestic service makes visible the recursive character of expropriation. Survival did not restore freedom; it reorganized her position within successive relations of labor, dependency, and belonging. Each new household could become another site where her labor and identity were appropriated to the needs of others. The home, therefore, was not outside the machinery of expropriation. It was one of its principal sites.

***Racial capitalism***

By focusing on the extraction of human capacity, this chapter enters into dialogue with Black radical feminist scholarship and theories of racial capitalism, which insist that capitalist relations have always depended on a relational, racialized, gendered division of labor: the formal freedom of the favored population is relationally distributed across unequal social fields and remains structurally dependent upon the violent, unfree subjection of others. Saidiya Hartman's analysis in Scenes of Subjection is useful for elaborating this dynamic, but it must be used carefully; as a conceptual tool, not as an equivalence between the Ottoman Armenian case and the history of African American enslavement. Hartman demonstrates that the U.S. postbellum order

reconciled freedom and bondage within the grammar of liberal legality: the state legally recognized formerly enslaved Black subjects in order to discipline and manage them through contract law and new legal codes. In the American case, the master-slave dynamic was codified, and its violence was subsequently administered through the very institutions of freedom; contract, wage, juridical personhood, that nominally superseded it.[260] Even after emancipation, Black subjects remained visible to the law as subjects whose freedom required management; bondage and liberty were not oppositional categories but were reconciled within the grammar of liberal legality itself. Hartman's intervention thus fundamentally reframes the relationship between freedom and domination: the production of free subjects has historically depended upon expropriative relations that remain structurally obscured.

The Armenian case both confirms Hartman's insight into freedom's constitutive dependence on unfreedom and demands a crucial analytical extension. Unlike the postbellum American context, the late Ottoman domestic space in which Armenian women and children were held captive operated through a regime this chapter calls juridical disappearance, which persisted until the Armistice of Mudros. There were no Ottoman slave codes naming the condition of a captive Armenian woman or child, no formal emancipation to be administered, and no legal category through which her captivity could become publicly legible or contestable. In the absence of slave codes, the captivity of Armenian women and children was rendered legally and socially invisible. The Ottoman state did not manage the captive through legal recognition; instead, it actively inverted the violence of captivity through the naturalizing, benevolent languages of "rescue," charity, and domestic kinship; she was framed not as enslaved but as rescued, saved from genocide, charitably integrated into Muslim domestic life through the language of protection. This distinction is historically significant because it reveals a different modality of expropriative power.

[260] Saidiya Hartman, *Scenes of Subjection: Terror, Slavery and Self-Making in the Nineteenth Century America*, p.X.

If Hartman demonstrates how domination survived through juridical recognition, the Armenian case demonstrates how domination could persist through juridical disappearance. Rather than reconciling freedom and bondage through law, Ottoman domestic structures dissolved the contradiction by rendering bondage socially invisible until, that is, the collapse of the CUP regime and the Allied occupation finally forced an acknowledgment. Following the end of the First World War, the Ministry of Interior of the new Ottoman government, acting under orders from the Allied forces, issued directives beginning in November 1918 for the release of Armenian slaves, political prisoners, orphan girls, and women, as Nazan Maksudyan has shown.[261] Lerna Ekmekcioglu has also shown that the Ministry's directive specifically addressed the detention of Armenian women and children, explicitly acknowledging their status as "slaves," and instructed that Christian girls and children who had been kept by force (*cebren*) in Muslim households be freed and returned to their relatives, or handed over to local Armenian religious authorities; an acknowledgment that arrived only after the fact, and only under Allied pressure.[262]

It is worth being precise about the vocabulary this chapter uses for that condition. Forced labor, or unfree labor, describes any form of work performed against a person's will (*cebren*), under the constant threat of death, violence, detention, destitution, or other extreme hardship affecting the person or their family, relatives, or community. Slavery is often distinguished from this by the fact that the enslaved person's place of work and residence is dictated by whoever holds them in bondage, such that the person is treated as the property of an owner. The Armenian women and children of Bardizag experienced both registers simultaneously, which is precisely why the

[261] Nazan Maksudyan, *Ottoman Children and Youth During World War One,* p.114.

[262] "Hıristiyan ailelerine mensup kızların ve çocukların Müslüman aileler nezdinde cebren alıkonulduğu haber alındığından, tahkikat yapılarak derhal aile veya akrabalarına teslimlerine dair." BOA, DH.ŞFR., 92/196, 15/M/1337 (21.10.1918); BOA, DH.ŞFR., 95/212, 19/R/1337 (23.12.1918); first mentioned in Lerna Ekmekçioğlu, "A Climate for Abduction," p.533.

Ottoman state's refusal to name their condition in law — until the very end of the war — mattered so much: it was not simply a legal oversight but an active, sustained mechanism of concealment.

***A constitutive silence***

Holding these gendered sites of extraction together in a single analytical frame exposes what might be called a constitutive silence in Ottoman labor and gender historiography. Ezgi Akyol's recent work powerfully reframes the First World War as a process of "total destruction," arguing that wartime capitalism transformed Ottoman society far beyond the Armenian case alone: faced with bankruptcy and the demands of total war, the empire mobilized women and children into the war economy, accelerating processes of primitive accumulation, proletarianization, and social dislocation.[263] Small producers lost autonomy, rural populations were uprooted, and wartime economic pressures drove mass movement into urban labor structures. Recent scholarship has extensively documented this wartime mobilization of Muslim women into public workshops and state agencies such as the Islamic Organization for the Employment of Women. Akyol's framework is essential to understanding how total war reorganized Ottoman society at multiple levels. Yet even within this expansive account, Armenian women and children remain largely absent—not simply as victims of violence, but as a population whose labor was being reorganized through a fundamentally different form of wartime coercion.

Lerna Ekmekçioğlu identifies a related problem within the historiography of Ottoman and Turkish feminism. She argues that feminist histories have long treated "Ottoman," "Turkish," and "Muslim" as interchangeable categories, marginalizing non-Muslim women and, in particular, Armenian feminists. More importantly, she cautions against an "add and stir"

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[263] Ezgi Akyol, *Birinci Dünya Savaşı'nda Osmanlı İmparatorluğu'nda İlksel Birikim ve Kapitalist Devlet.* Unpublished PhD Dissertation (İstanbul Üniversitesi,Siyasal Bilgiler Fakültesi, Kamu Yönetimi Ve Siyaset Bilimi Bölümü, Istanbul, 2022).

approach that merely inserts Armenian women into an already established narrative without reconsidering the historical structures that produced their distinct political subjectivities. [264] Such an approach, she argues, can acknowledge Armenian presence while leaving unexamined the imperial hierarchy, mass violence, and ultimately genocide that shaped the relationship between Armenian and Muslim women. Ekmekçioğlu thus calls attention not only to the absence of Armenian women from feminist historiography but to the conditions that make that absence possible: the tendency to imagine Ottoman women as a horizontally constituted community of shared experience while overlooking the confessional and political hierarchies that structured their lives.

This chapter extends that critique from the history of feminist subjectivity to the history of labor and extraction. The problem is not simply that Armenian women have been omitted from accounts of wartime labor mobilization. It is that the categories through which wartime labor has been analyzed can obscure the fundamentally different forms of coercion imposed upon populations according to their position within the imperial social order. Muslim women were increasingly incorporated into a state-directed wartime economy through new forms of productive labor and public mobilization; Armenian women and children were simultaneously subjected to deportation, dispossession, household captivity, and the appropriation of their labor through genocidal violence. These were not interchangeable experiences, nor can they be collapsed into a single category of "women's wartime labor." But they were historically connected within the same wartime political economy.

The contrast therefore reveals something more than a historiographical omission. **Patriotic labor mobilization and genocidal domestic captivity constituted distinct**

[264] Lerna Ekmekcioglu, "Majority Feminism and Mass Violence: How to Situate Armenians in Ottoman/Turkish Feminist Historiography," in *Mapping Gender in the Near East: What's New and What's Ahead in Ottoman and Turkish Women's, Gender, and Sexuality Studies* (Istanbul: Orient-Institut Istanbul, 2022), p. 44–51.

**but interconnected modes of wartime social reproduction.** The unfree, unwaged domestic labor of Armenian women and children, alongside the coerced labor of the male "productive remnant" conscripted into labor battalions and, later, Cemal Pasha's military factories in Syria, was produced through the destruction and expropriation of an Armenian community. Their labor and property could consequently be redirected toward the reproduction of households, institutions, and economic relations within the emerging national order. The relative freedom and productive incorporation of the favored population therefore cannot be understood separately from the simultaneous unfreedom imposed upon those marked for destruction.

### IV. Recursive Expropriation: Arshalous Patoogian

The archives of the Ottoman Ministry of Interior are filled with documents recording such "adoptions". The Directorate of Public Security explicitly stated that the state had no objection to officials adopting Armenian girls**.** In practice, such policies were carried out on a massive scale. According to the personal registers of Talat Pasha**,** later published by Murat Bardakçı, out of the 10,314 Armenian orphans reported by provincial authorities**,** 6,858 were distributed to Muslim families, while 3,456 were placed in state orphanages.[265] Although these figures are incomplete, they reveal the institutionalized character of child expropriation; a process that might be termed the bureaucratization of abduction. Through this process, the Ottoman state transformed Armenian children into objects of demographic engineering, social assimilation and labor extraction.

Hundreds of additional children were subsequently transferred from Anatolia to Istanbul through the Islamic Society for the Employment of Women (*Kadınları Çalıştırma Cemiyet-i İslamiyesi*). [266] Girls were distributed to Muslim households chosen by the Ministry, and boys

[265] Murat Bardakçı, *Talât Paşa'nın Evrak-ı Metrukesi*, p.88–89. Fuat Dündar, *Modern Türkiye'nin Şifresi*, 30; Watenpaugh, "The League of Nations' Rescue," 1329.
[266] Nazan Maksudyan, "Children and Youth: Ottoman Empire (Ottoman Empire/Middle East)," *International Encyclopedia of the First World War 1914-1918 Online*, https://encyclopedia.1914-1918-online.net/article/children-

were sent to workshops and small businesses, further blurring the boundaries between humanitarian welfare, forced labor, and cultural erasure. As Zabel Yesayan observed, Armenian women and children were treated as "cheap commodities", their bodies and labor exploited for the benefit of Ottoman society. Some were abducted, forced into harems, or tattooed as markers of ownership; others were compelled to perform unpaid domestic labor.[267]

At the end of World War I, Armenian and international organizations, foreign missions, and individual activists confronted the consequences of this system by undertaking the difficult task of locating and assisting survivors of the Armenian Genocide. Particular attention was directed toward Armenians who had been forcibly incorporated into Muslim households and institutions, including those who had been enslaved, adopted, married into Muslim families, or converted to Islam under coercive circumstances. These efforts sought not only to secure their freedom but also, when possible, to reunite survivors with surviving relatives and Armenian communities.

Known as the "Mission of Salvation" or "Liberation Mission" these efforts encountered significant obstacles. Many Turkish, Kurdish, and Arab families refused to surrender Armenians in their custody, concealed their identities, or moved them to prevent their recovery.[268] Even when their whereabouts were known, locating and retrieving them could take months or years and often proved unsuccessful. The recovery of orphans and young girls**,** many of whom had been separated from their families during deportation or absorbed into households and institutions, became a central priority of the postwar Armenian rescue effort.

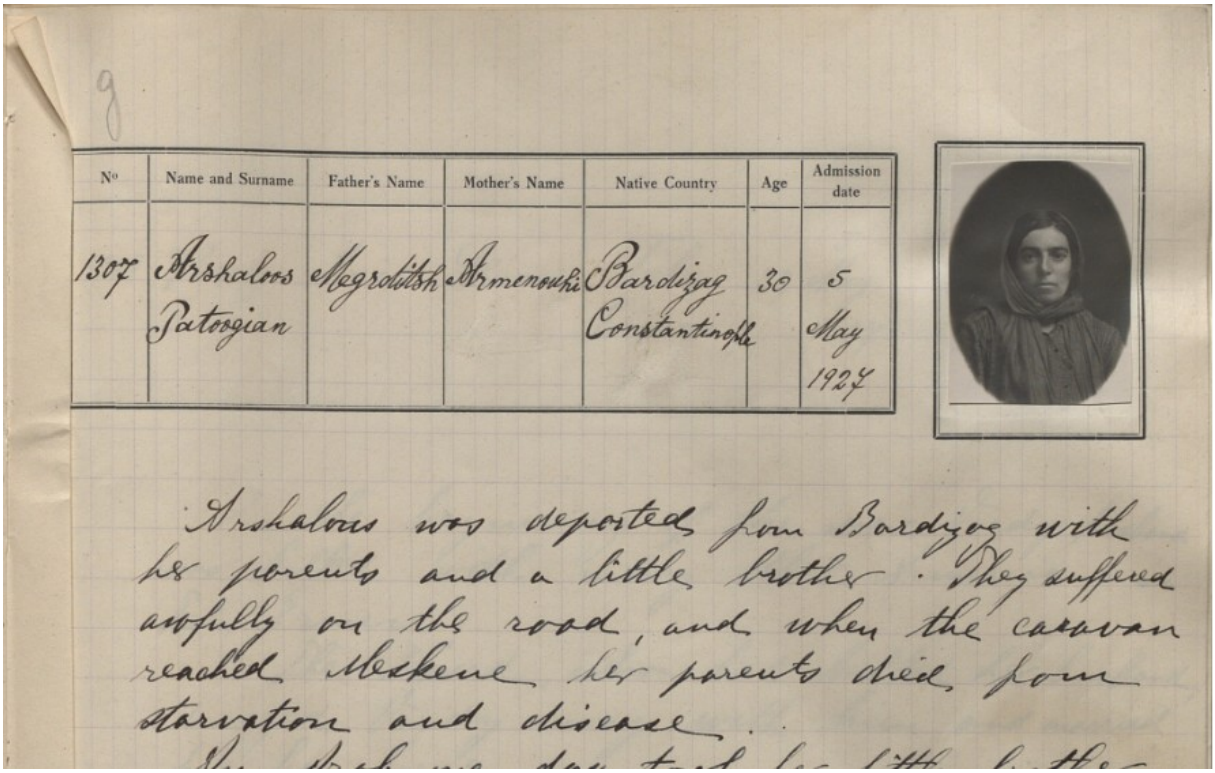
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and-youth-ottoman-empire-ottoman-empiremiddle-east/#easy-footnote-bottom-24-1088781 (Accessed date: 10/05/2026). Yavuz Selim Karakisla,

[267] Elysee Semerdjian, "The Liberation of non-Muslim Women and Children in Turkey," *Journal of the Society for Armenian Studies,* 202,

[268] Anna Aleksanyan, "Rescuing Armenian Women and Children after the Genocide: The Story of Ruben Heryan,"

The vorpahavak (ողբահավաք), literally "the gathering or reclamation of orphans", became one of the most important activities of the Armenian community in post-genocide Istanbul. Many Armenian children were repatriated to their families in this period.[269] There efforts formed part of broader national and international campaigns for the repatriation and rehabilitation of Armenian women and children who had been forcibly incorporated into Muslim households and institutions. The League of Nations closely followed these efforts in Aleppo, Mesopotamia, and Istanbul. At the same time, the Armenian patriarchate and local clergy organized their own recovery efforts: priests traveled through the provinces, visited orphanages and private households, identified Armenian children, and sought to facilitate their return.



| N° | Name and Surname | Father's Name | Mother's Name | Native Country | Age | Admission date |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1307 | Arshaloos Patoogian | Megrditch | Armenouhi | Bardizag Constantinople | 30 | 5 May 1924 |

Arshaloos was deported from Bardizag with her parents and a little brother. They suffered awfully on the road, and when the caravan reached Meskene her parents died from starvation and disease.

[269] Matthias Bjornlund, "'A Fate Worse Than Dying': Sexual Violence during the Armenian Genocide," in Dagmar Herzog (ed.), *Brutality and Desire: War and Sexuality in Europe's Twentieth Century*, London: Palgrave MacMillan, 2008, p.39.

This section follows the process of the institutionalized expropriation of Armenian children through the perspective of one Bardizag woman, Arshalous Patoogian. For Arshalous, the concepts developed above — recursive expropriation, coerced incorporation, hollow freedom — are not abstractions. but the concrete experiences of her life. Her story is not presented here as an uncomplicated tale of survival: her testimony was mediated by humanitarian institutions, and this section treats that mediation with methodological care rather than treating her as a straightforward witness to her own past. Born and raised in Bardizag, Arshalous was deported with her parents and younger brother in August 1915.[270] By the time the caravan reached Meskene, her parents had died of starvation and disease. Her brother was taken by an Arab man, and Arshalous, now orphaned, was seized into captivity.

What followed was not a single act of expropriation but a recursive one. She was sold and resold across households, each transfer resetting the relation of domination under new hands and conditions. After two years with her first captor, she was sold again; mistreated, she attempted to flee, but was recaptured at Deir ez-Zor by a man named Abou Djmeyd and compelled into a five-year forced marriage with one of his relatives. Each sale broke her social connections, changed who controlled her labor, destroyed accumulated local knowledge, and reset her vulnerability — converting her again into an object of exchange. The captive market she moved through was not incidental to her subjection but its sustaining mechanism: no site of captivity ever became familiar enough to be navigated toward escape.

***Marriage as hollow freedom***

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[270] C1603-499-1101-1200, No:1121, Armenian Orphanage Aleppo of Registry of Inmates. https://archives.ungeneva.org/challenge-inline?url=/armenian-orphanage-aleppo-registry-of-inmates-n-1-100 (accessed date: 09/04/2026).

The forced marriage crystallizes this dynamic with clarity. Her earlier captivities operated through direct, visible force; marriage instead appropriated one of the central institutions through which societies reproduce free subjects, subjecting her through a juridical form ordinarily associated with consent. Domination here did not operate outside the law but through it: she entered the household not as a subject requiring management, but as a wife — dependent, and simultaneously cast as a beneficiary of rescue. Unlike the postbellum U.S. order Hartman analyzes, where law named and disciplined the subject it claimed to free, Ottoman domestic institutions absorbed Arshalous without ever recognizing her captivity as such. What remained constant across her captivities, from informal seizure to juridically formalized marriage, was not their legal character but their structural function: the conversion of her person into a resource, her labor into unwaged service, her unfreedom into the condition of others' relative freedom.

Her case suggests an afterlife of genocide analogous to what Hartman calls slavery's afterlife: expropriation survived mass death by reorganizing itself within domestic institutions and kinship structures rather than disappearing with it. When escape finally came, it depended not on the restoration of any right but on external intervention; Armenian rescue agents in Syria facilitated her removal to the orphanage run by Karen Jeppe, from where relatives in Greece attempted to reclaim her. Arshalous's case confirms Fraser's insight that freedom is not a condition individuals simply possess but one distributed unevenly across a social field, underwritten by others' confiscation; it also demands an additional category beyond Hartman's: an expropriative power that operates not through the legal codification of bondage, nor through the disciplinary management of emancipation, but through the active concealment of domination within the ordinary institutions of domestic freedom itself.

Arshalous's testimony survives within the humanitarian archive created by the Danish relief worker Karen Jeppe, who established the Reception Home in Aleppo in 1921 to locate, identify, and where possible reunite Armenians absorbed into Muslim households.[271] On July 19, 1921, for example, an Armenian General Benevolent Union (UGAB) meeting in Paris received a report on the "deplorable situation" of Armenian refugees from Ismidt then in Constantinople and authorized £500 in relief for them. More broadly, the UGAB supported Armenian refugees and children in orphanages across the region, becoming part of the wider network of humanitarian institutions that sought to shelter, care for, and reconstruct Armenian communities fragmented by genocide, deportation, and displacement. [272]

At the Reception Home, this reconstruction took a particularly documentary form. Rescued Armenians received a medical exam and were entered into a register , each given a number, along with whatever remained of their name, their parents, birthplace, remembered relatives, and account of captivity, with a photograph attached, so they could be matched with relatives searching for them as far away as Europe or the United States. Arshalous's testimony is not an unmediated transcript of her past but an artifact of a rescue institution's documentary purpose: Jeppe's staff needed to establish who a survivor was and whether she could be identified and reunited, so her testimony functioned simultaneously as personal narrative and as an instrument of identification. This dual character of her testimony does not undermine its value as a historical artifact Rather, because the register is itself evidence of a historical reversal, the testimony highlights the conflicting subjectivity of women in Arshalous's position. That context does not diminish its value; it deepens it, because the register is itself evidence of a historical

[271] Matthias Bjørnlund & Elyse Semerdjian, "Karen Jeppe (1876-1935): "Mother of Armenians"," Houshamadyan, https://www.houshamadyan.org/mapottomanempire/vilayetaleppo/sandjak-of-aleppo/religion/missionaries.html (accessed date: 09/04/2026).

[272] Union Générale Arménienne de Bienfaisance, "Procès-verbal de la séance du Juillet 19/1921," p.14. Archives de l'UGAB, Bibliothèque Nubar de l'UGAB, Paris, France.

reversal. During the genocide, women like Arshalous were rendered administratively disposable: deported, separated from relatives, renamed, absorbed into households in ways that obscured who they had been. At the Reception Home, the same documentary techniques were redeployed to make an individual legible again. Read this way, Arshalous's case shows that recursive expropriation had an archival dimension as well as an economic one: where the household sought to incorporate her by suppressing her previous identity, the humanitarian archive sought to make that identity recoverable. The full institutional consequences of this contrast; a genocidal administration that made Armenians disappear from the record, set against a humanitarian one that worked to make them legible again are taken up further in Section VI.

Edita Gzoyan and Regina Galustyan examined 1,464 intake files of rescued Armenian women and children archived by the League of Nations. In their article, *Forced Marriages as a Tool of Genocide: The Armenian Case,* the authors reveal that 577 of these files document women; most of whom were subjected to sexual violence.[273] The interviews consistently point to a systematic pattern of genocide, including deportations, massacres, rape, enslavement, and forced marriage. Nearly half of the files concerning rescued women (238 in total) referenced coerced marriages to Muslim men—Turks, Kurds, Arabs, Chechens, and others. These marriages often involved girls as young as nine or ten, while some husbands were as old as sixty. In many cases, girls were initially adopted and later sold, married off, or married by their adoptive "guardians,". Some files even describe situations where mothers and daughters or sisters were forced to marry the same man. Others were taken into harems. Rouben Paul Adalian further details the enslavement of Armenian women and children, including the public auction of some Armenian girls.[274] Separated from their families, younger boys and girls were forcibly converted

[273] Edita Gzoyan and Regina Galustyan, "Forced Marriages as a Tool of Genocide: the Armenian Case," *The. International Journal of Human Rights*, Vol.25, no. 10, p.X

[274] Rouben Paul Adalian, *Century of Genocide: Critical Essays and Eyewitness Account*s, Second Edition, p.64.

to Islam and incorporated into Kurdish and Turkish households, where they were treated as servants or concubines. Adalian describes the auction as a commercial transaction in which purchasers acquired enslaved women for their households and harems, while referring to them as "masters." For many Armenian women, captivity continued long after the war: some remained in Muslim households, while others were rescued or escaped, sometimes leaving their children behind. The practice thus combined abduction, forced conversion, sexual and domestic exploitation, and the commodification of Armenian women through public sale.

**V. Deportation as Relocation, Not Termination**

As the deportations of August 13–15, 1915, emptied the homes, vineyards, and workshops of Bardizag, the primary phase of genocidal destruction and material confiscation appeared complete. The Armenian community's material world had been dismantled, and its surviving members were driven down the forced routes toward the Syrian desert. However, the political economy of the Armenian Genocide did not conclude with the physical seizure of property and the removal of bodies from the Marmara region. Deportation did not end the extraction of Armenian labor; it relocated it. As the survivors of Bardizag, Adapazarı, and other provincial towns crossed into the southern and eastern frontiers of the empire, they were subjected to a new phase of extraction, organized by the same administrative logic that had dismantled their communities at home, now redeployed in the transit camps, desert outposts, and state factories of Syria. Here, the Committee of Union and Progress state engineered a system that reorganized the "productive remnant" of the Armenian population: the surviving bodies and technical skills of Armenian artisans were conscripted into military provisioning, converting survivors into unfree, unwaged producers for the very state apparatus that had destroyed their families and communities.

### *A weaponized landscape*

To understand the specific vulnerability that enabled the extraction of unfree Armenian labor in Syria, it is worth first considering the environmental conditions of the deportation itself. As survivors left the Marmara region, they were thrust into an environment deliberately mobilized as an instrument of state violence. In his exploration of the environmental history of the genocide, Samuel Dolbee demonstrates how the state utilized the desert's climate and geography as an active tool of killing and concealment, maintaining a veneer of natural inevitability over what was a highly calculated state program. Drawing on Elyse Semerdjian's concept of the "weaponized environment," Dolbee argues that Ottoman authorities did not merely deport Armenians to the desert; they enlisted the desert itself; its extreme heat and endemic diseases, as nonhuman agents to perform the "dirty work" of mass execution while preserving state deniability.[275]

For the deportees of Bardizag, the journey through the Syrian desert consumed everything. Arshalous Patoogian's parents died of starvation and disease before their caravan even reached Meskene, leaving her orphaned and entirely defenseless. Her experience was not exceptional. Other survivors, such as Abraham Aghbasian of Tomarza, Kayseri, record the desperate measures required to sustain physical existence in this weaponized landscape: foraging for wild dandelions, drinking rainwater, and a constant search for sustenance in inhospitable terrain that frequently resulted in accidental poisoning and death;m underscoring the absolute material deprivation endured by deportees. [276] As Jason De León argues in his study of state-engineered border violence, nonhuman agents mask human responsibility, transforming political crimes into natural

[275] Samuel Dolbee, "The Desert at the End of Empire: An Environmental History of the Armenian Genocide," *Past & Present*, Volume 247, Issue 1, May 2020, p.198-202.

[276] Hasmik Grigoryan, "Food Procurement Methods During the Armenian Genocide as Expressions of "Unarmed Resistance: Children's Experiences," p.49.

tragedies.[277] The state-sponsored attack on Armenian communal solidarity and infrastructure, the intentional withholding of food and water, and the stripping of deportees' tools reduced Bardizag's Armenian population to something approaching Giorgio Agamben's "bare life" a condition in which individuals were reduced to biological existence while being deprived of the social, economic, and political structures that had previously made the existence viable.[278]

The experience of Bardizag deportees at Al-Bab illustrate this transformation with particular clarity. On New Year's Day 1916, Hovhannes Khacherian of Bardizag awoke to an Armenian woman singing *Aravod Louso* (Morning of the Light). [279]The hymn briefly evoked the world he had left behind, but Khacherian was now in a camp outside Al-Bab, where he and his compaions had arrived the previous night after being denied entry into the town. Thousands of Armenians crowded into makeshift tents, many already dead from starvation, disease, and violence. As Khatchig Mouradian shows, Al-Bab was a semi-porous site of exploitation rather than a sealed camp: locals entered trade, loot, and abduct women and children, often with the complicity of gendarmes. Food was so scarce that deportees consumed dead animals, while even those able to cook decaying scraps counted themselves fortunate. Suffering from typhus, Verjin Tingirian gave her daughter to an Arab man, believing she would not survive

By the time surviving remnants of Bardizag reached the transit camps of northern Syria, their survival was entirely contingent on the arbitrary decisions of state officials. This environmental dimension is best understood as evidence of how the state's violence was administered — the specific mechanism that stripped survivors of any remaining leverage — rather than as a separate theoretical pillar in its own right; what it produced, materially, was a population

[277] Jason De León
[278] Giorgio Agamben, *Homo Sacer: Sovereign Power and Bare Life.* Stanford University Press, 1998.

[279] Khatchig Mouradian, "Al-Bab: Gateway to the Desert During Armenian Genocide," *Agos' Agenda*, https://www.agos.com.tr/en/news/al-bab-gateway-to-the-desert-during-the-armenian-genocide-37271, 01/09/2017. (accessed date: 09/13/2026).

with nothing left to bargain with, and it was under exactly these conditions of vulnerability that Cemal Pasha, commander of the Ottoman Fourth Army and governor of Syria, implemented a distinct policy of labor mobilization functioning as a biopolitical labor regime.

***Artisan permits and Cemal Pasha's factories***

For the deportees of western Anatolia, the city of Aleppo and its surrounding environment represented the primary node of the genocidal administrative network. When the journalist Yervant Odian reached Sebil, a vast, barren plain lying east of Aleppo, he entered what survivors would later call "the gateway to hell". [280] Sebil functioned as a massive, open-air transit camp where thousands of deportees from Bardizag, Adapazarı, Edirne, and other regions were forced to wait under the open sky, suspended between the immediate threat of further deportation to the killing fields of Deir ez-Zor and the hunger and disease around them, constructing a temporary tent city. Odian's account of Sebil also exposes one of the most horrific dimensions of the deportation: the systematic trade and exploitation of Armenian children. He writes that he saw, for the first time, "the dreadful, heart-rending trade in children" in the camp. Arab, Turkish, and Jewish women traveled from Aleppo in carriages, going from tent to tent asking, "*Satılık çocuk var mı*?" (Are there children for sale?).[281] Odian recounts witnessing a mother lose her sanity only hours after selling her two children; others sank into a state of stupor, their gaze distant, sitting silently on the ground for hours. This testimony underscores the psychological toll of enforced dispossession and the commodification of Armenian children, who were treated as objects to be bought and sold.

[280] Yervant Odian, *Accursed Years: My Exile and Return from Der-Zor 1914-1919.* (London: Gomidas Institute, 2009), p.96.

[281] *Ibid*, p.99. Keith David Watenpaugh, "Are There Any Children for Sale?": Genocide and the Transfer of Armenian Children (1915-1922)," *Journal of Human Rights*,

In his memoirs, Karnig Bodourian, a teacher from Bardizag, confirms that many families from his home village were clustered in these tents, waiting for their fate to be decided. It was in this setting that Odian and his companions sought shelter in the tent of a Bardizag family. The head of this household revealed a crucial piece of administrative information: they had managed to arrange a transfer to Damascus, escaping the death marches to Deir ez-Zor, because Cemal Pasha had issued a decree allowing certain artisans to be separated from the main deportation convoys and sent to Damascus to work in government-run military factories.

According to this Bardizag survivor, the authorities were actively seeking tailors, shoemakers, metalworkers, carpenters, and weavers. In theory, this order provided a small window of survival for a fraction of the deported population. In practice, it established a highly coercive system of selection that reorganized Armenian productive capacity to serve the needs of the Ottoman military economy. As the Bardizag man explained to Odian, the factories established by Cemal Pasha in Aleppo and Damascus represented a new dimension of the colonial boomerang: the direct conversion of expropriated, dispossessed persons into unfree, military producers for the very state that had destroyed their communities. This labor mobilization was structurally continuous with the earlier moments of the boomerang that had dismantled Bardizag. The same state apparatus that had dispatched Ibrahim Bey to disarm the village's artisans, confiscate their tools, and deport them into the desert now found those same tailors, weavers, and carpenters useful again. This time, however, they were not independent economic agents operating within a prosperous Armenian town; they were captive, unfree laborers stripped of their tools, their mobility, and their legal protections, whose survival was entirely dependent on their continued productivity for the Ottoman military. The boomerang had not simply returned violence inward to

the heartland; it returned the dispossessed labor force inward to the state's military-industrial apparatus in the Arab provinces.

Under Cemal Pasha's military administration, the Fourth Army established six major army-run factories in Aleppo alone, alongside a similar workshop in Damascus. These factories functioned as highly extractive spaces where Armenian survivors; predominantly widows and young girls, were put to work producing clothing, tents, and bedding for the Ottoman troops. Reports from the American consul in Aleppo estimated that within just two months, these factories employed approximately 6,500 women, mostly widows, 3,000 young girls, and 650 men and older boys.[282] For this workforce of over ten thousand survivors, compensation was reduced to the barest minimum required to prevent starvation: a single loaf of bread and a bowl of soup each day. Yet under the constant threat of deportation to Deir ez-Zor, this minimal sustenance represented the difference between life and death.

This system is best read as a biopolitical labor regime. The artisan permits circulating through the transit camps of Meskene, Sebil, and Aleppo were not gestures of humanitarian mercy or inclusion; they were administrative instruments of selection. Through this permit system, the Ottoman state systematically sorted the surviving remnant of the Armenian population by its remaining extractable value. The state discarded those from whom nothing further could be taken, allowing the elderly, the sick, and the very young to perish in the desert, while conscripting those whose technical skills could be actively utilized to reduce the costs of social reproduction and military provisioning for the state. Armenian weavers who had once operated within the commercial networks of Bardizag were now forced to stitch Ottoman military uniforms to clothe

282 M.Talha Cicek, *War and State Formation in Syria: Cemal Pasha's Governorate during World War I, 1914–1917* (New York: Routledge, 2014), p.96. Umit Kurt, "Life and Death from Yemen to the Euphrates: An Evaluation on Syrian Governor Cemal Pasha," *Journal of Balkan and Near Eastern Studies,* Vol.27, No.6, 2025. pp.813-833.

the soldiers administering their dispossession. The unfree, uncompensated labor of these widows and artisans became the hidden precondition for the survival and relative freedom of the favored populations within the wartime national order. Survival under Cemal Pasha's system required complete submission to the machinery of one's own dispossession: a survivor's life was preserved only as long as their body could be converted into unfree military capital.

***Manipulating the categories of selection***

Confronted with this biopolitical labor regime, where the lack of an artisan permit meant certain death, Armenian survivors engaged in sophisticated tactics of collective deception, mimicry, and collective solidarity to subvert the state's categorization. Because the permit system established a rigid boundary between the "useful" artisan and the "disposable" deportee, survivors actively sought to blur these categories through bribery, forgery, and mutual aid. This resistance evidence matters because, left out, the chapter would risk making Armenians appear only as objects of state power; even within a highly coercive system, survivors actively manipulated the bureaucratic categories through which the state attempted to control them.

When Yervant Odian asked the Bardizag man in the Sebil camp whether all the families granted transfers to Damascus were truly skilled artisans, the man admitted frankly that many had secured their exemptions "by bribery or deception." Inside the crowded tents of Sebil, a remarkable scene unfolded: actual weavers and tailors from Bardizag spent their nights patiently teaching untrained neighbors, friends, and fellow deportees how to sew, stitch, and hold needles. Guided by their wives and skilled companions, these "artisans-in-making" hastily rehearsed the technical gestures of tailoring under the dim light of oil lamps, preparing to perform their newly claimed identities before the inspecting Ottoman officers the following morning. These fragile efforts at

improvisation were profound acts of resistance, subverting the state's attempts to measure and exploit only pre-existing human capacity.

Furthermore, a shadow market in identity documents and permits emerged within the camps. Because the state kept no centralized, biometric records of the shifting mass of deportees, permits and identity cards became highly valuable, liquid assets that could be detached from their original owners. The Bardizag men eventually helped Odian's group purchase two artisan permits belonging to deceased deportees for one Turkish lira each. Later, Odian himself acquired a *nüfus tezkiresi*, an official Ottoman identity card belonging to a recently deceased Armenian from Bardizag, paying half a lira to a camp intermediary. This document identified the cosmopolitan Constantinople journalist as "Asadour from Bardizag," a fifty-two-year-old builder, married with two children. Though entirely false, this paper provided Odian with the protective social legibility of a "useful" builder from the Marmara, shielding him from the immediate threat of deportation. This counter-market in papers reveals a striking paradox: while the Ottoman state mobilized its bureaucratic resources to register, classify, and dispossess the Armenian population, survivors co-opted these very same bureaucratic instruments, turning the names and papers of the dead into protective shields for the living.

***The contradiction of Cemal Pasha***

At the center of this extractive system stood the contradictory figure of Cemal Pasha, whose wartime policies in Syria have frequently been cited by apologists to project an image of moral authority and humanitarian exceptionalism. Publicly, Cemal Pasha declared that the Ottoman military authorities bore full responsibility for the "life, honor, and well-being" of all Armenians under their jurisdiction. He went so far as to order the public execution of a gendarmerie officer

accused of mistreating Armenian refugees, a performance designed to signal his commitment to justice and distance himself from the overt violence of Talat and Enver in Istanbul.

However, analyzing his policies through the lens of political economy reveals that this "protection" was deeply embedded within the broader machinery of genocidal displacement and control. The six army-run factories in Aleppo and the workshops of Damascus were not acts of altruism; they were highly organized, state-administered sweatshops designed to exploit a captive, desperate, and completely dispossessed population. By providing a minimal, sub-subsistence ration of a single loaf of bread and a bowl of soup, Cemal Pasha managed to keep a workforce of over ten thousand women and children alive while extracting their labor at zero wage cost to the Ottoman state. This was not a departure from the logic of primitive accumulation established in Bardizag but its ultimate institutionalization. The Fourth Army systematically capitalized on the destruction of Armenian independent economic life, converting the survival instinct of the "productive remnant" into a highly efficient military-industrial asset. As Nancy Fraser argues, the relative security of those within the recognized political community is materially underwritten by the violent, uncompensated confiscation of the racialized, excluded subject. In Cemal Pasha's Syria, this relationship was laid bare: the survival of the Ottoman military apparatus on the southern front was stitched together by the unfree, uncompensated labor of Armenian widows and children, whose independent social reproduction had first been thoroughly annihilated by the state.

**VI. Afterlives of Expropriation**

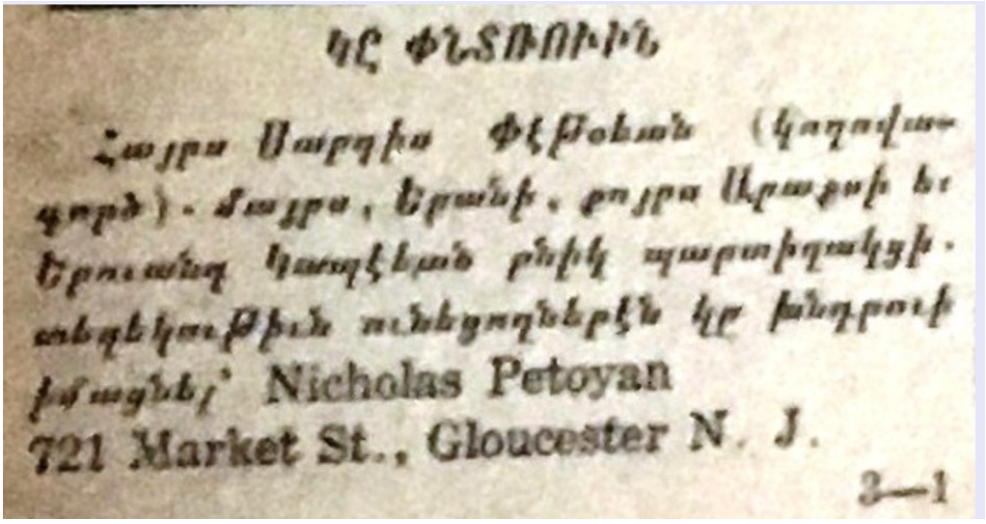
Expropriation in Bardizag did not end with deportation, and it did not end with the war. It persisted in the social destruction wrought by unresolved disappearance, in the postwar institutions that attempted, imperfectly, to reverse that destruction, and in the political and material continuities that carried individual perpetrators and confiscated property forward into the Turkish Republic.

Disappearance, as a category of violence, is not merely incidental to genocide; it constitutes a deliberate tactic designed to terrorize communities, eliminate leadership, and obstruct the possibility of mourning and justice. It describes how state apparatuses or irregular units, often at the state's encouragement, cause individuals to vanish; whether in official state spaces such as police stations and detention centers, or in remote locations beyond public visibility, such as deep forests or desolate interior regions; such that their fate remains denied and unacknowledged. When carried out with genocidal intent, disappearance becomes a constitutive act of genocide itself, and Bardizag demonstrates this at every stage, from the arrest of communal leaders in Section II to the fate of families deported into Syria in Section V.

This process continued long after the deportations themselves. Following the First World War and the collapse of the CUP regime, survivors scattered across the globe struggled to establish the fate of relatives who had disappeared during the genocide.[283] Armenian-language newspapers such as *Hairenik* became important spaces for these searches. The notices published there reveal the afterlife of disappearance: violence persisted through missing information, fragmented families, and the absence of graves or definitive accounts of death. Nicholas Petoyan's 1919 notice provides a particularly revealing example. A native of Bardizag and graduate of its American missionary high school, Petoyan had moved to Constantinople before being conscripted into the Ottoman army. During the August 1915 deportations, he witnessed the destruction of his community. Four years later, he placed a notice in Hairenik seeking information about his father Sarkis, mother Yerani, sister Araksi, and relative Yervant. [284]

283 On searching relatives in newspapers see: "Կը փնտռուին / Aranıyorlar," Interview with Zakarya Mildanoglu, Tugce Yilmaz, *Bianet*, 04/24/2024 https://bianet.org/haber/araniyorlar-294568#google_vignette (accessed date: 09/13/2026).

[284] Armenian Immigration Project, https://markarslan.org/ArmenianImmigrants/Public-ViewDetail-ArmenianImmigrants-Ads.php?submit=View&Staging=&SourcePage=Public-ViewSummary-ArmenianImmigrants-Combined-ByOriginPlace&SelectOriginCountry=Turkey&SelectOriginVSP=Izmit+



ԿԸ ՓՆՏՈՒՒՆ

Հայրս Մարգիս Փէթօեան (կողովա-
պոլի). Տայրս, Եղանէ, քոյրս Ափաքսի եւ
Երուանդ Կապէնեան բնիկ պարտիզակցի.
տեղեկութիւն ունեցողներէն կը խնդրուի
յայտնել՝ Nicholas Petoyan
721 Market St., Gloucester N. J.

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By publicly naming his relatives and identifying them with Bardizag, Petoyan was attempting to reconstruct a social world that deportation had violently dispersed. His search illustrates how disappearance outlasted physical violence: the problem was not simply that his relatives had been killed, but that their deaths had been rendered uncertain and inaccessible. The search notice became an attempt to produce knowledge where the state had produced silence. Petoyan's own life reflected the multiple social and political worlds that converged in the catastrophe of 1915. Educated at the American missionary high school in Bardizag, he acquired both French and English before graduating in 1913. He subsequently moved to Istanbul, where he found employment with the telephone company, placing him within the technological and administrative infrastructure of late Ottoman modernity. At the same time, he expressed sympathies for the Armenian Revolutionary Federation, whose political activities Ottoman authorities increasingly portrayed as evidence of Armenian disloyalty. Recalling the atmosphere before the genocide, Petoyan later remarked that “all the difficulties were blamed on Armenians”. His observation captures the normalization of anti-Armenian hostility that preceded deportation

%28mutesarifat%29&SelectOriginTown=Izmit+%28Baghtchedjik+%5BBardizag%5D%29&SelectSortOrder=ByName&Offset=0&argument1=Hairenik-1919-01-16-1-0 (accessed date: 09/04/2026).

and mass murder. Petoyan's later testimony established that his family, including his sister Mary, had been killed during the deportation, but this later certainty could not erase the years of uncertainty that preceded it.[285]

Bardizag therefore demonstrates disappearance as a process extending from the destruction of communal leadership to the fragmentation of families and the postwar struggle to recover their histories. By removing leaders, dispersing populations, and withholding information about the dead, the state attacked not only the physical survival of the community but also the relationships and forms of knowledge through which it organized, mourned, and remembered itself. Disappearance destroyed not only individuals but the social networks through which Armenian society reproduced memory, authority, kinship, and claims to property.

Karen Jeppe's Reception Home, discussed at length in Section IV, was one institutional response to exactly this problem. The contrast between the two processes is analytically striking: genocidal administration made Armenians disappear from the record, while humanitarian documentation worked to make survivors legible again. That contrast should not be mistaken for a claim that humanitarian archives simply restored the truth. As Section IV emphasized, the record Jeppe's institution produced was shaped by the categories and purposes of rescue, identification, and reunification, and testimony collected there was simultaneously personal narrative and administrative instrument. But the underlying contrast; disappearance engineered by the state,

[285] Petoyan, Nicholas. Interview 61873. Interview by Andrew Kzirian. Visual History Archive, Hovannisian Oral History Collection, June 07, 1972. Accessed September 04, 2026. https://vha-usc-edu.proxy.binghamton.edu/testimony/61873 Other testimonies from Bardizag: Dasnabedian, Satenig. Interview 56466. Interview by Maro Aghadjian. Visual History Archive, Hovannisian Oral History Collection, April 10, 1977. Accessed May 11, 2025. https://vha-usc-edu.proxy.binghamton.edu/testimony/56466 Sayan, Hasmig. Interview 56062. Interview by Alice Chalian. Visual History Archive, Hovannisian Oral History Collection, April 16, 1977. Accessed May 11, 2025. https://vha-usc-edu.proxy.binghamton.edu/testimony/56062 Spandarian, Satenik. Interview 56002. Interview by Rubina Peroomian. Visual History Archive, Hovannisian Oral History Collection, May 28, 1980.

legibility reconstructed by a private relief effort, remains one of the clearest afterlives of the expropriation this chapter traces.

**Conclusion:** The microhistory of Bardizag demonstrates that the Armenian Genocide was not solely a project of physical annihilation, but also a coordinated process of violent economic reorganization and capital transfer. By tracing the trajectory of this prosperous Marmara community, this chapter has proposed a critical revision of the standard formulation of the colonial boomerang. Rather than conceptualizing imperial violence as a force that merely travels from a distant geographical frontier back to the metropole, the Ottoman case reveals a more insidious domestic trajectory: the state actively turned frontier-style techniques of demographic engineering, irregular warfare, and selective dispossession inward, rendering a higly integrated and proximate population peripheral within the very heartland of the empire. Through the "three moments" of this boomerang forged on frontiers, carried by specialized perpetrators such as Ibrahim Bey, and applied to the interior region of the Marmara ; the Ottoman state and local forces gradually dismantled the defensive, social, political, and economic infrastructures of Armenian life, clearing the ground for mass plunder.

By analyzing this destruction through the lens of primitive accumulation, in this chapter, I argued that the extermination of the Armenians and confiscation of their material world including the expropriation of bodies and labor force, were structurally inseparable. The systematic confiscation of Armenian lands, vineyards, homes, and wealth was not an incidental byproduct of wartime panic, but a foundational, state-led intervention designed to underwrite the emerging Turkish national economy and consolidate a loyal national bourgeoise. In the streets of Bardizag, this process materialized first through "staged disarmament" and administrative extortion which rendered the community entirely defenseless, and culminated in a "coerced marketplace" in which

Ottoman state official and neighboring populations liquidated Armenian assets under conditions of extreme duress. Crucially, this primitive accumulation was not limited to land and property; it extended directly to human capacities, bodies, and labor. The political economy of the genocide relied on heavily segmented and gendered logic of extraction. For the male "productive remnant," survival was conditioned on unfree, conscripted labor- first in grueling auxiliary labor battalions and later as captive artisans stitching military uniforms in Cemal Pasha's factories in Aleppo and Damascus. For women and children, survival was predicated on assimilation into muslim households, the renunciation of their Armenian identity, and acceptance of conditions of forced domestic, household, and sexual labor.

The case of Bardizag thus illustrates in concrete terms how violence, legality, and economy converged to produce both material profit and political legitimacy. These dynamic challenges conventional distinctions between destruction and production, showing that the annihilation of a people was inseparable from the creation of a new social order. The interplay between violence and labor is crucial to understanding this period. The very process of mass deportation, through dispossession, starvation, and terror, transformed Armenians into a source of cheap and compliant labor. Violence functioned not only as an instrument of destruction but also as a mechanism of control, stripping individuals of property, mobility, and bargaining power. Under Cemal Pasha's administration in Syria, this violence was rechanneled into a system of coerced productivity: artisans, workers, and even widows were rendered dependent on military, provisioning and subject to the state's authority through labor. In this sense, the factories and road projects that Cemal oversaw in Aleppo and Damascus were exploitative spaces where survival was possible only through submission to a regime that had first annihilated the means of independent existence. The colonial boomerang provided the operational machinery for the

systemic expropriation of gendered labor by turning the techniques of frontier counterinsurgency inward against the Armenian heartland. The state-sponsored breakdown of community defense created the specific vulnerability required for what the chapter identifies as "recursive expropriation," exemplified by the experience of Arshalous, who was repeatedly seized and resold as a confiscated resource across multiple households. The colonial logic of treating subjects as "spoils of war" was thus institutionalized within the domestic sphere through the concept of "hollow freedom" where juridical forms like marriage were repurposed as instruments of possession to absorb Armenian labor into Muslim-Turkish household. Ultimately, the boomerang did not eliminate populations; it converted the expropriated bodies and "unwaged service" of women into the "hidden precondition" for the relative freedom and social reproduction of the favored populations within the emerging national economy. Through "recursive expropriation" women were repeatedly seized and sold across households, their bodies and labors treated as "spoils of war". The sources from Bardizag remind us that expropriation was not confined to property alone; it extended to bodies, in, and the very capacity to sustain life. Attending these intertwined histories of gender, labor, and dispossession allows us to grasp how capitalism, nationalism, and state violence operated together to reshape both space and society in the early twentieth century.

## Conclusion

The history of Bardizag demonstrates that Ottoman economic life depended upon forms of labor and ecological extraction that remain obscured when analysis begins and ends with the state, markets, or monetary institutions themselves. Charcoal production for the Imperial Mint, the appropriation of household labor, and the mobilization of rural resources reveal money-making as a material and social process grounded in forests, households, seasonal labor, and relations of coercion. Armenian peasants were not simply passive recipients of these demands: they negotiated obligations, sustained household economies, and pursued forms of autonomy within structures that continually sought to appropriate their labor and resources. Expropriation was therefore not a single act but an uneven process that continually reorganized relations among labor, property, nature, and the state.

The Armenian Genocide constituted a more profound rupture in these relations. For Bardizag Armenians, dispossession increasingly involved not only labor and property but the territorial and social foundations of communal life. Some survivors returned to Bardizag and sought to reclaim their homes, property, and livelihoods while rebuilding communal institutions in an increasingly hostile political environment. The postwar period, however, did not produce a straightforward restoration. After the Armistice of Mudros, some survivors sought refuge in Syria, while others attempted to return to their former homes. Those who returned encountered renewed insecurity and violence during the War of Independence, and many were displaced again. The result was a process of repeated displacement in which the possibility of return remained provisional rather than constituting a restoration of pre-1915 communal life.

Humanitarian institutions became central to this post-genocide reconstruction. Near East Relief and the American Woman's Hospital established orphanages and provided food, medical

assistance, and protection to survivors across Anatolia. By 1922, approximately 129,000 refugees were being housed in Near East Relief orphanages in different parts of Anatolia, demonstrating the scale of the population requiring institutional assistance.[1] American nurses and relief workers also assisted survivors and Greek populations in the İzmit region who faced displacement and persecution. For Armenians who remained in İzmit, relief institutions could provide not only shelter and care but also forms of economic reorganization. Survivors were employed in the basket-making house, where they also performed maintenance work. Their labor thus became part of the process through which post-genocide institutions attempted to sustain displaced populations and reconstruct communal life. Yet this reconstruction remained materially constrained: the same survivors whose labor had once sustained households and local production were now rebuilding lives within institutions created by displacement and humanitarian crisis. This postwar history complicates any linear transition from genocide to diaspora. Displacement did not occur in a single movement from Bardizag to a permanent destination. Survivors moved between Bardizag, Syria, Anatolian relief institutions, and eventually communities across the Middle East, Europe, and the United States. Some attempted to return; others remained in exile; still others were displaced more than once. Diasporization therefore emerged through an uneven process of attempted return, incomplete reconstruction, renewed displacement, and resettlement. Bardizag consequently acquired a new historical position: for many of its former inhabitants, it became a place of origin and memory rather than the primary location of everyday communal life.

The geographical extent of this transformation is visible in Boris Adjemian's study of the Armenian cemetery in Gulele, Addis Ababa.[286] By cross-referencing the dates and places of birth

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[286] Boris Adjemian, "Une visite au cimetière arménien d'Addis Abeba. Éléments pour la connaissance d'une diaspora et de ses pratiques funéraires en Éthiopie", *Afriques*[Online], 03 | 2011, Online since 17 January 2012,

recorded on tombstones, Adjemian identifies 365 individuals of Armenian origin born in 48 different places, demonstrating the remarkable geographic fragmentation of the communities from which Ethiopian Armenians emerged. Armenians from western Anatolian cities and towns —including Constantinople, Smyrna, Arslanbeg, Adapazarı, Bursa, Eskisehir, Geyve, Rodosto, and **Bardizag**—constituted a significant portion of those buried in Gulele. Bardizag thus appears not as an isolated site of displacement but within a much wider geography of Armenian dispersal.

A similar trajectory can be traced in the life of **Ardases Der Kirkorian (1890–1944)**, born in Bardizag and displaced to Syria following the genocide. He later arrived in Romania as a teacher, tracing a route from **Bardizag to Syria and then Romania** that illustrates how survivors rebuilt their lives across successive sites of displacement.[2] His trajectory also demonstrates that diasporization was not necessarily a single movement from the Ottoman Empire to a permanent destination. For many survivors, displacement produced successive migrations through different regions, with professional and communal roles reconstructed along the way**.Simion Tavitian, "Armeni din Romania: volumul III" (Ex Ponto: Constanta, 2008) P.368-369**

Individual records also make this transformation visible at the level of diaspora. Garabed Hagop Berberyan, born in Bardizag on April 6, 1880, appears in a U.S. World War II "Old Man's Draft" registration card dated April 27, 1942**.** [287] The form records his birthplace as "Bardezag, Ismidt city, Turkey," while listing his residence in Utica, New York, and mailing address in Salt Lake City, Utah. The record places Bardizag within a new geography of

connection on 06 October 2026. URL: http://journals.openedition.org/afriques/938; DOI: https://doi.org/10.4000/afriques.938 p. 9.

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Armenian life: a place of birth remembered across a diaspora increasingly dispersed across the United States. Although the card does not establish when or under what circumstances Berberyan migrated, it preserves the connection between a specific Armenian locality and the dispersed lives that followed its destruction.

This transformation from a community rooted in Bardizag to a population dispersed across the diaspora can also be traced through the intertwined trajectories of Gomidas Vartabed and Zabelle Panosian. In 1912, Gomidas visited Bardizag and collected Armenian songs, encountering its musical traditions within the village itself. Panosian, born Takouhi Der Mesrobian in Bardizag in 1891, had already emigrated to the United States in 1907. During the following decade, she became a prominent Armenian-American soprano and recorded Armenian songs for Columbia Records. After traveling to Europe and Egypt, she encountered Gomidas in Paris in the early 1920s and later published an account of their meeting.

The significance of their encounter lies in the historical distance between these two moments. Gomidas encountered Bardizag in 1912 as a living Armenian community; Panosian encountered Gomidas in Paris after that community had been violently disrupted and dispersed. Their meeting provides a concrete way to trace the process of diasporization. Panosian did not simply represent an individual migrant trajectory: as a woman born in Bardizag who established her life in the United States, her presence in Paris embodied the widening geography of Armenian life beyond the village. Gomidas, meanwhile, carried into the post-Genocide diaspora the memory of the Armenian cultural world he had encountered in Bardizag.

This connection brings the dissertation's central themes into a longer historical frame. Earlier chapters examined how imperial institutions reached into Bardizag's forests, households, and systems of rural production to appropriate labor and resources. After 1915, the rupture was

no longer confined to the organization of production. For many Armenians, displacement severed the relationship between community and territory itself. Diasporization thus extended the history of expropriation into a new register: from the appropriation of labor and resources within a landscape to the displacement of people from that landscape.

The movement from Bardizag to diaspora therefore forms the dissertation's final temporal arc. Gomidas's visit to Bardizag in 1912 and his later encounter with Panosian in Paris mark two points on either side of this rupture. Some Armenians returned to the village; many others established lives elsewhere. Together with the dispersed birthplaces documented by Adjemian, these trajectories reveal how Bardizag moved from an Ottoman rural community embedded in a particular ecological and economic landscape toward a dispersed population whose relationship to that landscape was increasingly mediated by displacement and memory.

Bardizag's history thus connects the material foundations of Ottoman political economy to the twentieth-century reorganization of Armenian life. The charcoal that moved from its forests into the Imperial Mint belonged to an economy organized around imperial extraction. The people who later moved from Bardizag into the diaspora inhabited a different historical geography, shaped by genocide, displacement, partial return, and resettlement. Gomidas's journey to Bardizag in 1912 and Panosian's encounter with him in Paris a decade later mark this transformation with unusual clarity: one begins with a community situated in its landscape; the other with that community dispersed across the world.

Claudio Katz's critique of world-systems analysis provides a final theoretical dimension to this dissertation. Katz argues that Wallerstein's framework under-theorizes the state as a political form of capitalist social relations and domination. A society's position within a world economy does not explain how labor and resources are actually organized and appropriated.

Following Katz and Moishe Postone's emphasis on the historically specific character of capitalist social relations, I treat the state not as external to accumulation but as one of the institutional forms through which those relations are politically organized.

Bardizag makes this visible. **Chapter Two** shows that the community's incorporation into imperial accumulation was mediated through concrete state institutions: forest regulations, taxation, labor obligations, and the Imperial Mint organized Armenian household labor and connected Bardizag's forests to monetary production. **Chapter Three** shows that changing forms of semi-proletarianization were likewise shaped by fiscal demands, commercialization, and state economic policies that reorganized household reproduction and increased dependence on markets and wage labor. **Chapter Four** demonstrates that these relations were contested through cooperatives, communal banks, mutual-aid organizations, and revolutionary networks that sought to protect collective resources and reorganize economic life. **Chapter Five** reveals the most violent extension of this political power: the destruction of Armenian households, property, and institutions through deportation and confiscation transformed earlier forms of extraction into large-scale expropriation.

Taken together, these chapters show that Bardizag cannot be understood simply through its position within a world-system. The question is how that position was politically produced. The Ottoman state did not merely mediate between a global economy and a peripheral community; its institutions actively organized the relations through which Armenian labor, land, forests, and eventually property were incorporated into circuits of accumulation. Yet this process was never purely top-down. Households, amiras, communal institutions, and revolutionary organizations mediated and contested state power. Bardizag therefore demonstrates how accumulation was politically constituted through the interaction of imperial institutions and

social actors on the ground—and how, after genocide, the expropriation of a community's material resources expanded into the dispersal of the community itself.

The theoretical problem of continuity and rupture becomes particularly important when considering the history of Bardizag after 1915. Orhan Gazi Ertekin's recent critique of the use of "apartheid" in the Turkish context offers a useful methodological point of departure. Ertekin's discussion of Jim Crow, drawing on Michelle Alexander's formulation of the "New Jim Crow," emphasizes that the formal abolition of a historical regime does not necessarily dissolve the social relations and inequalities that regime produced. Yet Ertekin simultaneously insists on preserving the historical and institutional specificity of the cases being compared. Jim Crow, South African apartheid, and the Turkish case may be brought into the same analytical conversation, but they cannot simply be treated as interchangeable manifestations of a single historical form. The value of comparison lies precisely in identifying relations of persistence and transformation without erasing the differences through which those relations were historically constituted.

This distinction is central to the argument of this dissertation. I have traced expropriation across different historical moments not because these moments constituted one continuous regime, but because expropriation provides a way of following how relations of labor, property, nature, mobility, and belonging were transformed over time. In this sense, expropriation is not a static condition but a recursive process: earlier forms of dispossession could establish the material and institutional conditions through which later forms became possible, even as the mechanisms, scale, and political meaning of expropriation changed. The genocide therefore cannot be understood simply as the culmination of the expropriative processes examined in the

preceding chapters. It transformed those processes and produced a fundamentally different historical configuration.

This is what I mean by the historical universe created by genocide. The destruction and deportation of Bardizag's Armenians did not merely remove a population from an existing social order. They transformed the conditions under which property could be possessed, labor could be organized, families and institutions could reproduce themselves, and belonging could be claimed. The subsequent appropriation of property, reorganization of space, disruption of labor, and foreclosure of return were not simply aftereffects of an event that had already ended. They constituted the social and material conditions of a new historical world. The genocide thus produced a rupture whose consequences could not be contained within 1915 itself.

At the same time, recognizing this rupture does not require severing the genocide from the histories that preceded it. The forms of extraction, labor discipline, ecological appropriation, political differentiation, and social hierarchy examined in this dissertation did not mechanically produce genocide, but they constituted historically specific relations through which Armenian life was organized and made vulnerable to subsequent forms of dispossession. The analytical task is therefore to hold continuity and rupture together: to ask how one historical configuration made another possible without treating the two as the same.

Ertekin's criticism of comparative uses of apartheid is useful here precisely because it identifies the danger on both sides. Historical specificity can be lost when distinct moments are placed under a single conceptual label; but historical comparison becomes equally impoverished if each case is treated as entirely self-contained. The methodological position of this dissertation lies between these extremes. I read different historical moments together not to establish equivalence, but to make transformation visible. The question is not whether pre-1915

expropriation, genocide, and post-genocide dispossession were the same process. They were not. The question is how their relations to one another can be reconstructed historically: where earlier forms persisted, where they were transformed, and where 1915 produced a rupture that generated an entirely new set of relations.

In this sense, comparison is not external to the history of Bardizag; it is part of the method through which its specificity becomes legible. Other histories of segregation, exclusion, dispossession, and racialized governance can illuminate mechanisms that might otherwise remain obscured, but they should not supply ready-made identities for the Armenian case. The task of theory is therefore not to make Bardizag resemble another history. It is to allow the history of Bardizag to place pressure on the categories through which we understand expropriation, coercion, dispossession, and historical continuity.

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